

MONTHLY CURRENT AFFAIRS MAGAZINE

JANUARY 2026



- Detailed release for all exams
- Static GK points included
- Category-wise Compilation
- Live Table of Content

Contents

Important Days & themes	4
Appointments(IN TABLE)	10
Books	17
Obituaries.....	18
Awards	20
National	20
State.....	37
Ladakh	37
Jammu & Kashmir.....	37
Punjab.....	38
Delhi.....	39
Uttar Pradesh.....	40
Madhya Pradesh.....	42
Bihar	44
Jharkhand	44
Chhattisgarh	44
Odisha.....	45
Mizoram	50
Nagaland.....	50
Rajasthan	51
Gujarat.....	52
MAHARASHTRA	54
Goa	55
Telangana	56
Andhra Pradesh	57
Karnataka.....	59
Tamil Nadu.....	60
Kerala.....	61
Himachal Pradesh	62
Uttarakhand.....	63
Delhi.....	63
Haryana	64
Defence	64
Science &tech	71
Environment.....	78
National	87
National/ international festivals.....	105
Banking	107

International.....	110
Sports.....	121
Index.....	126

Important Days & themes

Date	Day	Remark
3rd January	International Mind-Body Wellness Day	
3 rd January	Mahayana New Year	
4 th January	World Braille Day	
5 th January	National Bird Day	THEME : "Every Bird Counts – Your Observations Matter!"
6 th January	World Day of War Orphans	
6 th January	National Siddha Day	The celebrations, themed "Siddha for Global Health,"
8 th January	Earth's Rotations Day	
9 th January	NRI (Non-Resident Indian) Day or Pravasi Bharatiya Divas	
10 th January	World Hindi Day	
11th January	National Human Trafficking Awareness Day	
12th January	National Youth Day	
14th January	Defence Forces Veterans' Day	
15th January	Indian Army Day	
15TH January	Thiruvalluvar Day	
16th January-	National Startup Day	
16TH January	National Defence Academy's Raising Day	
16th January	Lokpal of India Foundation Day	
19th January	National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) Day	
19th January	Kokborok Day	
19th January	Martin Luther King Jr Day	
20th January	Penguin Awareness Day	
23rd January	Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose Jayanti (Prakaram Diwas)	
24th January	International Day of Education	The theme 2026 : The power of youth in co-creating education
24th January	National Girl Child Day	
25th January	National Voters' Day	The theme 2026 is "My India, My Vote" tagline - Citizen at the Heart of Indian Democracy.
25th January	National Tourism Day	
26th January	77th Republic Day	
26th January	International Customs Day	Theme: "Customs Protecting Society through Vigilance and Commitment."
26th January	International Day of Clean Energy	

27th January	National Geographic Day	
27th January	International Day of Commemoration in Memory of the Victims of the Holocaust	
28th January	International Data Privacy Day	Theme - "Privacy by Design: Building Digital Trust,"
28th January	International Day of Peaceful Coexistence	THEME: Commitment to Peaceful Coexistence and a Safe, Inclusive World
29th January	Indian Newspaper Day	
30th January	Martyrs Day or Shaheed Diwas	
30th January	National Leprosy Day	
31st January	International Zebra Day	

WITH STATIC

3 January- Mahayana New Year

- **Mahayana New Year starts on the first full moon day in January.** Celebrated in Mahayana countries like China, Korea, Japan, Taiwan and Vietnam.
- Mahayana is primarily practiced in Northeast Asia.
- **The Vardhana Dynasty Harshavardhana patronized Mahayana.**



4th January World Braille Day

- World Braille Day, celebrated since 2019, is observed to raise awareness of the importance of Braille as a means of communication in the full realization of the human rights for blind and partially sighted people.
- **Braille (named after its inventor in 19th century France, Louis Braille) is not a language but a code that allows multiple languages to be read and written in tactile form.**
- The Braille script was introduced in India in 1887. **But, in 1951, a single national standard, Bharati Braille, was adopted with the common codes for Indian languages.**



January 5 National Bird Day

- **First established in 2002 by the Avian Welfare Coalition**
- **THEME : "Every Bird Counts – Your Observations Matter!"**

6 January - World Day of War Orphans

Ministry of Ayush to inaugurate 9th Siddha Day celebrations in Chennai ; National Siddha Day to be observed on January 6

- The Ministry of Ayush, Government of India, **in association with its institutions-the National Institute of Siddha (NIS) and the Central Council for Research in Siddha (CCRS) along with the Directorate of Indian Medicine and Homoeopathy, Government of Tamil Nadu,** will celebrate the 9th Siddha Day on 6 January 2026 at Kalaivanar Arangam, Chennai.
- Siddha Day annually observed on 6 January.
- **The celebrations, themed "Siddha for Global Health,"** commemorate the birth anniversary of Sage Agathiyar, revered as the father of Siddha medicine...
- It is a **traditional system of healing** that originated in South India and is considered to be one of India's oldest systems of medicine.
- **Literary evidences of the Sangam Era state** the origin of this system to around 10,000 BC.



8 January- Earth's Rotations Day

- **Today marks the anniversary of French physicist Leon Foucault's 1851 proof that the Earth revolves on its axis.**

The United Nations has declared 2026 as the International Year for Rangelands and Pastoralists

- The United Nations has declared 2026 as the International Year for Rangelands and Pastoralists, renewing global attention on grasslands.
- Recent climate negotiations continue to prioritise forests, prompting debate on why grasslands must be integrated into national climate plans and NDCs.



9 January – NRI (Non-Resident Indian) Day or Pravasi Bharatiya Divas

- This significant event, celebrated once every two years, honoured the contributions of the Indian diaspora to their homeland.
- **January 9 was chosen as the day to celebrate PBD as it was on this day, in 1915, that Mahatma Gandhi had returned to India from South Africa.**
- **PBD conventions were being held every year since 2003.**
- Since 2015, its format has been revised.



Pravasi Bharatiya Samman Award (PBSA):

- The award, given out as part of the Pravasi Bharatiya programme, is the highest honour conferred on a Non-Resident Indian (NRI), Person of Indian Origin (PIO); or an organisation or institution established and run by them.
- **The award is to commemorate the contribution of the Indian diaspora to create a better understanding of India abroad, support India's causes and work for the welfare of the local Indian community.**

10 January - World Hindi Day

- **World Hindi Day was created to mark the occasion when Hindi was first spoken at the UNGA in 1949.**
- **National Hindi Day is celebrated on 14 September as a day that marked the adoption of Hindi as the official language of India in 1949.**
- The day was first commemorated in 2006 as the anniversary of the first world Hindi Conference held in 1975 in Nagpur, India.

19 January- Kokborok Day

- Kokborok Day is celebrated on January 19 annually. It holds great importance for the indigenous Tripuri people, especially in Tripura, India.
- The day honors the cultural heritage, history, and linguistic contributions of the Kokborok language. **Kokborok is the mother tongue of the Tripuri community.**
- Kokborok is the native language of the Borok (Tripuri) people, belonging to the Tibeto-Burmese linguistic family.
- **State Found:** Predominantly spoken in Tripura, it is also used in parts of Assam, Mizoram.

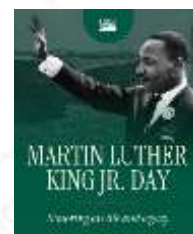


History of Language:

- Officially recognized as a state language of Tripura on January 19, 1979.
- **Declared an official language of the Tripura Tribal Areas Autonomous District Council (TTAADC) on April 20, 1999.**
- Historically used Bengali script, but recent movements advocate for the Roman script for better accessibility.

19 January- Martin Luther King Jr Day

- In the United States, Martin Luther King, Jr., Day is observed annually on the third Monday in January.
- **The day commemorates the life and work of Dr. King, who was a Baptist minister and prominent leader in the American civil rights movement.**



Lokpal of India observed its Foundation Day

- Lokpal of India observed its **Foundation Day on 16 January 2026**, marking the day the institution legally came into force in 2014.
- Lokpal is a statutory, independent anti-corruption ombudsman at the Union level.
- Designed as a sui generis institution to inquire into and investigate allegations of corruption against specified public functionaries, including those at the highest political and bureaucratic levels.
- **Established in:** Created under the Lokpal and Lokayuktas Act, 2013.

Historical evolution:

- The idea of an ombudsman-type body was first proposed in 1963.
- The First Administrative Reforms Commission (1966) recommended a two-tier mechanism—**Lokpal at the Centre and Lokayuktas in States**.
- The Act was finally passed in December 2013 and operationalised in January 2014.

Composition and members:

- Consists of a Chairperson and up to eight Members.
- Includes an equal balance of Judicial Members and Non-Judicial Members.
- Appointed by the President of India on the recommendation of a statutory Selection Committee.
- Tenure is five years or up to the age of 70, whichever is earlier.

20 January- Penguin Awareness Day

- Every year on January 20, Penguin Awareness Day is observed.
- Five species of penguin are found in Antarctica and it's no surprise that this massive frozen landmass has earned the nickname of 'the Land of the Penguin'.
- Emperor Penguin is the largest of all the different kinds of penguin species.

**National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) Day**

- National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) was raised on 19th January 2006 after the enactment of Disaster Management Act, 2005.
- **Since its raising, it has grown from initial 8 Battalions to 16 Battalions today.**
- It is a fund managed by the Central Government to meet the expenses for emergency response, relief, and rehabilitation due to any threatening disaster situation or disaster.

**23 January - Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose Jayanti (Prakaram Diwas)**

- Subhas Chandra Bose Jayanti, also known as Parakram Diwas or the Day of Valour, is observed annually in India to honour one of India's esteemed freedom fighters, Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose.
- In 2021, the government announced that 23rd January will be celebrated as 'Parakram Diwas.'
- **Subhas Chandra Bose, born on January 23, 1897, in Cuttack, Orissa, was a nationalist leader who joined the nationalist movement led by Mahatma Gandhi and the Indian National Congress in 1921.**
- He actively participated in the Salt Satyagraha in 1930.
- After returning from England, he became Congress president in 1938.
- **In 1934, Subhas Chandra Bose arrived in Japanese-controlled Singapore and issued his iconic "Delhi Chalo" call.**
- On October 21, 1943, he proclaimed the formation of the Azad Hind Government and the Indian National Army (INA)
- In 1939, he founded the Forward Bloc to unite all anti-British forces in India.
- **During World War II, Bose fled India and sought alliances in the Soviet Union, Germany, and Japan to combat British rule.**

**24 January - International Day of Education**

- Since 2018, the day has been authored by 59 member states.



- The resolution for the same was passed in the UN General Assembly on December 3, 2018.
- **The first International Day of Education was observed on January 24, 2019.**
- Meanwhile, India celebrates its National Education Day celebrated on November 11 to mark the birth anniversary of India's first Education Minister Maulana Abul Kalam Azad.
- **The theme 2026 : The power of youth in co-creating education**

24 January- National Girl Child Day

- National Girl Child Day is observed on 24 January every year, with an aim to spread awareness about the challenges faced by girls in Indian Society.
- National Girl Child Day was implemented for the first time by the Ministry of Women and Child Development in 2008
- **Launch of Beti Bachao Beti Padhao by the Prime Minister on 22 January 2015.**
- **Objective:** Address the declining Child Sex Ratio (CSR) and promote women's empowerment.



77th Republic Day

- This year marks **77 years since our Constitution came into effect** on January 26, 1950 (adopted on November 26, 1949).
- **The Indian National Congress, on 19 December 1929, passed the historic 'Purna Swaraj' – (total independence) resolution – at its Lahore session.**
- **A public declaration was made on 26 January 1930 – a day which the Congress Party urged Indians to celebrate as 'Independence Day'.**
- **First Republic Day Celebration: Parade** took place at **Irwin Stadium** (now Major Dhyan Chand National Stadium) in **New Delhi**.
- **President of India unfurls the National Flag** at Republic Day Parade.



24 January- National Girl Child Day

- National Girl Child Day is observed on 24 January every year, with an aim to spread awareness about the challenges faced by girls in Indian Society.
- National Girl Child Day was implemented for the first time by the Ministry of Women and Child Development in 2008
- **Launch of Beti Bachao Beti Padhao by the Prime Minister on 22 January 2015.**
- **Objective:** Address the declining Child Sex Ratio (CSR) and promote women's empowerment.

Difference Between Flag Unfurling and Flag Hoisting

- **Hoisting** refers to **raising the flag from a lower position to the top of a pole**. This act symbolises freedom and self-governance, and it is primarily associated with **Independence Day**, observed on **August 15**. On this day, the **Prime Minister hoists the flag at the Red Fort in Delhi**.
- **Unfurling**, on the other hand, involves **unveiling a flag that is already secured at the top of the pole**. The **President of India** performs this act during **Republic Day** celebrations, symbolising a commitment to the principles enshrined in the Constitution.
- **Union Ministry of Defence organises and manages** the Republic Day celebration.
- **Since 2022**, the Republic Day celebration **starts on 23rd January** and continues **till 30th January**.
- **23rd January** is observed in the country as the **Parakram Diwas** (birth anniversary of **Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose**)
- The **Beating Retreat ceremony** is held on **29th January** at the **Vijay Chowk in New Delhi** – it features a musical performance by the bands of the Indian Armed Forces, Central Armed Police Force (CAPF), and the Delhi Police.
- The Beating Retreat ceremony marks the end of the Republic Day parade and it is **presided over by the President of India**.
- During the Beating Retreat ceremony, the Armed Forces ask the permission of the President to go back to their barracks.
- The **President** is the **Supreme Commander of the Indian Armed Forces**.



- **Martyr's Day**, observed on **30th January** to mark the death anniversary of Mahatma Gandhi, will **officially mark the end of the Republic Day festivities**.

25TH January National Voters' Day

- Since 2011, National Voters' Day has been observed annually on January 25 to commemorate the foundation day of the Election Commission of India, established on January 25, 1950.
- The theme for National Voters' Day 2026 is "My India, My Vote" with a tagline of Citizen at the Heart of Indian Democracy.



25th January National Tourism Day

- National Tourism Day, observed on 25th January every year, aims to spread awareness about the importance of the tourism sector in contributing to the growth of the country in terms of finance as well as culture and diversity.
- **National Tourism Day origin can be traced back to the 1948 post-independence India era. The Ministry of Tourism took the initiative of promoting the tourism sector in order to improve economic growth and cultural diplomacy.**
- The United Nations World Tourism Organization (UNWTO) also celebrates World Tourism Day on September 27 each year, aligning with global tourism trends.



26 January - International Customs Day

- Dedicated to the united efforts of Customs to support people and businesses
- **Theme: "Customs Protecting Society through Vigilance and Commitment."**
- **Instituted by the World Customs Organization (WCO)**
 - The **WCO**, originally known as the Customs Cooperation Council (**CCC**), was **established in 1952**.
 - The **inaugural session** of the CCC was held **on January 26, 1953, in Brussels, Belgium**.



26th January - International Day of Clean Energy 2025

- **Declared in 2023 by the UN General Assembly**
- 26 January is also the **founding date** of the **International Renewable Energy Agency (IRENA)**, a global intergovernmental agency **established in 2009** to support countries in their energy transitions



27 January- National Geographic Day

- To honor the **foundation of the National Geographic Society on January 27, 1888, in Washington, D.C., USA**.
- **It is one of the most renowned organizations in the fields of science, exploration, and environmental conservation.**



27 January - International Day of Commemoration in Memory of the Victims of the Holocaust

- Also known as International Holocaust Remembrance Day.
- Designated by the United Nations **to mark the anniversary of the January 27, 1945, liberation of Auschwitz-Birkenau, the largest Nazi concentration and death camp.**



January 28 International Data Privacy Day

- In 2006 **Council of Europe initiated** International Data Privacy Day, also known as **Data Protection Day**.
- This date marks the **anniversary of the opening for signature** of the Council of Europe's "**Convention 108**," the **first legally binding international instrument on data protection in 1981**
- This day is now celebrated worldwide, under the name "International Data Protection Day" or "Privacy Day."
- **Theme - "Privacy by Design: Building Digital Trust,"**



28 January International Day of Peaceful Coexistence

- On 4 March 2025, the United Nations General Assembly adopted proclaiming 28 January as the International Day of Peaceful Coexistence.
- **THEME:** Commitment to Peaceful Coexistence and a Safe, Inclusive World



29 January - Indian Newspaper Day

- Commemorate the birth of the country's first-ever printed newspaper.
- On January 29, 1780, Ireland-born James Augustus Hicky published the first edition of 'Hicky's Bengal Gazette', India's first newspaper.
- The paper survived for just two years in India before being seized by the British administration in 1782 .



Mahatma Gandhi:

- Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi ; Known as Father of the Nation
- **Birth:** 2 October 1869, Porbandar, Gujarat

South Africa (1893–1914):

- Law practice
- Indian rights activism
- Founded Natal Indian Congress
- Started Indian Opinion (weekly, 1904)
- **Return to India:** January 1915

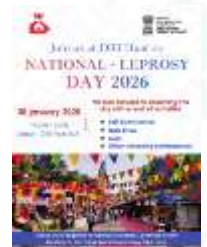
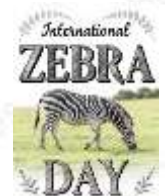


Major Movements:

- Champaran Satyagraha (1917)
- Ahmedabad Mill Strike (1918)
- Kheda Satyagraha (1918)
- Non-Cooperation Movement (1920)
- Dandi March / Salt Satyagraha (1930)
- Quit India Movement (1942)
- **Core Idea:** Satyagraha – non-violent resistance & civil disobedience
- **Literary Works:**
 - Hind Swaraj (1909)
 - The Story of My Experiments with Truth (Autobiography)
 - Editor of Newspapers : Young India, Navjivan, Harijan, Indian Opinion

30 January National Leprosy Day

- India observes National Leprosy Day annually on January 30,
- Leprosy, also known as Hansen's disease, is a chronic infectious disease caused by the bacterium Mycobacterium leprae.
- It primarily affects the skin, peripheral nerves, mucosa of the upper respiratory tract, and the eyes.
- India achieved the elimination of leprosy as a public health problem at the national level in December 2005,
- Leprosy is classified as a neglected tropical disease (NTD)



31 January- International Zebra Day

- Now listed as **"Near Threatened"** on the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) Red List of Endangered Species.

Appointments(IN TABLE)

Person	Appointment
Sharadchandra Sonak	Chief Justice of Jharkhand High Court
Justice Manoj Kumar Gupta	the Chief Justice of the Uttarakhand High Court.
Justice Revati Mohite Dere	first woman Chief Justice of the Meghalaya High Court
Justice Soumen Sen	Chief Justice of Kerala High Court
Sujoy Paul	chief justice of Calcutta High Court .
Sangam Kumar Sahoo	Chief Justice of Patna High Court
Air Marshal Nagesh Kapoor	Vice Chief of the Air Staff

Air Marshal Tejinder Singh	Air Officer Commanding-in-Chief, South Western Air Command
Air Marshal Seethepalli Shrinivas	Air Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Training Command
Lt. Gen. Harpal Singh	29th Director General Border Roads.
Shatrujeet Singh Kapoor	Director General of Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP)
Praveen Kumar	BSF chief
IPS officer Ajay Singhal	42nd Director General of Police of Haryana.
Rakesh Aggarwal	Director General of the National Investigation Agency (NIA),
Sreekumar G. Pillai	director of Indira Gandhi Centre for Atomic Research
A Sakthivel	chairman of the Apparel Export Promotion Council (AEPC)
Lav Aggarwal	chief of Directorate General of Foreign Trade
Rabindra Kumar Agarwal	Additional Secretary in the Ministry of Cooperation
IAS officer Dilip Kumar	Director General , Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship
DB Venkatesh Varma	nominated by the UN Secretary General to chair the Advisory Board on Disarmament Matters for the 2026–27 term
Shaya Zindani	Yemen Prime Minister
Mamady Doumbouya	Guinea president
MS Dhoni	goodwill ambassador for India's first international cycling road race
Nitin Nabin	National President of Bharatiya Janata Party
Shri Praveen Vashista	Vigilance Commissioner in the Central Vigilance Commission
Sanjeev Khirwar	new commissioner of Municipal Corporation of Delhi
Ravi Shankar Chhabhi	Deputy Inspector General (DIG) in the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF)
Vijender Singh	member of the Asian Boxing Council
Yoweri Museveni	Uganda's President
Keshav Poddar	Jersey City's deputy mayor for housing and economic development
Deepinder Goyal	Eternal's vice chairman
Albinder Singh Dhindsa	MD and CEO Eternal
Satyaki Ghosh	CEO Raymond Lifestyle
Kaizad Bharucha	whole-time director at HDFC Bank
Sunetra Pawar	Maharashtra's first woman Deputy CM

Person	Retirement
Sunita Williams	NASA astronaut

With static

Sangam Kumar Sahoo takes oath as Chief Justice of Patna High Court

- Sangam Kumar Sahoo was sworn in as the Chief Justice of the Patna High Court
- The oath was administered by Bihar Governor Arif Mohammad Khan
- He was elevated as a Judge of the Orissa High Court on July 2, 2014.

**Appointment of High Court Chief Justice**

- **Recommendation:** Supreme Court Collegium (CJI + 4 senior-most SC judges) recommends the name, considering seniority, merit, and regional representation.
- **Government Role:** Law Ministry forwards it to the PM; PM advises the President. Government may seek clarification but cannot indefinitely reject.
- **Oath & Tenure:** Takes oath under Article 219; retires at 62 years (Article 217(1)).

Justice Mahesh Sharadchandra Sonak sworn in as Chief Justice of Jharkhand High Court

- Justice Mahesh Sharadchandra Sonak sworn in as the 18th Chief Justice of Jharkhand High Court (HC).
- Governor Santosh Kumar Gangwar administered the oath of office
- **Justice Sonak assumed charge after incumbent Chief Justice Tarlok Singh Chauhan demitted office on January 8**, upon attaining the age of 62 years.

**Justice Manoj Kumar Gupta appointed Chief Justice of Uttarakhand HC.**

- Justice Manoj Kumar Gupta was appointed as the Chief Justice of the Uttarakhand High Court.
- At present, he is a judge of the Allahabad High Court.
- **He will assume charge after the incumbent, Justice Guhanathan Narendar, demits office upon attaining the age of 62.**
- Justice Gupta's name was recommended for elevation by the Supreme Court Collegium last month.

Sujoy Paul takes oath as Chief Justice of Calcutta High Court

- Sujoy Paul was sworn in as the chief justice of Calcutta High Court .
- **West Bengal Governor C.V. Ananda Bose administered the oath of office to Justice Paul.**
- He was officiating as the Acting Chief Justice of the High Court since the retirement of former Chief Justice T.S. Sivagnanam.

**Soumen Sen is new Kerala Chief Justice**

- **Soumen Sen, Chief Justice of the High Court of Meghalaya, will be the new Chief Justice of the Kerala High Court.**
- Nithin Jamdar, the present Chief Justice of Kerala, will retire on January 9.

**Appointment of High Court Judges (Article 217)**

- Constitutional Provision: Article 217 states that a High Court Judge is appointed by the President, in consultation with the Chief Justice of India (CJI) and the Governor of the State.

Chief Justice Appointment Policy:

- Appointment of High Court Chief Justice (Very Short):
- Recommended by Supreme Court Collegium (CJI + 4 senior SC judges).
- Appointed by President on PM's advice.
- Oath: Article 219.
- Retirement: 62 years (Article 217(1)).

Justice Revati Mohite Dere Becomes Meghalaya's First Woman Chief Justice

- Justice Revati Mohite Dere was sworn in as the first woman Chief Justice of the Meghalaya High Court.
- Justice Dere succeeds Soumen Sen, who has been transferred to the Kerala High Court.
- Revati Mohite Dere served as a judge of the Bombay High Court.

**Ajay Singhal takes charge as DGP**

- IPS officer Ajay Singhal assumed charge as the 42nd Director General of Police of Haryana.
- Singhal introduced the 'Madadgar Police' or 'May I Help You'



initiative, which will be launched soon to assist people in need at night.

BSF, ITBP and NIA get new chiefs

- **Senior IPS officer Rakesh Aggarwal was appointed as the Director General of the National Investigation Agency (NIA),** tenure up to August 31, 2028
- **Former Haryana DGP Shatrueet Singh Kapoor was named as the Director General of Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP)** up to October 31, 2026, succeeding incumbent Praveen Kumar
- **A IPS officer of West Bengal cadre, Praveen Kumar has been appointed as the next BSF chief** up to September 30, 2030, the date of his retirement.



National Investigation Agency (NIA)

- **Establishment:** Under the National Investigation Agency Act, 2008, which was enacted in the aftermath of the 26/11 Mumbai terror attacks.
- **Objective:** To investigate and prosecute offences that threatens India's sovereignty, security, and integrity, friendly relations with foreign States, matters relating to international treaties etc
- **Headquarters:** New Delhi with 2 Zonal offices at Guwahati & Jammu.
- **Headed by:** Director-General (DG), who is a senior Indian Police Service (IPS) officer.

Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP)

- It is a **Central Armed Police Force functioning under the Ministry of Home Affairs**, Government of India.
- This force guards the 3,488 km long India-China border through 197 BOPs situated at altitudes ranging from 9,000 ft to 18,750 ft from Karakoram Pass in Ladakh to Jachep La in Arunachal Pradesh.

Background:

- It was raised in 1962, in the wake of the Sino-Indian War of 1962, for deployment along India's border with China's Tibet Autonomous Region.
- **ITBP was initially raised under the CRPF Act.** However, in 1992, parliament enacted the ITBPF Act, and the rules thereunder were framed in 1994.

Border Security Force

- **Known as the First Line of Defence of Indian Territories**, BSF is a primary border-guarding organisation of India.
- **BSF is one of the seven Central Armed Police Forces (CSPFs)** of the Union of India under the administrative control of the Ministry of Home Affairs.
- **It was raised in the wake of the 1965 War on 1 December 1965**, "for ensuring the security of the borders of India and for matters associated therewith.
- **The motto of BSF, "DUTY UNTO DEATH"** is placed at the bottom.
- **BSF is the only CAPF to have its own Air Wing, Marine Wing, and artillery regiments**, which support the General Duty Battalions in their operations.

Air Marshal Nagesh Kapoor assumed the appointment of Vice Chief of the Air Staff, Indian Air Force.

- Air Marshal Nagesh Kapoor assumed charge as the Vice Chief of the Air Staff, succeeding Air Marshal Narmdeshwar Tiwari, who superannuated after 40 years of distinguished service to the nation.



The IAF also appointed two new AOC-in-Cs.

- **Air Marshal Tejinder Singh** took over as the Air Officer Commanding-in-Chief, South Western Air Command while Air Marshal Seethepalli Shrinivas assumed charge as the Air Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Training Command.

Lt. Gen. Harpal Singh assumed charge as the 29th Director General Border Roads

- Lt. Gen. Harpal Singh assumed charge as the 29th Director General Border Roads.

BRO:



- Raised in 1960, the BRO has been instrumental in developing strategic infrastructure in some of the most challenging terrains, enhancing national security and border connectivity.
- BRO was entirely brought under the Ministry of Defence in 2015.

Major Bureaucratic Reshuffle: Lav Aggarwal to DGFT, R.K. Agarwal Heads FCI

- Senior bureaucrat Lav Aggarwal was appointed as the chief of Directorate General of Foreign Trade as part of a major bureaucratic reshuffle effected by the Central government.
- Rabindra Kumar Agarwal, Additional Secretary in the Ministry of Cooperation, will be Chairman and Managing Director of Food Corporation of India.
- Punjab cadre IAS officer Dilip Kumar will be Director General, Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship



Indian Diplomat Chairs UN Disarmament Advisory Board

- **Senior Indian diplomat DB Venkatesh Varma** has been nominated by the UN Secretary General to **chair the Advisory Board on Disarmament Matters for the 2026–27 term, marking the first time an Indian will hold the position.**

Advisory Board on Disarmament Matters

- It was established in **1978**.
- **Membership:** The Secretary-General chooses the members of the Board from all regions of the world for their knowledge and experience in the field of disarmament and international security.
- The Advisory Board holds two sessions a year, alternating between New York and Geneva.
- Headquarter: New York.



A Sakthivel Appointed AEPC Chairman for Fifth Term

- A Sakthivel has been recently appointed as the chairman of the Apparel Export Promotion Council (AEPC), marking his fifth term at the helm of the organization.

About Apparel Export Promotion Council (AEPC)

- It was established in 1978 under the provisions of the Foreign Trade (Development and Regulation) Act of 1992.
- It is the **official body of apparel exporters in India.**
- It **operates under the aegis of the Ministry of Textiles, Government of India.**
- Its primary objective is to promote and support the export of Indian garments and textiles to the global market.



Sreekumar G. Pillai appointed director of Indira Gandhi Centre for Atomic Research

- Sreekumar G. Pillai, Deputy Chief Executive, Nuclear Recycle Board, Bhabha Atomic Research Centre (BARC), Mumbai, has been appointed the **new Director of Indira Gandhi Centre for Atomic Research (IGCAR), Kalpakkam, from January 1, 2026.**

Guinea Elects Mamady Doumbouya as President

- **Guinea coup leader Mamady Doumbouya has been elected president,**
- **Capital:** Conakry
- **Currency:** Guinean franc (GNF)



Yemen Names Shaya Zindani as Prime Minister After Breik Resignation



- Yemen's Saudi-backed presidential leadership council has accepted the resignation of Prime Minister Salem bin Breik and **appointed Foreign Minister Shaya Mohsin al-Zindani as the country's new prime minister.**
- **Yemen Capital:** Sanaa
- **Currency:** Yemeni rial

Bajaj Pune Grand Tour 2026: MS Dhoni named goodwill ambassador for India's first international cycling road race

- India's first international cycling road race, scheduled to be held in the city from January 19-23.
- The race will wind through a 437-km route across the Deccan Plateau and Sahyadri range, featuring sharp bends and challenging elevations.
- The event has attracted 171 riders from 29 teams across 35 countries.
- The Indian challenge will be led by decorated rider Naveen John for the Indian National Team.



Nitin Nabin becomes National President of Bharatiya Janata Party

- Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) working president Nitin Nabin has been elected as the new national president of the party.
- Mr Nabin is the youngest national President in the party's history and the first BJP leader from Bihar to be appointed to the post.
- He currently represents the Bankipur Assembly constituency in Patna district and holds the Road Construction portfolio in the Nitish Kumar led Bihar government.



Praveen Vashista Appointed Vigilance Commissioner in CVC

- Shri Praveen Vashista, IPS (Bihar cadre, 1991 batch), has been appointed as Vigilance Commissioner in the Central Vigilance Commission and took oath on 16 January 2026.



About Central Vigilance Commission (CVC):

- The apex integrity and vigilance institution of the Government of India.
- Mandated to promote integrity, transparency and accountability in public administration and to prevent corruption in Central Government organisations.

Established in:

- 1964 as an executive resolution of the Government of India.
- Given statutory status by the Central Vigilance Commission Act, 2003.

Historical background:

- Originated from the recommendations of the Santhanam Committee (1962–64) on Prevention of Corruption.
- Initially functioned without statutory backing, limiting its authority.
- Became a statutory and independent body in 2003, strengthening its supervisory and advisory role in vigilance administration.

Composition and members:

- Headed by a Central Vigilance Commissioner (Chairperson).
- Assisted by not more than two Vigilance Commissioners (Members).
- Appointed by the President of India on the recommendation of a high-level committee.
- Tenure is four years or up to 65 years of age, whichever is earlier.

Key functions:

- Supervises and coordinates the vigilance machinery across Central Government organisations.
- Inquires or causes inquiry/investigation into corruption complaints within its jurisdiction.

Sanjeev Khirwar appointed new commissioner of Municipal Corporation of Delhi

- The Union Home Ministry appointed Sanjeev Khirwar as the Commissioner of Municipal Corporation of Delhi.
- Khirwar served as the Private Secretary to then Women and Child Development minister Krishna Tirath between 2009 and 2014.
- He takes over from Ashwani Kumar.



Ravi Shankar Chhabhi Appointed DIG in CRPF on Central Deputation

- The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has formally approved the appointment of Ravi Shankar Chhabhi, a 2007-batch Indian Police Service (IPS) officer from the Uttar Pradesh cadre, as Deputy Inspector General (DIG) in the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF).
- **At present, Chhabhi is serving as DIG (Public Grievances) at the DGP Headquarters in Lucknow, a position he has held since June 2023.**

Vijender Singh Joins Asian Boxing Council

- India's Vijender Singh, who won a bronze medal at the Beijing 2008 Olympics, was appointed as a member of the Asian Boxing Council, the Boxing Federation of India (BFI) announced.
- **India's first Olympic medallist in boxing, he won gold at the 2010 Asian Games in Guangzhou** after securing bronze at the 2006 edition in Doha. He is also a three-time Commonwealth Games medallist, claiming silver at Melbourne 2006 and Glasgow 2014, and bronze at Delhi 2010.
- The Asian Boxing Council operates under the umbrella of the World Boxing Council. **World Boxing is an international federation approved by the International Olympic Committee.**



Museveni Secures Seventh Term in Uganda As President

- Veteran President Yoweri Museveni was the landslide winner of Uganda's presidential election.
- **Capital:** Kampala
- **Currency:** Ugandan shilling



Indian-origin attorney Keshav Poddar has been sworn in as Jersey City's deputy mayor for housing and economic development



Deepinder Goyal appointed Eternal's vice chairman, Albinder Singh Dhindsa named CEO

- Deepinder Goyal has been appointed as the vice chairman & director on the board of Eternal Ltd. (Formerly Zomato Ltd.)
- He had resigned as the director, MD and CEO of the company.
- The board also recommended and approved the appointment of Albinder Singh Dhindsa (currently, CEO-Blinkit) as chief executive officer.



Raymond Lifestyle has appointed Satyaki Ghosh as its CEO with immediate effect



RBI Approves Kaizad Bharucha Appointment at HDFC Bank

- The RBI has approved the appointment of Kaizad Bharucha as a whole-time director on the bank's board.
- HDFC Bank was incorporated in August 1994 in the name of HDFC Bank Limited, with its registered office in Mumbai, India.
- The bank commenced operations as a Scheduled Commercial Bank in January 1995.



NASA astronaut Sunita Williams retires

- After 27 years of service, NASA astronaut Sunita "Suni" Williams retired on December 27, 2025.
- She completed three missions aboard the International Space Station, setting multiple human spaceflight records.



- **First launched aboard Space Shuttle Discovery (STS-116) in December 2006; returned on Atlantis (STS-117).**
- In 2012, launched from Baikonur, Kazakhstan, for a 127-day mission as part of Expedition 32/33.
- Performed three spacewalks to repair a radiator leak and replace a solar power-linked component.
- Tied for sixth-longest single spaceflight by an American (286 days) with Butch Wilmore, achieved during Boeing Starliner and SpaceX Crew-9 missions.
- **First person to run a marathon in space.**
- Most recently, launched with Wilmore aboard Starliner in June 2024 for NASA's Boeing Crew Flight Test mission.
- **Completed two spacewalks and returned to Earth in March 2025 via SpaceX Crew-9.**
- Participated in NASA's NEEMO mission (2002), living nine days in an underwater habitat.
- Ms. Sunita 'Suni' Williams was born to a Gujarati father, Deepak Pandya, hailing from Jhulasan in Mehsana district and a Slovenian mother, Ursuline Bonnie Pandya, on September 19, 1965, in Euclid, Ohio, in the U.S.

Ajit Pawar's wife Sunetra Pawar set to be Maharashtra's first woman Deputy CM

- Sunetra Pawar, wife of the deceased Nationalist Congress Party leader Ajit Pawar, is set to become the first woman Deputy Chief Minister of Maharashtra.
- MP Sunetra Pawar was elected by NCP legislators as the leader of the party's

SUNETRA PAWAR SET TO BECOME
MAHARASHTRA'S DEPUTY CM



Books

Book	Author	Remark
'Early North India and Its Coinage'	Author: Devendra Handa	published by the Hinduja Foundation. The publication documents coinage from the North Indian region dating from 300 BCE to 300 CE
Gen V Bano' and 'Mahatma'		
Guru Gobind Singh Sahib: Life, Vision & Wisdom and Dasmesh-Pita Bakhshish Pavitar Ganga Sagar		Two new books that explore the life, teachings, worldview, and historic events related to Guru Gobind Singh—the tenth Sikh Guru
History That India Ignored	written by veteran journalist and Asian News International (ANI) Chairman Prem Prakash	The Prabha Khaitan Foundation, under its literary initiative 'Kitaab', organised the book launch .
"Sing, Dance and Lead: Leadership Lessons from the Life of Srila Prabhupada"	author Hindol Sengupta .	The central theme of the book, conveys the powerful idea that leadership can be joyful, participative and deeply human
'Darling Earth' — the English translation of 'Parthibo'	written by Shirshendu Mukhopadhyay translated by Prasenjit Saha	
, "Premnu Vishva, Vishvano Prem,"	Shrimad Vijayaratna Sunder Surishwarji Maharaj	
"Khutbat-e-Modi: Lal Qila Ki Faseel Se"	The book is a compilation of the Independence Day addresses delivered by the Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi from the Red Fort between 2014	Published in Urdu, the book has been brought out by the National Council for Promotion of Urdu Language (NCPUL), New Delhi.

	and 2025.	
From Volga to Ganga (Volvavilundhu Gangai Varai)	by Rahul Sankrityayan translation has been undertaken by A. Mangai.	She has translated into Tamil the English edition published by LeftWord.
BOOK: Nalanda: How It Changed the World	BY: Abhay K	
the book "Chalice of Ambrosia: Ram Janmabhoomi – Challenge and Response",	authored by Shri Surendra Kumar Pachauri	the book captures the centuries-old struggle to reclaim the birthplace of Lord Shri Ram and presents the historical narrative with balance, empathy and scholarly restraint
the Hindi edition of 'Palanivelu GUTS'	autobiography of eminent surgeon Dr. C. Palanivelu	the book as an inspiring testament to courage, perseverance and ethical innovation in the field of medicine.+
Book - 'The Sari Eternal'	by Lakshmi Puri	A personalised memoir of her own love affair with the sari
The Courtesan, Her Lover and I	Tarana Husain Khan	

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh releases book on 'Akash'

Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh released the book 'The Unprecedented success story of the first indigenous supersonic multitarget surface to air missile system - Akash' authored by former, project director 'Akash' & programme director, Defence Research and Development Laboratory (DRDL) G Chandramouli. Chandramouli has been selected for 'Padma Sri' Award 2026' in science and engineering category,

Obituaries

Renowned ecologist Madhav Gadgil passed away.

- Veteran ecologist Madhav Gadgil, known for championing community rights and sustainable development, passed away.
- In 2010, the Union government appointed Gadgil as the head of the Western Ghats Ecology Expert Panel (WGEEP), later known as the Gadgil Commission.
- In 2024, Dr Gadgil was named a laureate of the United Nations Environment Programme's Champions of the Earth award, recognising his lifetime contribution to environmental science and community-led conservation.
- This is the United Nations' highest environmental honour. He is one of six laureates in the 2024 cohort.
- One of Dr Gadgil's most significant achievements was **establishing India's first biosphere reserve, the Nilgiri Biosphere Reserve in 1986.**
- Gadgil was one of the key architects of India's Biological Diversity Act and contributed to the implementation of the Forest Rights Act.
- **His memoir, A Walk Up The Hill: Living with People and Nature.**



Assam BJP leader Kabindra Purkayastha dies at 94

- Former Union Minister Kabindra Purkayastha, who helped the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) strike roots in Assam in the 1980s, die
- **Three-time MP from southern Assam's Silchar constituency.**
- He served as a Minister in the first Atal Bihari Vajpayee government in 1998-99.



Suresh Kalmadi, former Union Minister and Congress leader, passes away at 81.

- Senior Congress leader and former Union Minister Suresh Kalmadi passed away in Pune, He was 81.



- He had served as Union Minister of State for Railways and was a former president of the Indian Olympic Association (IOA).

Former World billiards champion Manoj Kothari passes away

- Former World billiards champion and Indian cue sports chief coach Manoj Kothari passed away.
- He won the World billiards title in 1990 and the World doubles billiards championships in 1997 before being conferred the prestigious Dhyan Chand Award for lifetime achievement in 2005.



Pulitzer Prize-winning historian Daniel Walker Howe dead at 88.

- Daniel Walker Howe, a Pulitzer Prize-winning historian whose **"What Hath God Wrought"** became a widely acclaimed chronicle of the vast technological and social changes in the US in the first half of the 19th century, has died at age 88.
- Awarded the Pulitzer in 2008.



Former Indian Hockey player Davinder Singh Garcha passes away at 74.

- Former Indian Hockey player, Olympian and Gold Medallist, Davinder Singh Garcha passed away.
- He was 74.
- A former IPS officer, he was part of the Indian hockey team that won the gold medal in the 1980 Moscow Olympics.
- He was also the President of Mohinder Singh Munshi Hockey Tournament.



Ueli Kestenholz Dies in Swiss Alps Avalanche at 50

- Ueli Kestenholz, the Swiss snowboarder who won an Olympic bronze medal during snowboarding's debut at the Winter Games, has died after being caught in an avalanche in the Swiss Alps.
- An avalanche is a rapid downslope flow of snow, often triggered by terrain, weather, and human activity.
- Snowboarding made its Olympic debut at the 1998 Nagano Winter Olympics.



'Save Kurinji' crusader G. Rajkumar passes away at 70

- G. Rajkumar, a bank employee-turned-environmentalist and the driving force behind the Save Kurinji Campaign, passed away in Thiruvananthapuram. He was 70.
- Fondly known as "Kurinji Rajkumar".
- His efforts played a pivotal role in creating public awareness about the conservation of Strobilanthes kunthiana, popularly known as the Neelakurinji.

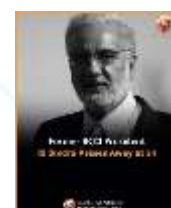


Neelakurinji

- A purplish flowering shrub that blooms once every 12 years.
- Endemic to the high-altitude shola grasslands of southwest India (1,340–2,600 m).
- Found mainly in the Western Ghats; one subpopulation in the Eastern Ghats (Yercaud).
- Semelparous: flowers and fruits only once at the end of its life cycle (synchronous mass blooming).
- Gave the Nilgiri Hills their name ("Blue Mountains").
- Used by Paliyan tribes to calculate age.

Former BCCI President IS Bindra Dies at 84

- Inderjit Singh Bindra, former president of the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) died in New Delhi
- He was 84.
- Bindra served as BCCI president from 1993 to 1996,



Justice David Annoussamy passes away

- Former Judge of Madras High Court David Annoussamy passed away at a private hospital due to age-related illness, here on Saturday afternoon. He was 98.



- Mr. Annoussamy had a distinguished career in Puducherry Court, including as Chief Judge, before his elevation to the Madras High Court.
- **He also headed the nine-member committee appointed to recommend November 1 as Puducherry's Independence Day.**
- He was the honorary president of Alliance Francaise de Pondicherry.

Valentino Garavani, the jet-set Italian designer often in his trademark shade of "Valentino red" has died



S. Siri Jagan, former judge of the Kerala High Court, passed away

- **Mr. Siri Jagan was serving as chairperson of the Sabarimala high-power committee appointed by the Kerala High Court** and as chairman of the Supreme Court-appointed committee to adjudicate compensation for victims of dog bites.
- He had also served as the acting Vice-Chancellor of the National University of Advanced Legal Studies, Kochi.



Padma Shri Father Kunnunkal, former CBSE chairman, passes away at 99

- Father Kunnunkal, a Jesuit priest, a Padma Shri awardee and one of the most influential figures in India's post-Independence education system, died .
- Born in Alappuzha, Kerala in 1926.
- **Best known for reshaping the Central Board of Secondary Education into a national benchmark.**
- Father Kunnunkal served as the CBSE chairman from 1980 to 1987.
- He helped conceptualise and establish the National Open School under the National Policy on Education, 1986.



Michael Nobbs Former Coach Of Indian Hockey Team Passed Away

- Former India Hockey team coach and ex-Australia international Michael Nobbs passed away
- Nobbs was a popular figure in the Indian hockey circuit, **having become the coach of the national side in June 2011 until July 2013**
- He was pivotal in the Indian team's return to the Olympics



Maharashtra Deputy CM Ajit Pawar died

- Maharashtra's Deputy Chief Minister Ajit Pawar has died in a plane crash at Maharashtra's Baramati .
- In November 2019, he rebelled against his uncle of Nationalist Congress Party Sharad Pawar and took oath as Deputy Chief Minister with the BJP's Devendra Fadnavis .
- The aircraft, a Learjet 45XR with registration VT-SSK operated by VSR Aviation.



Catherine O'Hara, the Emmy- winning Canadian- American actor passed away

- Catherine O'Hara, the Emmy- winning Canadian- American actor, popular for her comic roles, passed away in Los Angeles
- She was 71 year old. O'Hara was best known for her starring roles in the Home Alone and Beetlejuice films.



Awards

National

Karnataka State Film Awards 2020 and 2021: M.S. Sathyu honoured with Puttanna Kanagal Award

- The Lifetime Achievement Awards as part of the Karnataka State Film Awards 2020 and 2021 were announced.
- **Renowned filmmaker and theatre giant M.S. Sathyu was honoured with the Puttanna Kanagal Award for the year 2020.**
- **Actor-politician Jayamala, who has an experience of over 50 years in the film industry, was named for the Dr. Rajkumar Award**
- Veteran still photographer Pragathi Ashwath Narayana was picked for the Dr. Vishnuvardhan Award.

For the year 2021,

- Sa. Ra. Govindu, producer and former Karnataka State Film Chamber for Commerce (KFCC) president, was honoured with the Dr. Rajkumar Award.
- Director K. Shivarudraiah was named for the Puttana Kanagal Award, while actor-producer M.K. Sundar Raj was given the Dr. Vishnuvardhan Award.

Achyutananda Pati, Daisy Rockwell picked for Kalinga Literary awards

- The Kalinga Literary Festival (KLF) 2026 (January 8-11) has announced a slew of awards, **recognising outstanding contributions to literature, translation, cultural dialogue across India, South Asia, and the world.**
- Noted Odia writer Achyutananda Pati is being honoured with the Kalinga Literary Award (India) for his short stories on the lives of marginalised people.
- The **Kalinga Literary Award (International)** will be conferred on writer and translator Daisy Rockwell.
- **Her translation of Geetanjali Shree's Ret Samadhi** (Tomb of Sand) won both of them the International Booker Prize in 2022.
- **Writer and poet Ranjana Niraula of Nepal has bagged the Kalinga Literary Award (Youth).** With her stories, she has encouraged a new generation to engage deeply with the shared literary traditions of India, Nepal, and the wider South Asian region.
- **The International Living Legend Award 2026 is being conferred on Dr. Binod Chaudhury, at Kalinga Literary Festival .**

Winners of 'Badalta Bharat Mera Anubhav' Creative Challenges Announced

- The Information and Broadcasting Ministry has announced the winners of four creative challenges under the Badalta Bharat Mera Anubhav campaign.
- The challenges were organised in collaboration with the MyGov platform
- **Under the campaign, citizens were invited to share their personal experiences and creative expressions reflecting the country's transformation over the last 11 years under the visionary leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.**
- **Indrajeet Subodh Mashankar has won first prize in the Category of Badalta Bharat Mera Anubhav – Instagram Reel Contest,**
- **Manthan Rohit received the first prize in Badalta Bharat Mera Anubhav – YouTube Shorts Challenge** category.
- **Sushovan Manna won the first prize in the Short AV Challenge – Story of New India category.**
- while Krishna Gupta bagged the first prize in the category of Badalta Bharat Mera Anubhav – Blog Writing Contest.

**Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw conferred 70th Ati Vishisht Rail Seva Puraskar 2025 in New Delhi**

- Indian Railways conferred the 70th Ati Vishisht Rail Seva Puraskar–2025.
- A total of 100 awardees have been selected for the Ati Vishisht Rail Seva Puraskar–2025,
- **The Ati Vishisht Rail Seva Puraskar is one of the highest service awards of Indian Railways.**
- The awards aim to honour individuals and teams whose work has significantly strengthened railway operations, safety, innovation, and public service delivery across the country.

**ASTRAM project wins Skoch Award for sustainable traffic management**

- Project ASTRAM (**Actionable Intelligence for Sustainable Traffic Management**), a citizen-centric traffic management initiative conceived by NTR district(Andhra Pradesh) commissioner of police S.V. Rajashekhara Babu, has won the SKOCH Award 2025 in the Gold category under Police and Safety, earning national recognition for excellence in governance and public service delivery.

**The third edition of the Assam Police Sishu Mitra Champion Awards, 21 officers awarded for 'child-friendly policing'**

- This was the third edition of the Assam Police Sishu Mitra Champion Awards, a part of the Assam Police Sishu Mitra Programme.



- The Assam Police awarded 21 police officers from across the state for “outstanding contributions to child protection and child-friendly policing”.
- **the Jury’s Choice Award - Devojoyoti Mukherjee, IPS** (IGP, Border) - the jury acknowledged his supervisory role in the investigation of the Nagaon and Hojai child abuse cases.
- **Special Recognition Awards were conferred** on officials from the Women and Child Development department, Guwahati Medical College Hospital, and Pragjyotishpur Medical College, .

Karnataka Bank Wins IBA Award for Fintech Adoption

- Karnataka Bank emerged as **winner in the ‘Best Fintech & DPI Adoption’ category at the Indian Banks’ Association (IBA) Banking Technology Awards.**
- These awards reflect the combined efforts of IT and business teams in driving digital innovation, nurturing technology talent, and delivering customer-centric banking solutions.



Shri Arjun Ram Meghwal distributes prizes of 26th National Youth Parliament Competition, 2024-25

- The Prize Distribution Function of the **26th National Youth Parliament Competition, 2024-25 for Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalayas** was held, the 15th of January, 2026 at Mavalankar Auditorium, Constitution Club of India, Rafi Marg, New Delhi.
- **PM Shri School Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya, Suratgarh, Sriganganagar-II, Rajasthan** (Jaipur Region), which stood first at the National Level in the 26th National Youth Parliament Competition, 2024–25 for Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalayas,

In addition, the following 7 regional winning Vidyalayas also received prizes from the Minister:

Sl.No.	Name of Vidyalayas	Region
1.	PM Shri Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya, Valsad, Gujarat	Pune
2.	PM Shri Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya, Ambedkar Nagar, Uttar Pradesh	Lucknow
3.	PM Shri Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya, Shimla, Himachal Pradesh	Chandigarh
4.	PM Shri Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya, Birbhum, West Bengal	Patna
5.	PM Shri Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya, Golghat, Assam	Shillong
6.	PM Shri Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya, Medak, Telangana	Hyderabad
7.	PM Shri Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya, Mahasamund, Chhattisgarh	Bhopal

The D4 Counter-Drone System and the Dharashakti Integrated EW System have been conferred with the prestigious SKOCH Award

- Two critical indigenous systems — the D4 Counter-Drone System and the Dharashakti Integrated Electronic Warfare (EW) System — **have been awarded the prestigious SKOCH Award (Gold Category), underscoring India’s growing strength in electronic warfare, air defence, and counter-UAS technologies.**
- The award recognises the role of India’s defence research ecosystem in developing strategically significant, operationally deployed, and indigenously designed systems to counter emerging aerial and electronic threats.



What is SKOCH Award?

- The SKOCH Award is one of India’s most respected civilian awards, recognising excellence in governance, security, technology, and public sector innovation.
- The **Gold Category** is reserved for projects that demonstrate exceptional impact, scalability, and national importance.

Padma Awards 2026

- The Padma Awards, one of the highest civilian honour of India, are announced every year on the eve of Republic Day
- **The Awards are given in three categories: Padma Vibhushan** for exceptional and distinguished service; **Padma Bhushan** for distinguished service of higher order and **Padma Shri** for distinguished service in any field of activity.
- **The Awards are given in various disciplines, ranging from art and social work to public affairs, science, engineering, sports, and civil service.**
- **This year, the President has approved conferment of 131 Padma Awards — 5 Padma Vibhushan, 13 Padma Bhushan and 113 Padma Shri Awards.**
- **The highest number of winners this year were from Maharashtra (15), followed by Tamil Nadu(13), Uttar Pradesh (11), West Bengal (11), and Kerala (8).**
- **These Padma Awards are conferred by the President of India at ceremonial functions which are held at Rashtrapati Bhawan usually around March or April every year.**



Padma Vibhushan 2026 winners:

SN	Name	Field	State / Country
1	Shri Dharmendra Singh Deol (Posthumous)	Art	Maharashtra
2	Shri K T Thomas	Public Affairs	Kerala
3	Ms. N Rajam	Art	Uttar Pradesh
4	Shri P Narayanan	Literature and Education	Kerala
5	Shri V S Achuthanandhan (Posthumous)	Public Affairs	Kerala

Padma Bhushan 2026 winners:

SN	Name	Field	State / Country
1	Ms. Alka Yagnik	Art	Maharashtra
2	Shri Bhagat Singh Koshyari	Public Affairs	Uttarakhand
3	Shri Kallipatti Ramasamy Palaniswamy	Medicine	Tamil Nadu
4	Shri Mammooty	Art	Kerala
5	Dr. Nori Dattatreya	Medicine	United States of America
6	Shri Piyush Pandey (Posthumous)	Art	Maharashtra
7	Shri S K M Maeilanandhan	Social Work	Tamil Nadu
8	Shri Shatavadhani R Ganesh	Art	Karnataka
9	Shri Shibu Soren (Posthumous)	Public Affairs	Jharkhand
10	Shri Uday Kotak	Trade and Industry	Maharashtra
11	Shri V K Malhotra (Posthumous)	Public Affairs	Delhi
12	Shri Vellappally Natesan	Public Affairs	Kerala
13	Shri Vijay Amritraj	Sports	United States of America

Padma Shri 2026 winners:

SN	Name	Field	State / Country
1	Shri A E Muthunayagam	Science and Engineering	Kerala

2	Shri Anil Kumar Rastogi	Art	Uttar Pradesh
3	Shri Anke Gowda M.	Social Work	Karnataka
4	Ms. Armida Fernandez	Medicine	Maharashtra
5	Shri Arvind Vaidya	Art	Gujarat
6	Shri Ashok Khade	Trade and Industry	Maharashtra
7	Shri Ashok Kumar Singh	Science and Engineering	Uttar Pradesh
8	Shri Asok Kumar Halder	Literature and Education	West Bengal
9	Shri Baldev Singh	Sports	Punjab
10	Shri Bhagwandas Raikwar	Sports	Madhya Pradesh
11	Shri Bharat Singh Bharti	Art	Bihar
12	Shri Bhiklya Ladakya Dhinda	Art	Maharashtra
13	Shri Bishwa Bandhu (Posthumous)	Art	Bihar
14	Shri Brij Lal Bhat	Social Work	Jammu and Kashmir
15	Shri Buddha Rashmi Mani	Others – Archaeology	Uttar Pradesh
16	Dr. Budhri Tati	Social Work	Chhattisgarh
17	Shri Chandramouli Gaddamanugu	Science and Engineering	Telangana
18	Shri Charan Hembram	Literature and Education	Odisha
19	Shri Chiranji Lal Yadav	Art	Uttar Pradesh
20	Ms. Deepika Reddy	Art	Telangana
21	Shri Dharmiklal Chunilal Pandya	Art	Gujarat
22	Shri Gadde Babu Rajendra Prasad	Art	Andhra Pradesh
23	Shri Gafruddin Mewati Jogi	Art	Rajasthan
24	Shri Gambir Singh Yonzon	Literature and Education	West Bengal
25	Shri Garimella Balakrishna Prasad (Posthumous)	Art	Andhra Pradesh
26	Ms. Gayatri Balasubramanian & Ms. Ranjani Balasubramanian (Duo)	Art	Tamil Nadu
27	Shri Gopal Ji Trivedi	Science and Engineering	Bihar
28	Shri Guduru Venkat Rao	Medicine	Telangana
29	Shri H V Hande	Medicine	Tamil Nadu
30	Shri Hally War	Social Work	Meghalaya
31	Shri Hari Madhab Mukhopadhyay (Posthumous)	Art	West Bengal
32	Shri Haricharan Saikia	Art	Assam
33	Ms. Harmanpreet Kaur Bhullar	Sports	Punjab
34	Shri Inderjit Singh Sidhu	Social Work	Chandigarh

35	Shri Janardan Bapurao Bothe	Social Work	Maharashtra
36	Shri Jogesh Deuri	Others – Agriculture	Assam
37	Shri Juzer Vasi	Science and Engineering	Maharashtra
38	Shri Jyotish Debnath	Art	West Bengal
39	Shri K Pajanivel	Sports	Puducherry
40	Shri K Ramasamy	Science and Engineering	Tamil Nadu
41	Shri K Vijay Kumar	Civil Service	Tamil Nadu
42	Shri Kabindra Purkayastha (Posthumous)	Public Affairs	Assam
43	Shri Kailash Chandra Pant	Literature and Education	Madhya Pradesh
44	Ms. Kalamandalam Vimala Menon	Art	Kerala
45	Shri Kewal Krishan Thakral	Medicine	Uttar Pradesh
46	Shri Khem Raj Sundriyal	Art	Haryana
47	Ms. Kollakal Devaki Amma G	Social Work	Kerala
48	Shri Krishnamurty Balasubramanian	Science and Engineering	Telangana
49	Shri Kumar Bose	Art	West Bengal
50	Shri Kumarasamy Thangaraj	Science and Engineering	Telangana
51	Prof. (Dr.) Lars-Christian Koch	Art	Germany
52	Ms. Liudmila Viktorovna Khokhlova	Literature and Education	Russia
53	Shri Madhavan Ranganathan	Art	Maharashtra
54	Shri Maganti Murali Mohan	Art	Andhra Pradesh
55	Shri Mahendra Kumar Mishra	Literature and Education	Odisha
56	Shri Mahendra Nath Roy	Literature and Education	West Bengal
57	Shri Mamidala Jagadesh Kumar	Literature and Education	Delhi
58	Ms. Mangala Kapoor	Literature and Education	Uttar Pradesh
59	Shri Mir Hajibhai Kasambhai	Art	Gujarat
60	Shri Mohan Nagar	Social Work	Madhya Pradesh
61	Shri Narayan Vyas	Others – Archaeology	Madhya Pradesh
62	Shri Naresh Chandra Dev Varma	Literature and Education	Tripura
63	Shri Nilesh Vinodchandra Mandlewala	Social Work	Gujarat
64	Shri Nuruddin Ahmed	Art	Assam
65	Shri Othuvaar Thiruthani Swaminathan	Art	Tamil Nadu
66	Dr. Padma Gurmet	Medicine	Ladakh
67	Shri Palkonda Vijay Anand Reddy	Medicine	Telangana
68	Ms. Pokhila Lekthepe	Art	Assam
69	Dr. Prabhakar Basavprabhu Kore	Literature and Education	Karnataka

70	Shri Prateek Sharma	Medicine	United States of America
71	Shri Praveen Kumar	Sports	Uttar Pradesh
72	Shri Prem Lal Gautam	Science and Engineering	Himachal Pradesh
73	Shri Prosenjit Chatterjee	Art	West Bengal
74	Dr. Punniyamurthy Natesan	Medicine	Tamil Nadu
75	Shri R Krishnan (Posthumous)	Art	Tamil Nadu
76	Shri R V S Mani	Civil Service	Delhi
77	Shri Rabilal Tudu	Literature and Education	West Bengal
78	Shri Raghupat Singh (Posthumous)	Others – Agriculture	Uttar Pradesh
79	Shri Raghuveer Tukaram Khedkar	Art	Maharashtra
80	Shri Rajastapathi Kaliappa Goundar	Art	Tamil Nadu
81	Shri Rajendra Prasad	Medicine	Uttar Pradesh
82	Shri Rama Reddy Mamidi (Posthumous)	Others – Animal Husbandry	Telangana
83	Shri Ramamurthy Sreedher	Others – Radio Broadcasting	Delhi
84	Shri Ramchandra Godbole & Ms. Suneeta Godbole (Duo)	Medicine	Chhattisgarh
85	Shri Ratilal Borisagar	Literature and Education	Gujarat
86	Shri Rohit Sharma	Sports	Maharashtra
87	Ms. S G Susheelamma	Social Work	Karnataka
81	Shri Rajendra Prasad	Medicine	Uttar Pradesh
82	Shri Rama Reddy Mamidi (Posthumous)	Others – Animal Husbandry	Telangana
83	Shri Ramamurthy Sreedher	Others – Radio Broadcasting	Delhi
84	Shri Ramchandra Godbole & Ms. Suneeta Godbole (Duo)	Medicine	Chhattisgarh
85	Shri Ratilal Borisagar	Literature and Education	Gujarat
86	Shri Rohit Sharma	Sports	Maharashtra
87	Ms. S G Susheelamma	Social Work	Karnataka
96	Shri Shashi Shekhar Vempati	Literature and Education	Karnataka
97	Shri Shrirang Devaba Lad	Others – Agriculture	Maharashtra
98	Ms. Shubha Venkatesha Iyengar	Science and Engineering	Karnataka
99	Shri Shyam Sundar	Medicine	Uttar Pradesh
100	Shri Simanchal Patro	Art	Odisha
101	Ms. Sivasankari	Literature and Education	Tamil Nadu
102	Dr. Suresh Hanagavadi	Medicine	Karnataka
103	Swami Brahmdev Ji Maharaj	Social Work	Rajasthan

104	Shri T T Jagannathan (Posthumous)	Trade and Industry	Karnataka
105	Shri Taga Ram Bheel	Art	Rajasthan
106	Shri Tarun Bhattacharya	Art	West Bengal
107	Shri Techu Gubin	Social Work	Arunachal Pradesh
108	Shri Thiruvapur Bakthavathsalam	Art	Tamil Nadu
109	Ms. Tripti Mukherjee	Art	West Bengal
110	Shri Veezhinathan Kamakoti	Science and Engineering	Tamil Nadu
111	Shri Vempaty Kutumba Sastry	Literature and Education	Andhra Pradesh
112	Shri Vladimir Mestvirishvili (Posthumous)	Sports	Georgia
113	Shri Yumnam Jatra Singh (Posthumous)	Art	Manipur

45 people have been chosen for the coveted Padma Awards honour, under the 'Unsung heroes' category, for their distinguished and unwavering service to the nation.

What is the 'Unsung Hero' Category?

- The "Unsung Hero" is not a formal academic category but a distinct thematic shift introduced by the Government of India over the last decade.
- It refers to grassroots level achievers who have dedicated their lives to the service of society, often working in remote villages or neglected sectors, without any desire for fame, media attention, or official recognition.
- These individuals are supposed to embody the spirit of these awards and are also referred to as 'Peoples' Padma'.

S. No.	Name	State / Union Territory
1	Anke Gowda	Karnataka
2	Armida Fernandez	Maharashtra
3	Bhagwandas Raikwar	Madhya Pradesh
4	Bhikya Ladakya Dhinda	Rajasthan
5	Brij Lal Bhat	Jammu & Kashmir
6	Budhri Tati	Chhattisgarh
7	Charan Hembram	West Bengal
8	Chiranji Lal Yadav	Uttar Pradesh
9	Dharmiklal Chunilal Pandya	Gujarat
10	Gafruddin Mewati Jogi	Haryana
11	Hally War	Nagaland
12	Inderjit Singh Sidhu	Punjab
13	K Pajanivel	Tamil Nadu
14	Kailash Chandra Pant	Uttarakhand
15	Khem Raj Sundriyal	Uttarakhand
16	Kollakkayil Devaki Amma G	Kerala
17	Kumarasamy Thangaraj	Tamil Nadu
18	Mahendra Kumar Mishra	Bihar
19	Mir Hajibhai Kasambhai	Gujarat
20	Mohan Nagar	Odisha
21	Naresh Chandra Dev Varma	Madhya Pradesh
22	Nilesh Vinodchandra Mandlewala	Maharashtra
23	Nuruddin Ahmed	Delhi

24	Othuvar Thiruthani Swaminathan	Tamil Nadu
25	Padma Gurmet	Himachal Pradesh
26	Pokhila Lekthepi	Manipur
27	Punnamurthy Natesan	Tamil Nadu
28	R Krishnan	Tamil Nadu
29	Raghupat Singh	Rajasthan
30	Raghuveer Tukaram Khedkar	Maharashtra
31	Rajastapathi Kaliappa Goundar	Tamil Nadu
32	Rama Reddy Mamidi	Andhra Pradesh
33	Ramchandra Godbole and Sunita Godbole	Maharashtra
34	S G Susheelamma	Karnataka
35	Sangyusang S Pongener	Nagaland
36	Shafi Shauq	Jammu & Kashmir
37	Shrirang Devaba Lad	Goa
38	Shyam Sundar	Jharkhand
39	Simanchal Patro	Odisha
40	Suresh Hanagavadi	Karnataka
41	Taga Ram Bheel	Rajasthan
42	Techi Gubin	Arunachal Pradesh
43	Thiruvavarur Bakthavathsalam	Tamil Nadu
44	Vishwa Bandhu	Himachal Pradesh
45	Yumnam Jatra Singh	Manipur

About Padma Awards

- Padma Awards - one of the highest civilian Awards of the country, are conferred in three categories, namely, Padma Vibhushan, Padma Bhushan and Padma Shri
- The awards are announced on the eve of Republic Day every year.
- These Awards are conferred by the President of India at ceremonial functions which are held at Rashtrapati Bhawan usually around March/ April every year.
- Padma Awards were instituted in the year 1954
- Interruption(s) during the years 1978 and 1979 and 1993 to 1997.

77th Republic Day: President approves Gallantry awards to 70 Armed Forces personnel, including six posthumous

- President Smt Droupadi Murmu has approved Gallantry awards to 70 Armed Forces personnel, including six posthumous, on the eve of 77th Republic Day.

BAR TO SENA MEDAL (GALLANTRY)			
1.	3010203A L/HAV SATYA PAL SINGH, SM, 6 RAJPUT	ARMY	BAR TO SM(G)

SL. NO.	RANK & NAME	SERVICE	AWARD
ASHOKA CHAKRA			
1.	29014 GROUP CAPTAIN SHUBHANSHU SHUKLA, FLYING (PILOT)	AIR FORCE	ASHOKA CHAKRA
KIRTI CHAKRA			
1.	IC-81753K MAJOR ARSHDEEP SINGH, ARMD, 1 ASSAM RIF	ARMY	KIRTI

			CHAKRA
2.	JC-415036K NAIB SUBEDAR DOLESHWAR SUBBA, 2 PARA (SF)	ARMY	KIRTI CHAKRA
3.	25284 GROUP CAPTAIN PRASHANTH BALAKRISHNAN NAIR, FLYING(PILOT)	AIR FORCE	KIRTI CHAKRA

SHAURYA CHAKRA			
1	IC-71626F LIEUTENANT COLONEL GHATAGE ADITYA SHRIKUMAR, 21 PARA (SF)	ARMY	SHAURYA CHAKRA
2	IC-83399Y MAJOR ANSHUL BALTOO, JAK LI, 32 ASSAM RIF	ARMY	SHAURYA CHAKRA
3	IC-84586K MAJOR SHIVKANT YADAV, 5 PARA (SF)	ARMY	SHAURYA CHAKRA
4	SS-49451K MAJOR VIVEK, MECH INF, 42 RR	ARMY	SHAURYA CHAKRA
5	SS-49484P MAJOR LEISHANGTHEM DEEPAK SINGH, 11 PARA (SF)	ARMY	SHAURYA CHAKRA
6	IC-85492Y CAPTAIN YOGENDER SINGH THAKUR, 6 PARA (SF)	ARMY	SHAURYA CHAKRA
7	JC-0110806H SUBEDAR P H MOSES, 1 ASSAM RIF	ARMY	SHAURYA CHAKRA
8	15507686K L/DFR BALDEV CHAND, ARMD, 4 RR (POSTHUMOUS)	ARMY	SHAURYA CHAKRA
9	G/38589Y RIFLEMAN MANGLEM SANG VAIPHEI, 3 ASSAM RIF	ARMY	SHAURYA CHAKRA
10	G/5019682A RIFLEMAN DHURBA JYOTI DUTTA, 33 ASSAM RIF	ARMY	SHAURYA CHAKRA
11	08030-Z LIEUTENANT COMMANDER DILNA K	NAVY	SHAURYA CHAKRA
12	09134-H LIEUTENANT COMMANDER ROOPA A	NAVY	SHAURYA CHAKRA
13	129078 ASSISTANT COMMANDANT VIPIN WILSON	MHA	SHAURYA CHAKRA

Wartime Highest Gallantry Awards:

- Param Vir Chakra : India's highest military decoration
- Maha Vir Chakra : The second highest war time gallantry award
- Vir Chakra : Country's third-highest wartime gallantry award

Peacetime Highest Gallantry Awards:

- Ashoka Chakra : The highest military award during peacetime
- Kirti Chakra : The second highest peacetime gallantry award
- Shaurya Chakra : The third highest peacetime gallantry award

Other Awards:

1. Sena Medal
2. Nao Sena Medal
3. Vayu Sena Medal

Order of precedence



Lieutenant Colonel Seeta Ashok Shelke selected for Subhas Chandra Bose National Award for Disaster Management 2026

- Sikkim State Disaster Management Authority (SSDMA) and Lieutenant Colonel Seeta Ashok Shelke, **who led disaster relief operations during the 2024 Wayanad landslide** have been selected for the Subhash Chandra Bose Aapda Prabandhan Puraskar.
- The Central government instituted the award to recognise and honour invaluable contribution and selfless service rendered by individuals and organisations in the field of disaster management.
- The award is announced every year on 23rd January, the birth anniversary of Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose.
- The award carries a cash prize of Rs. 51 lakh and a certificate in case of an institution and Rs. 5 lakh and a certificate in case of an individual.



Eligibility

- Only Indian nationals and Indian institutions are eligible to apply for the award.**
- Institutions, voluntary organisations, corporate entities, academic/research institutions, response/uniformed forces or any other institution may apply as an institution for the award.
- The candidate for the award must have worked in the area of Disaster Management like Prevention, Mitigation, Preparedness, Rescue, Response, Relief, Rehabilitation, Research/ Innovations or Early Warning related work in India.**

Mozambican rights activist Graca Machel to be conferred with Indira Gandhi Peace Prize

- Recently, Mozambican rights activist and humanitarian Graca Machel has been selected for the Indira Gandhi Prize for Peace, Disarmament and Development for 2025.
- Indira Gandhi Peace Prize was instituted in the memory of the former Prime Minister Indira Gandhi by a trust in her name in 1986.**
- It is also known as the Indira Gandhi Prize for Peace, Disarmament, and Development.
- The Indira Gandhi Prize for Peace, Disarmament and Development consists of an award of Rs.10 million/₹1 crore and a trophy with a citation.



It is awarded annually by the Indira Gandhi Memorial Trust to a person or organization without any distinction of nationality, race or religion, in recognition of creative efforts towards:

- Promoting international peace and disarmament, racial equality, and goodwill and harmony among nations;
- Securing economic co-operation and promoting a new international economic order;
- Accelerating the all-round advancement of developing nations;**
- Ensuring that the discoveries of science and modern knowledge are used for the larger good of the human race; and
- Enlarging the scope of freedom and enriching the human spirit...

Jeevan Raksha Padak Awards

- Recently, the President of India has conferred the Jeevan Raksha Padak Series of Awards-2025 to 30 persons.

The President of India has approved the conferment of Jeevan Raksha Padak Series of Awards – 2025 on 30 persons which includes

- Sarvottam Jeevan Raksha Padak to 06,
- Uttam Jeevan Raksha Padak to 06 and
- Jeevan Raksha Padak to 18 persons.



- Six awardees are posthumous.

About Jeevan Raksha Padak Awards

- It is awarded to a person for a meritorious act of human nature in saving the life of a person.

The Jeevan Raksha Padak Award is given in three categories, namely,

- **Sarvottam Jeevan Raksha Padak:** It is awarded for conspicuous courage in saving life under circumstances of very great danger to the life of the rescuer.
- **Uttam Jeevan Raksha Padam:** It is awarded for courage and promptitude in saving life under circumstances of great danger to the life of the rescuer.
- **Jeevan Raksha Padak:** It is awarded for courage and promptitude in saving life under circumstances of grave bodily injury to the rescuer.

Jeevan Raksha Padak Awards Eligibility

- Persons of all walks of life are eligible for these awards. The award can also be conferred posthumously.
- It is presented to the awardees by the respective Union Ministries/Organizations/State Government to which the awardee belongs.

Jeevan Raksha Padak Awards Features

- Its nominations are invited annually from States/UTs and Union Ministries.
- **Final approval is given by the Prime Minister and the President of India.**
- **Award:** The decoration of the award consists of a Medal, Certificate, along with a one-time monetary allowance: Sarvottam Jeevan Raksha Padak (₹2 lakh), Uttam Jeevan Raksha Padam (₹1.5 lakh) and Jeevan Raksha (₹1 lakh).

Veer Gatha 5.0 Awards Honour Young Voices of Patriotism

- Raksha Rajya Mantri Shri Sanjay Seth and the Minister of State for Education and Skill Development & Entrepreneurship (I/C), Shri Jayant Chaudhary, felicitated the Super-100 winners of Veer Gatha 5.0 in New Delhi .
- **Each winner was presented with a cash prize of Rs. 10,000, a medal and a certificate.**
- **Project Veer Gatha was initiated in 2021 as part of the Azadi Ka Amrit Mahotsav to mark India's 75th year of Independence.**
- These Super-100 are among the special guests witnessed the Republic Day Parade at Kartavya Path on January 26, 2026.



Sukhatme National Award in Statistics – 2026

- **Sukhatme National Award in Statistics has been instituted by Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation** to recognize the exceptional/ outstanding contribution made by the individuals in terms of high-quality research work, to improve the system of official statistics.
- **This prestigious award is given in alternate years since the year 2000** to eminent Indian Statisticians of the age 45 years and above for their Lifetime Contributions and Achievements in the field of Statistics.
- Nominations have been invited online for Sukhatme National Award in Statistics – 2026 through the National Awards Portal i.e., <https://www.awards.gov.in>.
- The eligible candidates can nominate themselves or the names can also be proposed by institution.
- **The Award will be presented during Statistics Day function on 29th June 2026.** The Award carries a citation, shawl and memento.



Centre for Development of Telematics (C-DOT) receives SKOCH Award 2025 during the 104th SKOCH Summit for its Cell Broadcast Solution

- Centre for Development of Telematics (C-DOT), the premier Telecom R&D centre of the Government of India, has been conferred the "SKOCH Award-2025" for its Cell Broadcast Solution (CBS).
- **The award ceremony was held as part of the 104th SKOCH Summit on the theme "Resourcing Viksit Bharat".**
- C-DOT is a premier research and development centre, under the aegis of Department of Telecommunications, Government of India, for telecommunication technologies.



Lt Sudha Becomes First Northeasterner to Win NCC Gold

- **Lieutenant K M Sudha has created history by becoming the first individual from India's Northeast to secure a gold medal** at a prestigious National Cadet Corps officers' training event.
- The National Cadet Corps functions under the Ministry of Defence.
- Officer Training Academy, Gwalior, conducts NCC officer training events.

Tamil Nadu Launches State Award for Non-Hindi Language Writers

- A new annual state-sponsored literary award aimed at recognising outstanding works in major Indian languages other than Hindi.
- **The award is named "Semmozhi Illakiya Virudhu (Classical Language Literary Award)"** and is intended to honour high-quality literary works in non-Hindi languages with a national-level character.
- The award will carry a cash prize of ₹5 lakh for each language.

The awards will be conferred for the best works in seven Indian languages:

- Tamil
- Telugu
- Kannada
- Malayalam
- Odiya
- Bengali
- Marathi



Ilaiyaraaja to be honoured with Padmapani Award at Ajanta-Ellora Film Festival

- The prestigious 'Padmapani Award' of the 11th Ajanta-Ellora International Film Festival has been announced for this year's veteran music composer Ilaiyaraaja, in recognition of his unparalleled contribution to Indian cinema.
- **The award comprises a Padmapani memento, a citation certificate, and a cash prize of 2 lakh rupees.**
- The 11th Ajanta-Ellora International Film Festival will be held from 28 January to 1 February at Mahatma Gandhi Mission, Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar.
- **The Ajanta-Ellora International Film Festival is being organised with the support of the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, Government of India, and the Department of Cultural Affairs, Government of Maharashtra, with co-presentation by the National Film Development Corporation (NFDC) and the Maharashtra Film, Stage and Cultural Development Corporation, Government of Maharashtra.**



National Awards To Honour Model Youth Gram Sabha Winners

- The Ministry of Panchayati Raj in collaboration with the Ministry of Education and the Ministry of Tribal Affairs, is jointly organizing a National Award Ceremony to felicitate the winners of the Model Youth Gram Sabha.



About Model Youth Gram Sabha

- It is a simulated forum for School Children to participate in mock Gram Sabha sessions.
- **Purpose:** It is a pioneering initiative to strengthen Janbhagidari and promote participatory local governance by engaging students in simulated Gram Sabha sessions.
- It is an **initiative based on the Model UN – an educational simulation of the United Nations** – in schools across the country.
- **Implementation:** It will be rolled out across more than 1,000 schools nationwide, including Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalayas, Eklatva Model Residential Schools (EMRSs), and State Government Schools.

Republic Day Parade 2026: Best Marching Contingents and Tableaux announced

- The results of the Best Marching Contingents and Best Tableaux of the Republic Day Parade 2026 have been announced.
- Among the three Services, the **Indian Navy has been adjudged the Best Marching Contingent.**
- Delhi Police won the award in the category of Central Armed Police Forces and other Auxiliary Forces.

In the States and Union Territories category,

- **Maharashtra secured first place for its tableau Ganeshotsav: A Symbol of Aatmanirbharta.**
- Jammu and Kashmir stood second for Handicrafts and Folk Dances of Jammu & Kashmir, followed by Kerala in third place for Water Metro and 100 Per Cent Digital Literacy: Aatmanirbhar Kerala for Aatmanirbhar Bharat.

- **Among Central Ministries and Departments, the Ministry of Culture won for its tableau Vande Mataram – The Soul Cry of a Nation.**

In the tableaux category:

- Gujarat secured first place with Mantra of Swadeshi – Self-Reliance: Vande Mataram, followed by Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan.
- **Special prizes were awarded to the Central Public Works Department for Vande Mataram – Commemoration of 150 Years, and to the dance group for Vande Mataram: The Eternal Resonance of India.**



The Popular Choice Awards, based on an online poll conducted on the MyGov portal, were also announced.

- The Assam Regiment was voted the Best Marching Contingent among the Services,
- while the CRPF topped the Central Armed Police Forces and Auxiliary Forces category.
- **The Department of School Education and Literacy won the Popular Choice Award among Central Ministries and Departments for its tableau National Education Policy 2020: Rocketing Indian School Education on the Path to Viksit Bharat.**



SAIL earns “great place to work” certification for third consecutive time

- Steel Authority of India Limited (SAIL), a Maharatna and India’s largest public sector steelmaker has earned the coveted ‘Great Place to Work’ certification for February 2026 to February 2027, straight third time in a row
- The Great Place to Work Institute, a global authority on workplace culture, honors organizations that deliver exceptional employee experiences through a rigorous evaluation process.

The Wings India 2026 Awards were announced

- The country’s premier aviation event, hosted by the Ministry of Civil Aviation in collaboration with FICCI and the Airports Authority of India (AAI).
- The awards recognised excellence across airports, airlines, service providers, manufacturing, innovation and state governments
- Delhi International Airport Limited - Best Airport of the Year,
- Kempegowda International Airport, Bengaluru, - Best Airport handling over 25 million passengers annually (MPPA).
- Pune Airport took the top honour in the 10–25 MPPA category, and Lucknow International Airport Limited won in the 5–10 MPPA segment.
- Air India Express was awarded for Domestic Connectivity,
- Star Air, operated by Ghodawat Enterprises Pvt. Ltd., won for Regional/UDAN Connectivity
- InterGlobe Aviation Limited was recognised as the Best Aviation Service Provide
- Air India Limited also received awards for Aviation Skills & Training,
- ideaForge Technology Ltd. won the Drones category.
- Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) was honoured as Best Contributor to Atmanirbhar Bharat.
- The Airports Authority of India (AAI) was named Innovation Champion, while Delhi International Airport Limited received the Sustainability Champion award.
- States recognised for aviation leadership
- In the states category, Andhra Pradesh was awarded Best State with a Dedicated Outlook for the Aviation Sector.
- The award for Best State for Promotion of Aviation Ecosystem was jointly given to Telangana, Uttarakhand and Gujarat.
- Assam won the award for Most Proactive State under RCS–UDAN Priority Areas,
- while Uttar Pradesh and Bihar were joint winners in the Most Proactive State under RCS–UDAN Non-Priority Areas category.
- Karnataka and Maharashtra were jointly recognised as State Champions in Aviation.



NEWS IN SHORT

- **Akashvani’s News Service Division has received the Media Award 2025 in the Radio (Electronic) category for the Best Campaign on Voters’ Education and Awareness.**

International

Toby Kiers Wins Tyler Prize for Mycorrhizal Research

- American evolutionary biologist "Toby Kiers" has been awarded the Tyler Prize for Environmental Achievement, often referred to as the Nobel for the environment. which is accompanied by a reward of \$250,000 (€215,000).
- The award recognises her pioneering work in revealing the ecological and climatic importance of mycorrhizal fungi.
- The award established in 1973 and administered by the University of Southern California
- It has honored dozens of prominent figures, such as the British primatologist Jane Goodall, who died on October 1, 2025, and the American climatologist Michael Mann.



Golden Globe 2026

- The 83rd edition Golden Globes returned in 2026
- 'One Battle After Another' has emerged as the most-nominated film at the 83rd Golden Globe Awards earning nine nominations
- Best Motion Picture – Drama:** Hamnet
- Best Motion Picture – Musical/Comedy:** One Battle After Another
- Best Motion Picture – Animated:** Kpop Demon Hunters
- Best Motion Picture – Non English language:** The Secret Agent, Brazil
- Best Actress in a Motion Picture, Drama:** Jessie Buckley, Hamnet
- Best Actor in a Motion Picture, Drama:** Wagner Moura, The Secret Agent
- Best Actress – Musical or Comedy:** Rose Byrne, If I Had Legs I'd Kick You
- Best Actor – Musical or Comedy:** Timothée Chalamet, Marty Supreme
- Best Original Song, Motion Picture:** "Golden" from KPop Demon Hunters
- Best Television Series, Drama:** The Pitt
- Best Television Series, Musical or Comedy:** The Studio
- Best Actor in a Drama Series:** Noah Wyle, The Pitt



The 31st annual Critics Choice Awards 2026

- The 31st Annual Critics Choice Awards 2026 took place in California on January 4, 2026

Film

- Best Picture:** One Battle After Another (Warner Bros.) (WINNER)
- Best Director:** Paul Thomas Anderson - One Battle After Another (WINNER)
- Best Actor:** Timothee Chalamet - Marty Supreme (WINNER)
- Best Actress:** Jessie Buckley - Hamnet (WINNER)
- Best Young Performer:** Miles Caton - Sinners (WINNER)



Television

- Best Drama Series:** The Pitt (WINNER)
- Best Comedy Series:** The Studio (WINNER)
- Best Limited Series:** Adolescence (WINNER)
- Best Actor, Drama Series:** Noah Wyle - The Pitt (WINNER)
- Best Actress, Drama Series:** Rhea Seehorn - Pluribus (WINNER)

Italy Honours Shrinivas Dempo with Prestigious Civilian Award

- Italy has conferred one of its most respected civilian honours, the **Cavaliere dell'Ordine della Stella d'Italia (Knight of the Order of the Star of Italy)**, on Goa-based industrialist Shrinivas Dempo in recognition of his services to Italian citizens and bilateral interests in India.



- The Cavaliere dell'Ordine della Stella d'Italia is a prestigious Italian civilian decoration awarded to individuals who have promoted friendly relations with Italy or contributed significantly to its international cooperation.
- **Shrinivas Dempo serves as the honorary vice consul of Italy in Goa.**

Nalini Joshi Named New South Wales Scientist of the Year

- Renowned Indian-origin mathematician Professor Nalini Joshi has been honoured as the 2025 New South Wales (NSW) Scientist of the Year, becoming the first mathematician to receive the state's premier science accolade.
- The recognition was announced at the NSW Premier's Prizes for Science & Engineering ceremony held at Government House in Sydney.
- The award comes with a trophy and a AUD 60,000 cash prize, cementing Joshi's place among the most impactful scientists in Australia.



Tunisian filmmaker Zoubeir Jlassi win world's largest AI Film Award for his film Lily & receives one-million-dollar prize

- Tunisian filmmaker Zoubeir Jlassi has won the world's largest AI Film Award for his film Lily.
- Received a one-million-dollar prize during the 1 Billion Followers Summit 2026 in Dubai.
- The award is organised in collaboration with Google Gemini and was presented at the fourth edition of the summit, which is being held in Dubai from January 9 to 11 under the theme 'Content for Good'.



Oscars 2025: Indian Films Enter Best Picture Eligibility List

- The 98th Academy Awards, also known as Oscars 2026, have recognized five Indian films as eligible for the prestigious Best Picture category.

The four Indian films eligible for Best Picture consideration at Oscars 2026 include:

- **Kantara: A Legend – Chapter 1** (Kannada), directed by Rishabh Shetty
- **Tanvi The Great** (Hindi), directed by Anupam Kher
- **Mahavatar Narsimha** (Multilingual animated feature)
- **Tourist Family** (Tamil), by debut filmmaker Abishan Jeevinth
- Additionally, **Sister Midnight**, a Hindi-UK co-production starring Radhika Apte, is also included.

Indian Army officer from Bengaluru wins UN Secretary General's Award 2025

- An Indian army officer from Bengaluru, Major Swathi Shantha Kumar, has won the UN Secretary General's Award 2025 for her project Equal Partners, Lasting Peace.
- **Major Swathi is currently serving on an United Nations Mission in South Sudan (UNMISS).**
- This prestigious award recognises initiatives that advance gender parity and promote gender-responsive peacekeeping in alignment with the UN mandate.



SVIMS students secure place in Guinness Book of Records

- Tirupati Sri Venkateswara Institute of Medical Sciences (SVIMS) students **Sheikh Ghouse Basha and Jangam Shruti secured a place in the Guinness Book of Records for being part of the Kuchipudi Kalavaibhavam-2** event conducted recently by Bharat Arts Academy in Hyderabad.
- Their names were recorded in the Guinness Book of Records due to their participation in the largest Kuchipudi lesson titles' demonstration, which saw 4,608 participants sharing the stage.

14th edition of the Ahmedabad International Flower Show – Gujarat

- The exhibition themed Bharat Ek Gatha, showcases country's rich and diverse cultural heritage.
- The **flower show will continue till 22nd of this month.**
- The event gained international attention after setting two Guinness **World Records for the world's largest flower mandala and the world's largest flower portrait**, the latter depicting national leader Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel.
- The achievements **marked the third consecutive year the Ahmedabad Flower Show** has entered the Guinness World Records, following earlier records for the world's longest flower structure in 2024 and the world's largest flower bouquet in 2025.



NHAI sets two Guinness World Records for longest & highest bituminous concrete laying

- **National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) has achieved two Guinness World Records for laying Bituminous Concrete** on the Vanavolu-Vankarakunta section of the six-lane Bengaluru-



Kadapa-Vijayawada Economic Corridor.

- The records include around 29 lane kilometre, the longest distance of **Bituminous Concrete laid continuously within 24 hours, and over ten thousand metric tonnes**, the highest quantity of Bituminous Concrete laid continuously within 24 hours.
- 343-kilometre-long Bengaluru-Kadapa-Vijayawada Economic Corridor will strengthen inter-state connectivity between Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh.
- It will also support trade, tourism, and regional economic growth through faster, safer, and uninterrupted mobility..
- **Two more Guinness World Record attempts are currently underway on the Vanavolu-Vankarakunta-Odulapalle section of NH-544G.**

NHAI creates four Guinness World Records in Andhra Pradesh

- The National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) in association with concessionaire M/s Rajpath Infracon Private Limited successfully created four Guinness World Records:



On 6th January 2026, NHAI made two Guinness World Records near Puttaparthi, Andhra Pradesh.

- First, was the record for the longest continuous laying of Bituminous Concrete, covering 28.89 lane km or 3-lane wide 9.63 km long section within 24 hours.
- The second record was created for continuous laying of highest quantity of 10,655 metric tons Bituminous Concrete in 24 hours.

Pariksha Pe Charcha 2026 records over 4 crore registrations, surpassing last year's Guinness World Record

- In the previous edition, Pariksha Pe Charcha was recognised by Guinness World Records for recording 3.53 crore registrations, last year.
- PPC 2026 will be held in January 2026
- Students from Classes 6 to 12, along with teachers and parents, are eligible to participate.
- Pariksha Pe Charcha, launched in 2018, is a flagship initiative that allows students to directly engage with the Prime Minister. The programme focuses on addressing issues such as exam pressure, mental health concerns, academic stress and post-result anxiety.



Anna Chakra Named Finalist for 2026 Franz Edelman Award

- The Department of Food and Public Distribution (DFPD) is among the six finalists for the prestigious 2026 Franz Edelman Award for its initiative, "Anna Chakra" an operations research (O.R.) based decision support solution that strengthens India's Public Distribution System by optimizing state-specific logistics.
- **Developed in partnership with the United Nations World Food Programme (WFP) in India and the Indian Institute of Technology Delhi.**
- **Widely regarded as the "Nobel Prize of Operations Research and Analytics"**, the Franz Edelman Award recognizes the world's most impactful, high-value applications of advanced analytics.
- The winner of the 2026 Franz Edelman Award will be announced at the INFORMS Analytics+ Conference in National Harbor, Maryland, USA, from April 12–14, 2026.



Indian Doctor Wins Wiley Research Heroes Prize 2025

- Chandrakant Lahariya, former staff member of World Health Organisation (WHO), has won the Wiley Research Heroes Prize 2025.
- **He is credited to be the first and only Indian so far to have won this International Wiley Prize**
- The Wiley Research Heroes Prize recognizes researchers worldwide who ensure that research is inclusive, innovative, and impactful.
- **Dr. Lahariya won the award in the 'Impact Beyond Academia' category** for his sustained contribution to public health policy and implementation.



APO National Award Honours Bakul Limbasiya for Productivity Leadership

- Bakul Limbasiya, founder of Bhathwari Technologies, has been conferred the APO National Award, recognising his outstanding contribution to productivity, innovation, and leadership in India.



- The APO National Award is instituted by the Asian Productivity Organization and administered in India by the National Productivity Council under the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade.
- Asian Productivity Organization is a Tokyo-based intergovernmental body.

State

Ladakh

Spituk Gustor Festival begins in Ladakh

- In Ladakh, the two-day-long annual monastic festival of Spituk Monastery – Spituk Gustor – begins.
- This festival is observed after a week-long period of prayers and rituals in honour of God and Goddess for world peace, prosperity and triumph over evil.
- It is marked as the end of the first phase of the coldest and harsh climatic weather of Ladakh.
- **Spituk Gustor is the first festival of Monasteries among the 16 monastic festivals observed with different sacred masked dances, rituals and prayers during different seasons of the year.**



Zaskar River

- **The much-awaited Chadar trek on the frozen Zaskar River in Ladakh has been deferred due to inadequate ice formation,** disappointing trekkers eager to participate in the adventure sport.

About Zaskar River

- It is a major left-bank tributary of the Indus River, flowing entirely within the union territory of Ladakh in northern India.
- It drains the remote Zaskar Valley in the northwestern Himalayas.



Course:

- The **Zaskar River starts high in the Himalayas.**
- The **Zaskar River has two main branches**; one is Doda, with main source near Pansi-La Pass, and the other branch is formed by the Kargyag River (source near Shingo La) and the Tsarap River (source near Baralacha La).
- **The river meets the Indus River near Nimmu of the Ladakh region at an elevation of about 3,100 meters.**



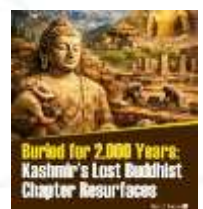
Lieutenant Governor Kavinder Gupta launches Ladakh Sports Policy 2025 in Leh

- It is the first Sport Policy of Ladakh, **since it was separated in 2019 as a Union Territory from the erstwhile from Jammu and Kashmir state**
- It aims to take Ladakh's sports ecosystem to the next level through comprehensive roadmaps.
- The **Sports Policy provides a 4 per cent reservation in government jobs.**
- The Sports Policy mandate to establish Ladakh Sports Council, which will work with sports associations to Coordinate Infrastructure, Coaching, and financial support.

Jammu & Kashmir

Zehanpura Stupa

- The 2,000-year-old Buddhist stupas and monastic complex at Zehanpura in Baramulla, Kashmir, dating to the Kushan period, have been scientifically excavated.
- The **Zehanpura site is a large Kushan-era Buddhist complex comprising multiple stupas, apsidal chaityas (prayer halls), viharas (monk residences), urban-type settlements, and artefacts.**
- Located along the ancient Silk Route corridor linking Kashmir with Gandhara (Afghanistan–Pakistan region)



History:

- The site dates to the Kushan period (1st–3rd century CE)
- Kashmir was a major centre of Buddhist learning during this time under rulers like Kanishka and Huvishka
- Buddhism in Kashmir began earlier under Ashoka (3rd century BCE) and flourished through Mahayana Buddhism, which later spread to Central Asia and China
- Zehanpora was likely part of the Gandhara Buddhist network, a trans-regional system of monasteries, trade routes and learning centres

ICAR-CTCRI commercialises purple taro variety

- The ICAR-Central Tuber Crops Research Institute (CTCRI) has commercialised a purple taro variety **named “Jamuni”**; which is characterised by a high anthocyanin content.
- **The variety is root vegetable and carries high anthocyanin content**, which gives the tubers their purple colour and potentially enhanced antioxidant properties (anthocyanins are plant pigments associated with health benefits).

**Tawi Boating Festival begins in Jammu**

- The Tawi Boat/Boating Festival has commenced in Jammu city on the banks of the Tawi Riverfront.
- This event is a multi-day recreational festival featuring boat rides, cultural activities, and community engagement along the river's artificial lake/riverfront area.

**Punjab****Ludhiana's PAU makes history: Only Indian state agri-varsity to join BRICS Network University**

- The Punjab Agricultural University, Ludhiana, has been formally **included in the BRICS Network University under the thematic area of Sustainable Agriculture and Food Security**.
- **The expansion of the BRICS Network University was approved by the BRICS International Governing Board in May 2025**, leading to the creation of new thematic clusters, including Sustainable Agriculture and Food Security.
- Notably, PAU is the only state agricultural university from the country to be selected in the network.

Punjab celebrates 'Dhiyan Di Lohri' to honour 5100 newborn girls

- In Punjab, as a reflection of the positive transformation in society's mindset towards daughters, 'Dhiyan Di Lohri' (Lohri of Daughters) was celebrated in a Jalandhar village where 5100 newborn girls were honoured
- **The objective of the celebrations is to further strengthen the National movement of 'Beti Bachao-Beti Padhao'.**

Punjab Government Introduces Mukhya Mantri Sehat Yojana for Free Cashless Medical Care

- The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government in Punjab has rolled out the Mukh Mantri Sehat Yojana (MMSY), a universal healthcare scheme that provides cashless medical treatment of up to Rs 10 lakh per family per year. With no exclusions, the scheme aims to bring all residents of the state under a single healthcare coverage framework.
- Families possessing an Aadhaar card and Voter ID are eligible for enrolment, while children below the age of 18 are covered through the voter identity documents of their parents or guardians.
- **The scheme is being implemented through a hybrid financial model. Insurance coverage of Rs 1 lakh per family is provided through United India Insurance Company**, while the remaining coverage up to Rs 10 lakh is funded directly by the Punjab government through the State Health Agency.

**Punjab Police launches 'Operation Parhar' to make state gangster-free**

- Punjab Police launched 'Operation Parhar' to dismantle the gangster network in Punjab to make the state gangster-free. 2,000 teams involving 12,000 police officials have started raids across Punjab.
- The complete ecosystem involving financing, logistics, safe houses, weapon supply chains and communication chains will be busted.
- Launching an Anti-Gangster Helpline Number- 93946-93946, he called upon the citizens to inform about gangster activities in their areas to make Punjab a safe state.

Delhi

New Delhi World Book Fair 2026 to be held from Jan 10 to Jan 18

- The **53rd edition of the New Delhi World Book Fair 2026** will be held from 10th to 18 January at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi.
- The **nine-day book fair will attract participation from over one thousand publishers** representing more than 35 countries.
- **Theme** – Indian Military History: Valour and Wisdom @ 75.



Delhi Chief Minister to hold 'Lunch Pe Charcha' on January 11 ahead of National Youth Day

- Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta is set to hold an interaction titled 'Lunch Pe Charcha', with youth on January 11, a day before the National Youth Day.
- The **event will also feature an open discussion on problems and complaints** faced by young people in the past 11 years.



PM Modi Inaugurates Exhibition of Sacred Piprahwa Buddha Relics

- The Prime Minister of India inaugurated "The Light and The Lotus: Relics of the Awakened One", an international exposition of the sacred Piprahwa relics associated with Lord Buddha in New Delhi.
- The **event coincided with the recent repatriation of priceless Buddhist relics that had been taken out of India** during the colonial period and were nearly auctioned abroad.
- **Piprahwa relics were excavated in 1898 by William Claxton Peppé from a stupa at Piprahwa**; they include 349 gemstones, reliquaries, caskets, and bone/ash believed to be of Buddha.
- **Under the Indian Treasure Trove Act, 1878**, most relics were claimed by the British; some remained with the Peppé family for 127+ years.
- **In 2025, Sotheby's Hong Kong listed them for auction (~\$100 million).** India intervened via the Ministry of Culture and Archaeological Survey of India.
- **Godrej Group purchased and returned the relics to India**; they are loaned to the National Museum for five years.



Delhi to Declare Rabies a 'Notifiable Disease'

- In a significant move to strengthen disease surveillance and ensure timely reporting and treatment, **the Delhi government is set to declare human rabies a notifiable disease under the Epidemic Diseases Act.**
- So far, 20 states have declared human rabies a notifiable disease, as per the official website of the Ministry of Health & Family Welfare's National Rabies Control Program.

Notifiable Disease

- A disease that healthcare providers are legally required to report to public health authorities in India.
- Usually infectious diseases with outbreak potential, high mortality risk, or requiring urgent investigation (e.g., dengue, TB, COVID-19).
- Used for monitoring, outbreak prevention, and control.
- The list varies by state, as state governments issue notifications.

Rabies

- **Spread via saliva of infected animals, the virus enters peripheral nerves** → brain/spinal cord.
- **Symptoms appear after ~3 months** (may be days to >6 months): fever → hydrophobia, excess salivation, hallucinations, paralysis.
- **Almost always fatal after symptoms**, but preventable by post-exposure vaccination after bites/scratches/saliva exposure from animals (dogs, cats, monkeys, bats).

Union Ministry of Culture and the International Buddhist Confederation will jointly organise the **2nd Global Buddhist Summit (GBS)** in New Delhi

- The International Buddhist Confederation (IBC), in collaboration with the Ministry of Culture, Government of India, will organise the 2nd Global Buddhist Summit (GBS) on 24th and 25th January 2026 at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi.
- **Theme:** Collective Wisdom, United Voice, and Mutual Coexistence



About the 1st Global Buddhist Summit

- The 1st Global Buddhist Summit was held on 20–21 April 2023 in New Delhi, with the Hon'ble Prime Minister of India as the Chief Guest.

About the International Buddhist Confederation (IBC)

- The International Buddhist Confederation (IBC) is a global Buddhist umbrella organisation headquartered in New Delhi under the aegis of the Ministry of Culture, Government of India.
- **Established in 2011 under the patronage of the supreme Buddhist religious hierarchy, the IBC has a global membership of over 300 monastic and lay organisations.**
- United by the motto "Collective Wisdom, United Voice,"

PM Vishwakarma Haat 2026 to be Organised at Dilli Haat, New Delhi from 18th to 31st January

- The **Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSME)** will organise PM Vishwakarma Haat 2026 at Dilli Haat, INA, in the national capital from January 18 to 31
- **The theme** "Vishwakarma Ka Abhiyaan, Viksit Bharat Ka Nirman".
- PM Vishwakarma Haat 2026 aims to celebrate India's rich heritage of traditional skills while enabling artisans to directly exhibit and market their products to buyers, stakeholders and the general public.



PM Vishwakarma Scheme :

- **Type:** Central Sector Scheme (Ministry of MSME)
- **Objective:** Support traditional artisans; preserve Guru–Shishya parampara (family-based skills)
- **Benefits:** Skill training, market linkage, digital incentive support, financial assistance
- **Duration:** 5 years (2023–24 to 2027–28)

Uttar Pradesh

India's First Government AI Clinic Launched at GIMS Greater Noida

- The Government Institute of Medical Sciences (GIMS) in Greater Noida has inaugurated the country's first artificial intelligence clinic.
- This is the country's first government-based AI clinic and experts consider it to be a major and significant step in integrating AI in the healthcare sector.
- The clinic will use artificial intelligence and genetic screening to detect and treat serious diseases such as cancer and heart, kidney and liver ailments at an early stage.



One time three years relaxation in upper age limit for UP Police and PAC constable recruitment

- The state government has given a one-time three-year relaxation in the **upper age limit for the proposed direct recruitment of constables, civil police, and equivalent positions in the police force in 2025.**

- As per the government order, this age relaxation will be provided once to candidates of all categories participating in the recruitment process for the posts of Constable Civil Police (Male/Female), Constable PAC/Armed Police (Male), Constable Special Security Force (Male), Female Constable for Women Battalion, Constable Mounted Police (Male) and Jail Warder (Male and Female).

UP govt to establish state-of-the-art digital libraries in Gram Panchayat Secretariats

- In Uttar Pradesh, the state government has decided to establish state-of-the-art digital libraries in Gram Panchayat Secretariats, **with a target to complete the procurement of IT equipment in all districts by January 30.**
- An amount of approximately Rs 4 lakh will be spent on each library. This includes Rs 2 lakh for books, Rs 1.30 lakh for IT equipment and Rs 70,000 for modern furniture.



Uttar Pradesh to Host Regional AI Impact Conference 2026

- IndiaAI and the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), in collaboration with the Government of Uttar Pradesh, are set to host the Uttar Pradesh Regional AI Impact Conference 2026 in Lucknow on 12–13 January 2026.
- The Uttar Pradesh Regional AI Impact Conference 2026 marks a precursor to the India AI Impact Summit 2026, scheduled to be held in New Delhi, India from February 16–20, 2026,** and is part of the national series of eight Regional AI Impact Conferences being organised across the country.



Uttar Pradesh foundation day

- On 24 January 1950, the United Provinces was renamed as Uttar Pradesh.
- The initiative to celebrate 'Uttar Pradesh Day' was taken by the then Governor Ram Naik and this event has been celebrated for three days every year since 2018.
- Theme** 'Developed India-Developed Uttar Pradesh'.
- A special exhibition and craft fair themed 'Viksit Bharat — Viksit Uttar Pradesh' organised.
- State Animal Of Uttar Pradesh** – Barasingha
- State Bird Of Uttar Pradesh** – Sarus Crane
- State Fish Of Uttar Pradesh** – Chital
- State Tree Of Uttar Pradesh** – Ashoka
- Chief Minister** : Yogi Adityanath
- Governor** : Anandiben Patel
- The state government will confer the 'Uttar Pradesh Gaurav Samman' award on six individuals from the fields of music, agriculture and education during the state foundation day .



The awardees include :

Five individuals were honoured with Rs 11 lakh, an angavastram, a memento, and a citation.

- Astronaut and Group Captain Shubhanshu Shukla;
- Alakh Pandey of Physics Wallah for his contributions to education, entrepreneurship and self-reliance;
- Rashmi Arya for education and innovation;
- Hariom Panwar for literature;
- and Sudhanshu Singh for contributions to the agriculture sector.

Lucknow to host three-day 86th All India Presiding Officers' Conference

- The state is set to host the 86th All India Presiding Officers' Conference (AIPOC) and 62nd Conference of Secretaries of Legislative Assemblies and Legislative Councils of India from January 19 to 21, 2026, which is being hosted by the Uttar Pradesh



Legislative Assembly at UP Vidhan Bhavan.

- **Lok Sabha speaker Om Birla will also address the inaugural session.**
- The conference will conclude on January 21 with the valedictory address of the Lok Sabha speaker.
- The 86th AIPOC will be preceded by the 62nd Conference of Secretaries of Legislative Bodies in India on January 19.
- **Themes to be discussed** at the meet are 'Levering Technology for Transparent, Efficient and Citizen Centric Legislative Processes,' 'Capacity Building of Legislators to Increase Efficiency and Strengthen Democratic Governance,' and 'Accountability of Legislature towards the Public.'

UP Govt launches 'One District, One Cuisine'

- Union Home Minister Amit Shah launched the 'One District, One Cuisine' (ODOC) initiative in Uttar Pradesh, aimed at giving a distinct identity to the traditional food and beverage specialities of each district, on the lines of the state's flagship 'One District, One Product' (ODOP) programme.
- **The initiative is expected to benefit traditional halwais, small food entrepreneurs and local workers by helping their signature dishes reach wider and even global markets, while also creating sustainable livelihood opportunities at the grassroots level.**



UP Govt Approves Cashless Medical Treatment for Teachers, Staff

- The Uttar Pradesh Cabinet approved a major welfare decision to **provide cashless medical treatment to nearly 15 lakh teachers and non-teaching staff, as well as their dependent family members, associated with the Basic and Secondary Education Departments.**
- The scheme, announced by the CM on Teachers' Day in 2025, has now received formal Cabinet approval.
- **Under the scheme, beneficiaries will be eligible for cashless in-patient (IPD) treatment at government hospitals as well as empanelled private hospitals, on the lines of the Ayushman Bharat scheme.**



Eligible:

- Teachers in government & aided schools (Secondary Education).
- Dependents included.
- Teachers, Shiksha Mitras, special educators, instructors under Basic Education Council (aided/self-financed).
- KGBV wardens & teachers (full/part-time).
- PM Poshan Yojana cooks — all with dependents.

Not Eligible:

- Those already covered under any central/state health scheme (incl. PM-JAY or CM Jan Arogya Abhiyan).

UP Makes Aadhaar Authentication Mandatory for Property Registration from Feb 1, 2026

- Aadhaar-based authentication will be compulsory for all property registration procedures in Sub-Registrar Offices in Uttar Pradesh from 1 February 2026.
- Authentication Methods: Identity of buyers, sellers and witnesses will be verified electronically using e- KYC, biometric authentication and e- signatures linked to Aadhaar.
- Objective: The initiative is designed to prevent fraudulent property registrations, impersonation and forged documents while improving the credibility of property records.



Madhya Pradesh

NDSA Flags Safety Lapses at Bargi Dam

- Recently, the National Dam Safety Authority has issued a show-cause notice to the Narmada Valley Development Authority over safety concerns at Bargi Dam.

About Bargi Dam

- It is a major multi-purpose dam, serving irrigation, water supply, and power generation.
- It is on the Narmada river.
- Location:** It is located in the state of Madhya Pradesh.
- Out of 30 major dam projects on Narmada river, it is one of the first completed dams on the river.
- Bargi dam construction started in 1974 and completed in 1990.
- It was constructed as part of the Narmada Valley Development Project.**
- It was classified as Safety Category III, meaning “minor deficiencies,” during pre-monsoon and post-monsoon inspections.



What is the National Dam Safety Authority?

- It is a statutory body set up by the Central Government under the Dam Safety Act, 2021.
- It operates with a clear mandate to regulate, oversee, and inspect dams.
- It is headed by a chairman and assisted by five members to lead its five wings – policy and research, technical, regulation, disaster and resilience, and administration and finance.
- Headquarter:** New Delhi

Indore Declares Bhagirathpura Waterborne Outbreak an Epidemic

- More than half of the ground water samples taken from multiple borewells in Indore's Bhagirathpura locality have tested positive for E coli bacteria.

Escherichia coli

- It is commonly known as E. coli, is a type of bacteria that can be found in the intestines of humans and animals.
- A rod-shaped bacterium of the Enterobacteriaceae family.
- Most strains are harmless, but some cause diarrhea, UTIs, respiratory infections, and pneumonia. Spread via contaminated food, water, or fecal contact.
- Disease-causing strains produce Shiga toxin, damaging the intestine → diarrhea.



Mahakaleshwar Temple

- The Supreme Court recently did not entertain a petition challenging the practice of 'VIP darshan' at the famed Shri Mahakaleshwar temple in Ujjain, observing that the court is not meant to play the role of a gatekeeper on who enters a temple and when.
- It is a Hindu temple located on the banks of the River Shipra at Ujjain in Madhya Pradesh.**
- It is dedicated to Lord Shiva. It is one of the 12 Jyotirlingas in India.
- The history of Mahakaleshwar Temple dates back to ancient times, with references to the temple found in various Hindu scriptures and texts.
- The temple finds mention in the Puranas.
- The renowned poet Kalidas also mentioned this temple in his creations.
- The current structure of the temple was built in the 18th century by the Maratha ruler Ranoji Shinde.**
- However, the temple has been destroyed and rebuilt several times throughout history.
- The architecture of the temple shows the influence of Maratha, Bhumija, and Chalukya styles of structural design.



Madhya Pradesh Declares 2026 as Year of Agriculture

Some initiatives:

- Agriculture budget increased to over ₹27,000 crore in 2024–25.



- e-Mandi implemented in 259 markets with 40 lakh farmer registrations.
- **Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar Kamdhenu Yojana focuses on dairy expansion.**

Bihar

Bihar's Motihari - world's largest Shivling installed at Virat Ramayan Mandir

- The installation of the Sahasralingam—described as the world's largest Shivling—in Motihari took place at the under-construction temple complex in Kathwalia village of Kalyanpur block on Magh Krishna Chaturdashi, an auspicious date in the Hindu calendar.
- Carved from a single piece of black granite, the monolith was crafted over nearly a decade in Pattikadu village near Mahabalipuram in Tamil Nadu by artisans overseen by Vinayak Venkatraman and his mother Hemlata Devi.
- Expected to be completed by 2030, the foundation stone of the Virat Ramayan Mandir was laid on June 20, 2023.



News in short

- ❑ **Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar will launch his 'Samridhhi Yatra' on January 16, during which he will tour the districts and review the implementation of government schemes.**

Jharkhand

PESA Act implemented in Jharkhand after 25 years

- Jharkhand notified PESA Rules in January 2026, 25 years after becoming a state, extending tribal self-governance to its Fifth Schedule areas.
- **The Panchayat (Extension to Scheduled Areas) Act, 1996 (PESA) extends Part IX of the Constitution (Panchayati Raj) to Fifth Schedule tribal areas, recognising Gram Sabha as the primary authority over local governance, land, forests and community resources.**
- **It was enacted on 24 December 1996** to operationalise tribal self-rule in Scheduled Areas across nine States including Jharkhand



Key history of the PESA Act:

- **Colonial legacy:** British laws dispossessed tribes, eroding customary governance.
- **Fifth Schedule (Art. 244):** Protection without local self-rule = weak.
- **73rd Amendment (1992):** PRIs nationwide; Scheduled Areas excluded.
- **Bhuria Committee (1994–95):** Gram Sabhas to control resources & development.
- **PESA (1996):** Legal empowerment via direct democracy.

Key Features

- **Gram Sabha supreme authority.** Customary law & culture protected.
- **Resource rights:** MFP, water bodies, community lands.
- **Land safeguards:** Mandatory consultation; illegal transfers reversible.
- **Local powers:** Regulate markets, moneylending, liquor; choose scheme beneficiaries

Chhattisgarh

Foundation stone of Boramdev Corridor Development Project laid in Chhattisgarh

- In Chhattisgarh, Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai and Union Minister for Tourism and Culture, Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, laid the foundation stone of the Boramdev Corridor Development Project at a programme held at Boramdev Dham in Kabirdham district



- Under the Central Government's Swadesh Darshan Scheme 2.0, the Borhamdev Corridor Development Project will be developed at an estimated cost of around 146 crore rupees, on the lines of the Kashi Vishwanath Corridor in Varanasi.
- The Borhamdev Temple, popularly known as the Khajuraho of Chhattisgarh, is renowned in India and abroad for its ancient architectural excellence and religious significance.

Chhattisgarh: Raipur Literature Festival to begin

- The Raipur Sahitya Utsav 2026 will be held over three days from January 23 to 25 at Purkhouti Muktangan in Nava Raipur Atal Nagar
- Aimed at providing a larger platform for literary and cultural discussions, with participation expected from writers, readers and cultural practitioners from within Chhattisgarh and other parts of the country.



Odisha

Puri Upgraded to Municipal Corporation in Odisha

- The state government officially upgraded Puri municipality into a municipal corporation and declared four urban areas as Notified Area Councils (NACs).
- The government also declared four urban areas as NACs - Loisingha in Balangir district, Chandikhol in Jajpur district, Jashipur in Mayurbhanj district and Basta in Balasore district



Kalinga Literary Festival to celebrate literature without borders

- The 12th edition of the Kalinga Literary Festival (KLF) 2026 to be held from 8-11 January at Mayfair, Bhubaneswar.
- The theme, 'Stories That Shape Humanity: Translating Worlds, Transforming Futures',
- KLF 2026 will confer the Kalinga Literary Award, Kalinga Literary Award (International), and Kalinga Literary Award (Youth), along with the Penguin-KLF Book Review Project Awards and Inter School Debate Competition.
- The festival will also host the launch of the 'Legislators for Literature' initiative.



Odisha government launches new scheme 'Aame Padhiba Aama Bhasare'

- Scheme aimed at providing early childhood education in mother tongue.
- Scheme:** 'Aame Padhiba Aama Bhasare' (meaning "We will study in our own language") is a five-year educational initiative to impart early childhood education in children's mother tongue. Emphasising women's empowerment and child welfare as a priority.
 - Target Group:** It will benefit children aged 3-6 years.
- Anganwadi Capacity Building:** Anganwadi workers will receive language-specific training, educational materials and audio-visual content.
- Child Marriage Prevention:** The government has also launched a 100-day campaign to prevent child marriage.

The Sunabeda Wildlife Sanctuary in Odisha was officially declared 'Maoist-free' in January 2026

- Established in 1983, it is part of the Deccan Peninsula biogeographic zone and serves as a vital ecological bridge in Central India.
- Located in:** Nuapada, Odisha.
- Adjoins the Sitanadi and Udanti Sanctuaries of Chhattisgarh.
- Hydrology:** It forms the primary catchment area for the Jonk River, a tributary of the Mahanadi. The sanctuary is also the source of the Sunder and Indra
- Acts as a critical corridor for Wild Water Buffalo migrating between Odisha and Chhattisgarh.

Buddhist Diamond Triangle Joins UNESCO World Heritage Tentative List

- The UNESCO World Heritage Centre has officially added Odisha's famed Buddhist Diamond Triangle—comprising Lalitgiri, Udayagiri, and Ratnagiri—to India's Tentative List for World Heritage Sites.
- The Diamond Triangle is a serial cultural nomination of three interconnected monastic complexes located in the Jajpur and Cuttack districts of Odisha.
- **These sites are unique because they document 1,500 years of continuous history, showcasing the transition of Buddhism through three major schools:** Theravada (Hinayana) ; Mahayana ;Vajrayana (Esoteric Buddhism)



Lalitgiri: The Ancient Spiritual Hub

- Located in the Cuttack district, Lalitgiri is the oldest site in the triangle, dating back to the 2nd–3rd Century BCE.
- **Key Discovery:** A massive stupa containing sacred relic caskets made of gold, silver, and stone—believed by many to be the relics of Lord Buddha himself.
- Home to an east-facing **apsidal chaityagriha**, the first of its kind discovered in Odisha.
- Inscriptions of “Sri Chandraditya Vihara” prove it was a highly organized center of learning for over a millennium.



Udayagiri: The Sunrise Hill of Monasteries

- Udayagiri, the largest complex in the group, flourished between the 1st and 13th Century CE.
- **Advanced Architecture:** Features a unique double-storeyed monastery and the Madhavapura Mahavihara.
- **Artistic Grandeur:** The site is famous for its colossal images of Avalokiteswara and the Pancha Dhyani Buddhas, representing the peak of Mahayana artistic complexity.



West Bengal

Sagar Island Latest News

- The West Bengal Chief Minister recently laid the foundation stone of a 5-km-long bridge over the river Muriganga to connect Sagar Island with the mainland.



About Sagar Island

- Sagar Island, also known as Gangasagar or Sagardwip, is located in the Ganges delta, in West Bengal.
- It is about 100 km south of Kolkata.
- It is part of the South 24 Parganas district. It consists of 43 villages.
- It lies at the mouth of the Hooghly River (a major tributary of the Ganges), an arm of which separates it from the mainland to the east.
- **Although Sagar Island is a part of Sundarbans**, it does not have any tiger habitation or mangrove forests or small river tributaries as is characteristic of the overall Sundarban delta.
- Situated at a point where the Ganges River system meets the Bay of Bengal, the island is held to be particularly sacred and is a noted Hindu pilgrimage center.
- **The Ganga Sagar Fair is the second most attended fair in the world, after the popular Kumbh Mela.**
- The Kapil Muni temple on the island is a popular pilgrim centre,

49th International Kolkata Book Fair Begins at Salt Lake

- Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee inaugurated the 49th International Kolkata Book Fair.
- **The 49th International Kolkata Book Fair commenced at the Boi – Mela ground at**



Salt Lake in Kolkata

- The inaugural function lifetime achievement award was given to a former official of Akashvani, Swapnomoy Chakraborty.
- **This year, the focal theme country is Argentina.**
- **China participated in the fair after a gap of 15 years**
- The United States of America and Bangladesh have not participated this year

Assam

Assam Governor Launches Sanskaar Shaala, Stresses Value-Based Education

- Lakshman Prasad Acharya, Governor of Assam, inaugurated Sanskaar Shaala in Guwahati at the Lohia Lions Auditorium.
- The programme is designed for children aged 4 to 14 years and focuses on value-based education alongside formal schooling.

Assam becomes first to constitute 8th Pay Commission for state employees, CM appoints panel head

- Assam became the first State to constitute an 8th State Pay Commission, ahead of the expiry of the 7th Pay Commission on 1 Jan 2026.
- **Headed by former Chief Secretary Subhas Das.**
- The Central Government approved ToR for the 8th Central Pay Commission (CPC).
- **Coverage:** ~Chairperson: Ranjana Prakash Desai (ex-SC judge; Chair, Press Council of India).
- **Pay Commissions:** Set up ~every 10 years; 7 formed since Independence.



Assam Unveils Welfare Scheme for Udasin Bhakats at Satras

- Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma launched a new financial assistance scheme aimed at providing support to celibate monks residing in the state's traditional 'satras' — the Vaishnavite monastic institutions that are key to Assamese cultural and spiritual life.
- Under the scheme, each eligible monk — referred to as an Udasin Bhakat (celibate Vaishnavite monk) — will receive monthly financial assistance of Rs 1,500 directly into their bank accounts.



PM Modi lays foundation stone for Kaziranga corridor, flags off 2 Amrit Bharat trains

- **Prime Minister Narendra Modi laid the foundation stone for the Rs 6,957-crore Kaziranga Elevated Corridor**, and virtually flagged off two Amrit Bharat trains in Assam's Nagaon district.
- **The corridor aims to ensure safe wildlife movement across the Kaziranga National Park and Tiger Reserve**, reduce road accidents on National Highway-715, and boost ecotourism, while generating local employment opportunities.
- The Prime Minister also virtually flagged off two Amrit Bharat Express trains – Dibrugarh-Gomti Nagar (Lucknow) and Kamakhya-Rohtak.
- India's first overnight sleeper Vande Bharat train connecting Kolkata and Guwahati (the Howrah–Guwahati (Kamakhya) route, also launched.



PM Modi Addresses Bagurumba Dwhou Celebrating Bodo Heritage

- Recently, the Prime Minister of India witnessed a performance of the traditional **Bagurumba dance of the Bodo community in Assam** with over 10,000 artists participating in the program.



About Bagurumba Dance

- It is one of the folk dances of the Bodo community, deeply inspired by nature.

- It represents peace, fertility, joy and collective harmony, and is closely associated with festivals such as Bwisagu, the Bodo New Year, and Domasi.

Features of Bagurumba Dance

- The dance symbolises blooming flowers and reflects harmony between human life and the natural world.
- It features gentle, flowing movements that imitate butterflies, birds, leaves and flowers.
- It is **traditionally performed only by women of the Bodo community, with the musical instruments being played by their male counterparts.**
- Dance Attire:** The dancers dress in handwoven, bright red, yellow, and green dokhna, jwmgra, and aronai..
- Musical Instruments used:** The musical instruments include the traditional kham (a drum made of wood and goatskin), including sifung (a bamboo flute), and other wooden instruments like jota, gongwna and tharkha.

Assam Launches Eti Koli Duti Paat Scheme for Tea Workers

- Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma launched the Mukhya Mantrir Eti Koli Duti Paat Scheme at Doomdooma in Tinsukia district,.
- The scheme aims to recognise the contribution of tea tribes and indigenous communities and provide direct financial support across the state.
- The scheme, over Rs. 300 crore will be disbursed as a one-time assistance of Rs. 5,000 each to more than six lakh tea garden workers, including permanent and casual labourers.**



Amit Shah unveils development projects worth ₹1,715 crore in Assam

- Union Home Minister Amit Shah launched projects worth ₹1,715 crore, including the second legislative assembly complex, in Assam's Dibrugarh.
- The Union Home Minister also attended the Takam Mising Porin Kebang Youth Festival as the chief guest at Dhemaji district
- The project will include an educational and administrative block, a central laboratory, a museum, a state-of-the-art auditorium, a clinical block and a laboratory with radiation facilities.
- Mr. Shah also launched the ₹692 crore project for the restoration and rejuvenation of wetlands under the National Disaster Mitigation fund.



Arunachal Pradesh

Arunachal celebrates India's first sunrise of 2026 with 'Dance of the Dawn'

- India's first-ever Sunrise Festival in the picturesque easternmost village of Dong in Anjaw district.**
- As the first rays of the sun illuminated India's easternmost horizon, history was made in Dong with the inaugural Sunrise Festival, "ALO PRABHAT – Dance of the Dawn."
- The Meyor and Mishimi communities played a central role in the celebrations.



Keyi Panyor to Become India's First Bio-Happy District

- The newly formed Keyi Panyor district in Arunachal Pradesh is set to become India's first Bio-Happy District, marking a pioneering experiment in integrating biodiversity conservation with human well-being.
- The **initiative revives the concept of "Biohappiness", coined by legendary agricultural scientist M.S. Swaminathan**, and aims to build a sustainable development model rooted in ecology, livelihoods, and public health.
- The project is being implemented by the M. S. Swaminathan Research Foundation in collaboration with the district administration.



Arunachal Pradesh hosts Namsai-Pangsau PowerDrive 2026 to boost adventure tourism

- The two-day Motorsport 'Namsai-Pangsau PowerDrive 2026'
- **with the theme "Daring to Push Boundaries, Celebrating Culture," began today at Namsai, Arunachal Pradesh.**
- The event aims to position the state as India's next major destination for adventure tourism and motorsports.
- It is a **part of the 10th Edition of the Pangsau Pass International Festival 2026,**
- and is organised by Adventure X-Fusion Tribe under the aegis of the Federation of Motor Sports Clubs of India (FMSCI),

Manipur**Prasar Bharati Moves to Restore Thadou Language Broadcast in Manipur**

- Public broadcaster Prasar Bharati has initiated steps to resume live radio programming in the Thadou language from All India Radio, also known as Akashvani, in Imphal.

About Thadou Tribe

- They are an **indigenous people who live in the hill country adjacent to the Imphal Valley in Manipur.**
- According to the 2011 census the total Thadou population in Manipur was 190,595.
- The **Thadous are the second largest tribe in Manipur**, preceded only by the Meiteis, or Manipuris.
- They are also found in smaller numbers in Nagaland, Assam, Tripura, Meghalaya, Mizoram, and Delhi.
- **Language:** They speak Chin and Thado, which belong to the Tibeto-Burman family of the Sino-Tibetan languages.
- **Thadous share a common culture with all the Chin-Kuki-Mizo commun**



Manipur Statehood Year	1972
Tripura, Statehood Year	1972
Meghalaya Statehood Year	1972
Constitutional Amendment	States were formed under the 27th Constitutional Amendment Act.
Key Legislation	North Eastern Areas Reorganisation Act, 1971.
Pre-Statehood Status of Manipur	Union Territory (merged with India in 1949).
Pre-Statehood Status of Tripura,	Union Territory (merged with India in 1949).
Pre-Statehood Status of Meghalaya	In 1947 the rulers of the Garo and Khasi region acceded to the newly independent country of India. Autonomous State within Assam (granted autonomy in 1969).

21 January - Tripura, Manipur, and Meghalaya Foundation Day**About Tripura**

- **State Animal** : Phayre's Langur (*Trachypithecus phayrei*)
- **State Bird** : Green Imperial Pigeon (*Ducula aenea*)
- **State Tree** : Agar (*Aquilaria malaccensis*)



- **State Flower:** Nageswar (Mesua ferrea)
- **State Fruit :** Queen Pineapple (Ananas comosus)
- **Capital:** Agartala
- **Governor :** Shri Indrasena Reddy Nallu
- **Chief Minister:** Professor (Dr.) Manik Saha

About Manipur

- Capital Imphal
- State Bird: Nongyeen
- State Animal: Sangai
- State Game : Manipuri Polo
- State Flower : Shirui Lily
- CM: Nongthombam Biren Singh **served as the Chief Minister of Manipur from 2017 until his resignation in February 2025, after which the state came under President's Rule**
- Governor: Shri Ajay Kumar Bhalla

About Meghalaya

- State Animal – Clouded Leopard
- State Bird of Meghalaya – Common Hill Myna
- State Tree of Meghalaya – Gmelina arborea
- State Flower of Meghalaya – Lady's slipper orchid
- Chief minister : Conrad Sangma
- Governor : C. H. Vijayashankar

Mizoram

Mizoram Government to Procure Ginger, Broomsticks Under Bana Kaih scheme

- Mizoram Chief Minister Lalduhoma announced that **the state government will begin procuring ginger and dry broomsticks directly from farmers from February 2 under its flagship handholding initiative, the Bana Kaih scheme.**
- launch of the Bana Kaih scheme in September 2024.
- Under the Bana Kaih programme, the government will procure ginger and dry broomsticks at support prices, ensuring assured income for cultivators.



Nagaland

Nagaland gets its first Drone School

- Nagaland got its first Drone School and Drone Centre of Excellence at the Nagaland GIS and Remote Sensing Centre at Kohima.
- The state-of-the-art facility is a pioneering initiative of the State GIS and Remote Sensing Centre under the Planning and Transformation Department, which aims at equipping youth with advanced drone technology skills and promoting innovation-driven employment.
- The Drone School would also serve as a hub for innovation and capacity building, enabling the transfer of knowledge to districts and interior areas so that the benefits of technology reach the last mile.



Fifth Rüsoma Orange Festival Begins in Nagaland

- In Nagaland, the 5th edition of the Rüsoma Orange Festival began today at Rüsoma village.
- the theme "Abundance of Rüsoma, the two festival aims to promote village welfare, boost rural entrepreneurship, and recognise the hard work of orange growers while promoting the unique taste of Rüsoma oranges.



Rajasthan

Rajasthan Regional AI Impact Conference 2026 in Jaipur

- As part of India's build-up to the India AI Impact Summit 2026, the **Rajasthan Regional AI Impact Conference 2026 will be held on January 6, 2026, in Jaipur.**
- The Conference will serve as a key regional platform to explore **how Artificial Intelligence can drive governance reform, economic growth, innovation, and inclusive development.**
- Held in conjunction with Rajasthan DigiFest × TiE Global Summit 2026.



Centre Grants GI Tag to Nagauri Ashwagandha

- Recently, the Centre has officially granted a Geographical Indication (GI) tag to 'Nagauri Ashwagandha'.

About Nagauri Ashwagandha

- It is mainly grown in the Nagaur district of Rajasthan.
- Nagaur's dry climate and sandy soil are ideally suited for Ashwagandha cultivation.
- It has longer, thicker roots rich in medicinal compounds, particularly alkaloids.**
- Its berries are known for their dark, bright red colour, which is considered a clear indicator of superior quality.
- It has **brittle and starchy roots. The 'Nagori Ashwagandha' is the supreme among all Ashwagandha varieties in arid regions.**



Key Facts about Ashwagandha

- Ashwagandha (Withania somnifera) is an important ancient plant.
- Other names: Indian ginseng or Indian winter cherry
- It grows in dry and sub-tropical regions. It is grown as a late rainy season (kharif) crop.**
- Major Ashwagandha Producing states: Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Punjab, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Gujarat, Maharashtra

Benefits of Ashwagandha

- It has been in use as a medicinal plant for thousands of years, especially in traditional Ayurvedic medicine.
- It is **often called an adaptogen**, meaning it helps the body adapt to stressors and restore balance. Its other benefits are reducing inflammation, increasing energy, alleviating anxiety, ease pain, and improving sleep.

Bamanwas Kankar Becomes Rajasthan's First Organic Panchayat

- Bamanwas Kankar panchayat in Rajasthan has become the first village body in the State to be certified as fully organic.
- Bamanwas Kankar panchayat, comprising seven hamlets in Kotputli–Behror district, has formally committed to 100% organic farming** and eco-friendly animal husbandry, eliminating chemical fertilisers, pesticides, and synthetic inputs from all agricultural and livestock practices.



Rajasthan Government's Raj-UNNATI initiative for project monitoring

- The Rajasthan Government's Raj-UNNATI, a new **project-monitoring initiative inspired by the Centre's PRAGATI** (Pro-Active Governance and Timely Implementation), an information and communication technology-enabled multimodal platform.
- Raj-UNNATI aims to resolve issues related to important projects, schemes, and public



grievances that are stuck for various reasons. Using the initiative, projects and schemes of both the central and state governments are reviewed through videoconferencing.

- Rajasthan is the first state to adopt it as Raj-UNNATI."

Gujarat

1000 years survival of Somnath Temple

- Prime Minister of India highlighted the thousand-year survival of the Somnath Temple, marking 1,000 years since the 1026 attack by Mahmud of Ghazni.
- The Somnath Temple is one of the 12 sacred Jyotirlingas of Lord Shiva, revered across Hindu tradition. It is often called the "Eternal Shrine" due to its repeated destruction and reconstruction over centuries.



Location:

- Prabhas Patan, near Veraval, in the Saurashtra region of Gujarat
- Situated on the Arabian Sea coast, at the confluence (Triveni Sangam) of the Kapila, Hiran, and Saraswati rivers

History of the temple:

- **Ancient origins:** References in the Shiva Purana and inscriptions suggest worship since antiquity, with multiple pre-medieval reconstructions.
- **1026 CE:** Attacked and plundered by Mahmud of Ghazni, marking the most cited historical rupture.
- **Medieval period:** Rebuilt several times by rulers such as Kumarapala (12th century) and Chudasama kings, and destroyed again under Sultanate invasions.
- **Repeated cycle:** Historical records indicate the temple was destroyed six times and rebuilt each time, reinforcing its symbolic resilience.



Key architectural features:

- Built in the Chaulukya (Solanki) style of temple architecture
- Features a lofty shikhara, intricate stone carvings, and a grand garbhagriha housing the Jyotirlinga

Modern reconstruction:

- Post-Independence revival (1947–51): Initiated by Vallabhbhai Patel, who viewed reconstruction as a civilisational duty.
- **Executed by architect Prabhashankar Sompura using traditional methods.**
- Inaugurated on 11 May 1951 by Rajendra Prasad, despite political differences of the time.
- Today, the temple is managed by the Somnath Trust, chaired by the Prime Minister of India.

Rashtriya Khanij Chintan Shivir–2026 to be held from 8–10 January in Gandhinagar, Gujarat

- Ministry of Mines is organising the Rashtriya Khanij Chintan Shivir–2026 from 8th to 10th January, 2026 at Gandhinagar, Gujarat.
- A dedicated focus of the Rashtriya Khanij Chintan Shivir–2026 will be on the Critical Minerals Mission, aimed at strengthening domestic availability of critical and strategic minerals essential for clean energy transition, advanced manufacturing and emerging technologies.



Gujarat Activates Karuna Abhiyan Ahead Of Uttarayan

- **Uttarayan is celebrated in Gujarat during the Makar Sankranti period.**
- Karuna Abhiyan is a Gujarat initiative for animal and bird welfare. Wildlife rescue operations involve veterinarians and trained volunteers.
- Kite strings, especially synthetic ones, pose serious risks to birds.

Gujarat CM Inaugurates 'Asha Van' for Early Cancer Screening

- Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel inaugurated a mobile cancer screening unit, 'Asha Van', in Gandhinagar, aimed at early detection and diagnosis of cancer.
- The **Asha Van is equipped with ultra-modern medical technology, including EVA-Pro diagnostics, a mammography unit, and expert teleconsultation facilities.**
- It is capable of screening and diagnosing multiple life-threatening diseases on the spot.

Prabhas Patan Inscriptions Reveal Somnath's Sacred Continuity

- The Bhadrakali inscription is a key 12th-century record that confirms the history and development of Somnath Temple and patronage given by the Solanki dynasty.

About Bhadrakali Inscription

- **Location:** It is situated in Prabhas Patan, Gujarat specifically on the wall of the Bhadrakali Temple.
- **It was carved in 1169 CE** and currently protected by the State Department of Archaeology,

Gujarat lays foundation stone for India's first integrated private satellite plant in Sanand

- The foundation stone for the country's first integrated private satellite plant was laid at Khoraj in Sanand in Gujarat.
- **This facility, known as the 'Palmnaro' plant, is set to become a premier hub for the indigenous manufacturing of satellites** and advanced optical payloads by the private sector.

Gujarat to Support Girls Education with ₹1,250 Crore under Namo Laxmi Scheme

- The Gujarat government announced that under the **Namo Laxmi Scheme, it will provide financial assistance of Rs 1,250 crore in the 2025-26 academic year to more than 12 lakh girls studying in secondary and higher secondary education.**
- The scheme aims to ensure that financial constraints do not prevent girls from completing their education after primary schooling.
- The scheme is open to students enrolled in schools recognised by the **Gujarat Secondary and Higher Secondary Education Board (GSHSEB)** or the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE).
- **Girls who are already beneficiaries of other government scholarships are also eligible, as the scheme provides additional support.**
- Under the Namo Laxmi Scheme, students in Classes 9 to 12 will receive total financial assistance of Rs 50,000 over four years.
- For Classes 9 and 10, the total support of Rs 20,000 will be disbursed, with Rs 5,000 provided annually as Rs 500 per month over 10 months, and the remaining Rs 10,000 released upon passing the Class 10 board examinations.
- For Classes 11 and 12, students will receive Rs 30,000, of which Rs 7,500 is provided annually as Rs 750 per month over 10 months in each year, and the remaining Rs 15,000 following successful completion of Class 12 board exams.
- **Eligibility for the scheme requires students to have completed Classes 1 to 8 in government or aided primary schools or under the RTE, or to have completed Class 8 in a private primary school,** and to belong to families with an annual income of Rs six lakh or less.
- Students enrolled in Class 9 who meet these criteria can avail themselves of the benefits.



Gujarat Launches Mukhyamantri Gramotthan Yojana

- In Gujarat, Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel launched the state-wide 'Mukhyamantri Gramotthan Yojana'.
- Under the scheme, the villages will be provided with modern urban equivalent facilities, including road infrastructure, water, sanitation, solar street lights, e-grams, and community halls, etc, helping reduce the burden on cities,
- In the first phase of this mission, 114 villages that serve as Taluka headquarters will be equipped with modern amenities.

MAHARASHTRA

India's first bullet train to be launched on August 15, 2027 between Mumbai and Ahmedabad

- Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw announced that India's first bullet train will be ready by August 15, 2027.
- The National High-Speed Rail Corporation Limited (NHSRCL) is currently executing the country's first bullet train corridor between Mumbai and Ahmedabad.
- The first operational section will be the Surat–Bilimora stretch, followed by Vapi–Surat.
- The Vapi–Ahmedabad section will be opened, after which services will begin on the Thane–Ahmedabad stretch.



Mumbai-Ahmedabad Bullet train stations

- The 508-km long Mumbai-Ahmedabad High Speed Rail (MAHSR) project will have 12 stations.
- The total estimated cost of MAHSR project is Rs 1,08,000 crore (approximately). Of these, Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA) is funding 81% of the project cost i.e. Rs. 88,000 crores.
- Once operational, it will reduce travel time Mumbai and Ahmedabad to just 2 hours and 7 minutes (127 minutes).

Cabinet Clears Nashik–Solapur Six-Lane Greenfield Corridor

- The 'Jaystambh' at Perne village in Pune district to mark the 208th anniversary of the Battle of Koregaon Bhima.
- Jaystambh, a military monument located in Perne village on the Pune–Ahilyanagar highway, was erected by the British government in 1821 in memory of its soldiers who fought against the Peshwas at Koregaon Bhima on January 1, 1818.
- The records say that the British Army, comprising 500 soldiers from the Mahar community, defeated a 28,000-strong force of Peshwas in this battle.
- Dr Ambedkar had visited the Jaystambh on January 1, 1927, as part of the historic anti-British movement against the ban on recruitment of the then "untouchables" in the British Army.



208th anniversary of battle of Koregaon Bhima marked peacefully at 'Jaystambh'



Gangapur Dam

- The air show, featuring the Indian Air Force's Suryakiran aerobatic team, took place over the Gangapur dam in the Nashik district recently.

About Gangapur Dam

- It is an earthfill dam on the River Godavari, near Nashik, Maharashtra.
- It is the longest earthen reservoir of Asia, with a length of 9.8 kilometers and a height of 36.6 meters.
- **The dam has a unique design, with a curved shape and a spillway in the middle.**
- It was built in 1965 as part of the Godavari Marathwada Irrigation Development Project.



Mumbai To Host India's First City-Led Initiative To Showcase Climate Action As Fundamental Child Right

- Mumbai is slated to host the 'Mumbai Climate Week 2026' from February 17 to 19.
- UNICEF India and YuWaah have been named the official youth engagement partners.
- The initiative is grounded in the recognition that climate change disproportionately affects children, impacting health, education and long-term well-being.

Maharashtra Cabinet Clears ₹4,775 Crore Bembla River Irrigation Project

- Project is Located in Yavatmal district of Maharashtra.
- The **Bembala River is an important tributary of the Wardha River in Maharashtra.**

- Implemented under the Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchayee Yojana (PMKSY) and sponsored by the Department of Water Resources, River Development & Ganga Rejuvenation, Ministry of Jal Shakti, was sanctioned on 02 April 2007 to strengthen irrigation infrastructure and enhance agricultural productivity in the Vidarbha region.
- In another key decision, approval was granted for the establishment of the Maharashtra Agency for Holistic International Mobility and Advancements – MAHIMA to provide overseas employment opportunities for the state's youth.

Maharashtra Launches India's First Menopause Clinics

- Maharashtra has launched the country's first dedicated menopause clinics across government hospitals and urban health facilities to address women's physical and mental health needs.
- Dedicated menopause clinics within the public healthcare system that provide integrated medical and psychological care for women undergoing menopause, recognising it as a natural but health-sensitive life stage.



11th Ajanta-Ellora International Film Festival 2026

- The 11th Ajanta-Ellora International Film Festival (AEIFF) began on 28th January in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar.
- On the occasion, legendary music composer and Padma Vibhushan awardee Ilaiyaraaja will be honoured with the prestigious Padmapani Award in recognition of his outstanding contribution to Indian cinema.
- A Padmapani Memento Certificate and a letter of felicitation coupled with a cash prize of Rs. 2,00,000 constitutes the Padmapani Award.
- The festival will run for four days, until February 1, 2026.
- The festival will open with the screening of the Spanish film 'Siret'.
- Actress Bhagyashree Borase from Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar will also be specially honoured for her contribution to South Indian cinema.



News in short

- The Navi Mumbai International Airport will be named after late D B Patil, a prominent people's leader associated with farmers' and local rights movements in the region.

Goa

Goa Announces Third District Kushavati

- Goa's third district will be named Kushavati, deriving its name from Kushavati river that flows through southern Goa.
- Goa currently has two districts – South Goa and North Goa.
- The headquarters for the third district will be located in Quepem.
- The ancient capital of Goa, Chandrapur or Chandor, is located on the banks of the Kushavati, wherein the Bhojas, South Konkan Shilaharas and Kadamba dynasties ruled from the 4th century to the mid-14th century.



India Energy Week 2026 to be held in Goa from 27–30 January

- Organised under the patronage of the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas and jointly hosted by the Federation of Indian Petroleum Industry (FIPI) and dmgt events, IEW 2026 will serve as the first major international energy gathering of the year.
- The event will showcase India's reform-driven energy framework, including recent legislative and regulatory reforms under the Oilfields (Regulation and Development) Act, 2025 and the Petroleum and Natural Gas Rules, 2025.



Telangana

Operation Smile–XII launched to trace missing children across Cyberabad

- The Cyberabad Police(Telangana) launched Operation Smile–XII, a month-long drive aimed at tracing missing children and rescuing vulnerable minors across the commissionerate.
- **The initiative, launched on January 1, will continue till January 30**
- The police will also use facial recognition technology through the Darpan mobile application to trace missing children and reunite them with their families.



Telangana Assembly passes Bill abolishing two-child norm for local body elections

- The Legislative Assembly passed a Bill to overcome the existing law, enacted in 1994, that disqualifies people with more than two children from contesting local body elections.
- **The Bill supersedes the earlier Ordinance. The new Bill — Telangana Panchayat Raj (Amendment) Bill 2026 — was moved by Minister for Panchayat Raj Danasari Anasuya Seethakka, who said the time has come to remove the two-child norm given the changes in society and the fall in fertility rate.**
- **India Launches First Tropical RAS-Based Rainbow Trout Farm**
- The Union Minister, Ministry of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying and Ministry of Panchayati Raj, Shri Rajiv Ranjan Singh alias Lalan Singh will inaugurate the Smart Green Aquaculture Farm and Research Institute and state-of-the-art Recirculatory Aquaculture System (RAS) Facility following the General body meeting on 5th January 2026 in Hyderabad, Telangana.
- Situated at Kandukur Mandal in Ranga Reddy District, Telangana .
- Smart Green Aquaculture Limited has established India's first commercial-scale tropical Recirculating Aquaculture System (RAS)–based Rainbow Trout Aquaculture Farm & Research Institute.



Lambadi Tribe

- The Supreme Court is once again being asked to rule on long-standing controversy of Parliament's decision on Scheduled Tribe status to Lambadi community in Telangana.
- **Lambadi Tribe are found in Telangana, Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka states in South India.**
- They are also known as Sugali or Banjara.
- **Language:** They speak Gor Boli also called Lambadi which belongs to the Indo-Aryan Group of Languages. Lambadi has no script.
- **Belief System:** The majority of Banjara in India are Hindu; some have combined Hindu practices with their own animistic beliefs.
- **Lambadi Tribe/ Banjara people celebrate the festival of Teej during Shravanam (in the month of august).**
- In this festival young unmarried Banjara girls pray for a good groom.
- Fire dance and Chari are the traditional dance forms of the banjara people.
- Tattoos are very common in their community.

Hyderabad to host 750-year-old Sufi Basant tradition

- Sufi Basant Festival, organised by the Telangana Arts and Cultural Council, will be held in Hyderabad on January 23.
- The musical evening will present Mehfil-e-Nizami, a qawwali recital featuring select lyrical compositions by Amir Khusrau. The tradition traces its origins to a poignant episode from the life of Saint Nizamuddin Aulia, who, after losing his nephew, withdrew into grief.
- Muzaffar began organising the annual celebration in Hyderabad in 2014.



Sammakka–Saralamma Jatara

- Telangana is preparing for the biennial Sammakka–Saralamma Jatara beginning 28 January 2026, **alongside a large-scale redevelopment of the sacred precinct at Medaram.**
- A biennial tribal spiritual festival honouring Sammakka and Saralamma, revered as ancestral goddesses of the Koya Adivasi community.
- **Recognised as Asia's largest tribal festival and one of the largest human congregations in the world.**

Held in:

- Celebrated at Medaram village in Mulugu district, Telangana, located inside the Eturnagaram Wildlife Sanctuary, part of the Dandakaranya forest belt.
- Conducted during the full moon of the Hindu month of Magh.

Origin:

- Rooted in Koya tribal history and legend, centred on Sammakka, a forest-born woman adopted by tribals, and her daughter Saralamma.
- According to tradition, they resisted the Kakatiya rulers' tax oppression, attained martyrdom, and are remembered as symbols of tribal resistance and sacrifice.
- The deities are not worshipped permanently in temples; instead, they are symbolically brought from the forest to stay with the people for a few sacred days.

Key features:

- Rituals are conducted exclusively by Koya tribal priests, following indigenous customs.
- **Devotees offer "Bangaram" (jaggery) instead of gold or money, symbolising equality and agrarian life.**
- Worship centres around sacred trees, bamboo totems, flags (dalgudda) and clan symbols rather than idols.
- Attracts over one crore devotees, second only to the Kumbh Mela in scale within India.

Wings India 2026 Set to Soar: Asia's Largest Civil Aviation Event to Showcase the Future of Global Aviation

- The Wings India 2026 launch will mark the beginning of a landmark **four-day global aviation gathering scheduled to be held from 28 to 31 January 2026 at Begumpet Airport, Hyderabad.**
- **The theme** "Indian Aviation: Paving the Future – From Design to Deployment, Manufacturing to Maintenance, Inclusivity to Innovation and Safety to Sustainability",
- **Wings India 2026 will feature impressive static aircraft displays, flying displays and aerobatic air shows, showcasing a wide range of aircraft.** Highlight attractions include aerial performances by the Surya Kiran Aerobatic Team of the Indian Air Force.



Andhra Pradesh

'Sakhi One Stop Centre' launched in Chittoor

- This mobile unit is intended to enhance the outreach and facilitate quicker access to services for women in distress across the district.
- Women facing violence or distress can seek immediate assistance from the "Sakhi One Stop Centre"
- One Stop Centre Scheme, also known as the Sakhi Scheme, is a flagship initiative by the Ministry of Women and Child Development (MWCD), Government of India.
- Launched on April 1, 2015, the scheme aims to provide integrated support and assistance to women affected by violence, both in private and public spaces, under one roof.



Guntur to Host National SARAS Mela 2026

- Guntur, Andhra Pradesh, will host the prestigious national-level SARAS Mela from 6th January to 18th January 2026
- SARAS Mela are a flagship initiative aimed at the economic empowerment of women SHG members through sustainable livelihoods.
- As a National SARAS event, SARAS-2026 will bring together around 300 women artisans and entrepreneurs from 21 States and Union Territories, offering them national-level exposure and market access.

Andhra Pradesh Deputy CM Pawan Kalyan Inducted Into Kenjutsu

- Actor and Andhra Pradesh Deputy Chief Minister K. Pawan Kalyan has been formally inducted into Kenjutsu, the umbrella term for all schools of classical Japanese swordsmanship.
- It is a global recognition for his more than three decades of disciplined training, research, and commitment to martial arts traditions.
- He was the first Telugu-speaking person to be inducted into the Takeda Shingen Clan.
- Additionally, Mr. Pawan Kalyan was felicitated by the Golden Dragons organisation with the distinguished title, 'Tiger of Martial Arts'.



Recently, the Indian Railways has introduced a humanoid robot named "ASC ARJUN" at Visakhapatnam Railway Station.

- It is a humanoid robot introduced by the Indian Railways.
- The robot will operate alongside Railway Protection Force (RPF) personnel to assist in station operations, particularly during periods of heavy passenger movement.
- **It is designed and developed entirely in Visakhapatnam using home-grown technology.**



Features of ASC Arjun

- It is equipped with a Face Recognition System (FRS) for intrusion detection, AI-based crowd monitoring and real-time alert generation for RPF control rooms.
- **It can also make automated public announcements in English, Hindi and Telugu to assist passengers and promote safety awareness.**
- It also features semi-autonomous navigation with obstacle-avoidance capability,
- **It has been designed for passenger interaction, offering gestures such as a 'Namaste' for passengers and salutes for RPF personnel, along with an interface to provide information and assistance**

Ponduru Khadi receives GI Tag; KVIC to felicitate Artisans and expand Global Outreach

- **Ponduru Khadi of Andhra Pradesh has been granted the Geographical Indication (GI) tag, with the registration awarded in favour of the Khadi and Village Industries Commission (KVIC) by the Geographical Indications Registry.**
- Ponduru Khadi, is a famous handspun and handwoven cotton fabric from Andhra Pradesh.
- It is locally known as Patnulu and is produced in Ponduru village in Srikakulam district.
- **It has been nominated for the One District One Product (ODOP) scheme from the Srikakulam district.**
- During the pre – independence era Mahatma Gandhi mentioned its virtues in his Young India (the national weekly that Gandhiji edited).



Key Characteristics of Ponduru Khadi

- **Production:** It is produced from one of three types of cotton: hill cotton, punasa cotton, or red cotton.

- **Cotton Source:** Cotton is indigenous to Srikakulam district and is grown in and around Ponduru.
- **Process:** The entire process, from cotton to fabric, is carried out manually.

Unique to Ponduru Khadi

- **Cleaning:** The process of cleaning the cotton with the jawbone of Valuga fish is unique to Ponduru khadi and is not practiced anywhere else in the world.
- **Spinning:** Ponduru is the only place in India where spinners still use single-spindle charkhas with 24 spokes, also known as the "Gandhi Charkha".

Chittoor Police launch 'Dhairya Sparsha' initiative in Chittoor, Andhra Pradesh

- The 'Dhairya Sparsha' initiative, stressing the importance of recognising good touch and bad touch at an early age.
- Students were advised to firmly say no to any inappropriate behaviour and immediately report such incidents to parents, teachers or the police without fear or hesitation.
- The women police wing launched an awareness camp focusing on child safety, legal protections and emergency response mechanisms.

Paathara (Khoni) Practice

- The ancient Paathara (or Khoni) grain storage tradition in Andhra Pradesh's Srikakulam district is facing imminent extinction in January 2026.
- Paathara (referred to as Khoni in Odia) is a traditional underground grain storage pit.
- It is a highly scientific, indigenous method used by farmers to preserve freshly harvested paddy for long-term household consumption and rituals.
- Observed primarily in the Srikakulam (Andhra Pradesh), along the banks of the Mahendratana River, near the Odisha border.



Key Features:

- A rectangular or circular pit is dug into the earth, usually in front of the house or cattle shed.
- The pit is meticulously plastered with straw and clay.
- Sealing: Once filled with paddy, the top is sealed with a thick layer of clay and cow dung, making it airtight and pest-proof.

Karnataka

Jamma Bane Lands

- Recently, the Karnataka government has amended its land revenue law to modernise an age-old system of land records called Jamma Bane lands.

About Jamma Bane Lands

- The word Jamma means hereditary.
- The **Jamma Bane tenure is a form of land holding prevalent in Kodagu district of Karnataka.**
- **History:** These lands were originally granted by erstwhile kings of Coorg and the British — between 1600 and 1800 to local communities in return for military service.
- These lands comprise both wetlands, used for paddy cultivation, and forested highlands, which have transformed into the now-famous coffee estates of Coorg.



Issue with Jamma Bane Lands

- **Ownership:** The Jamma Bane land ownership is registered in the name of the original pattedar from a family.
- Over generations, the names of the new owners are added alongside the name of the pattedar.
- The land ownership name could not be changed to reflect new owners

Karnataka Launches Gruha Lakshmi Digital Marketing Portal

- Gruha Lakshmi Digital Marketing is a Karnataka government initiative.
- **It promotes women entrepreneurship through a state-backed e-commerce portal.**

- The scheme is implemented by the Department of Women and Child Development.
- Focus areas include rural women, artisans, and digital inclusion.

Neolithic Relics Unearthed at Lakkundi Boost UNESCO Bid

- Recent excavations at Lakkundi in Karnataka have unearthed Neolithic-era artefacts, strengthening the State's push to include Lakkundi in UNESCO's World Heritage Site list.
- **An Archaeological Survey of India (ASI)–supervised excavation at the Kote Veerabhadreshwar (Veerabhadraswamy) Temple**, aimed at uncovering buried structures and cultural layers to support heritage conservation and UNESCO nomination.
- Lakkundi village, Gadag district, Karnataka, about 12 km from Gadag town; historically known as Lakkigundi.



Discoveries made at Lakkundi:

- **Neolithic artefacts:** broken grey clay pot, stone axe, cowrie shells, cross-shaped pedestal.
- **Early historic–medieval finds:** stone pedestal carved with a Jina figure, inscriptions, buried temple remains.
- **Confirms continuous human occupation** from prehistoric to early medieval periods.

History of the place:

- A major economic, religious and cultural centre from the 10th–13th centuries.
- **Flourished under the Kalyana Chalukyas and later the Hoysalas; famous as the “village of a hundred wells and temples”.**
- Associated with Queen Attimabbe (11th century), noted Jain patron and philanthropist.
- Home to Hindu temples, Jain basadis, stepwells, and later even a Muslim dargah, reflecting religious pluralism.
- Known for the “Lakkundi school” of Chalukyan temple architecture.

Tamil Nadu

First Jallikattu Event of 2026 Approved in Tamil Nadu

- The Tamil Nadu government has granted permission for the first Jallikattu event of 2026 to be held on January 3 at Thatchankurichi village in Pudukkottai district, officially marking the beginning of the state's annual bull-taming season.
- The event has been permitted under the provisions of the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act, 1960, as amended by the Tamil Nadu Amendment Act, 2017.
- Thatchankurichi holds a unique place in Tamil Nadu's Jallikattu tradition, as it customarily hosts the first event of every season.

What is Jallikattu?

- Jallikattu is a traditional sport that is popular in the Indian state of Tamil Nadu.
- The sport involves releasing a wild bull into a crowd of people, and the participants attempt to grab the bull's hump and ride it for as long as possible, or attempt to bring it under control.
- It is celebrated in the month of January, during the Tamil harvest festival, Pongal.



Young Ambassadors of Change Initiative

- A government school in Trichy, Tamil Nadu, has launched an innovative value-education programme to inculcate moral values and social responsibility among children through daily practice rather than rote learning.
- **A school-based value education initiative launched at the Government Aadi Dravidar Primary School, Kattur**, aimed at nurturing core moral and civic values among children through experiential and community-linked learning.

IIT Madras Pravartak Swayam Plus launch free AI training for rural school teachers

- IITM Pravartak Technologies Foundation has partnered with SWAYAM Plus to launch Artificial Intelligence Training for Rural School Teachers across India.
- **These courses are being offered at no cost to the participants.**
- **The 'AI for Educators – K12 Teachers'** (Classes I to XII) Certification Course will start from February 5.
- This 40-hour programme is designed to help teachers confidently adopt AI tools and methodologies to enhance learning outcomes while ensuring inclusive and responsible use of technology in schools and colleges
- **SWAYAM (Study Webs of Active–Learning for Young Aspiring Minds) is India's own MOOCs (Massive Open Online Course) platform** of the Ministry of Education (MoE) initiative and was launched during 2017.
- It seeks to bridge the digital divide for students who have hitherto remained untouched by the digital revolution and have not been able to join the mainstream of the knowledge economy.



Kerala

India's First Fully Paperless District Judiciary Launched

- India marked a milestone in judicial reform as Chief Justice of India Surya Kant virtually inaugurated the country's first fully paperless district judiciary in Kalpetta, Wayanad, Kerala.
- **For the first time, an entire district court system has shifted to end-to-end digital functioning**, signalling a transformative change in access to justice.
- All courts in Kalpetta district now operate entirely digitally, with electronic filings, digital scrutiny, and instant access through the District Court Case Management System (DCMS) developed in-house by Kerala High Court.



Kochi to Host 9th International Spice Conference 2026

- The All India Spices Exporters Forum (AISEF) will host the 9th edition of the International Spice Conference (ISC 2026) from February 23 to 26, 2026 in Kochi.
- **The 4-day conference theme -- "Spice 360 – Getting Future Ready"** -



World Spice Organisation

- The World Spice Organisation (WSO) is a collaborative platform that unites all stakeholders in the spice industry—farmers, processors, academics, and end-users. Its mission is to work collectively towards sustainable development.
- **It was established in 2011 with the objectives of achieving Food Safety and Sustainability in the spice sector.**

Kerala to observe January 4 as Registration Day

- The State Registration department will observe January 4 as Registration Day every year, with the first State-level celebrations to be held on January 4.
- **The first registration system in the country was established at Anjarakandy in Kannur in 1865** by British official Murdoch Brown in connection with the registration of a cinnamon plantation.
- Records show that the first registration under the system took place on January 4, 1867, prompting the government to choose the date for annual observance.

Kerala Sangeetha Nataka Akademi unveils logo of ITFoK 2026

- The Kerala Sangeetha Nataka Akademi has unveiled the logo of the International Theatre Festival of Kerala (ITFoK 2026), which will be held from January 25 to February 1.



- **This year's theme, Voices in Silence.**
- The logo was designed by Thrissur Ads Creations.

PM Modi flags off four new trains in Kerala, launches SVANidhi Credit Card

- Prime Minister Narendra Modi flagged off the newly allotted three new Amrit Bharat Express trains and one passenger train service for Kerala, in Thiruvananthapuram .
- **Mr. Modi has also launched the PM SVANidhi Credit Card, marking the next phase of financial inclusion for street vendors.**
- The UPI-linked, interest-free revolving credit facility will provide instant liquidity, promote digital transactions, and help beneficiaries build formal credit histories.
- The foundation stone for the CSIR-NIIST Innovation, Technology and Entrepreneurship Hub was also laid.



PM SVANidhi Scheme

- It was **initially launched on 1st June 2020** to support street vendors who faced unprecedented hardships during the COVID-19 pandemic.
- It is **implemented jointly by the Ministry of Housing & Urban Affairs (MoHUA) and Department of Financial Services (DFS)**, with DFS being responsible for facilitating access to loan/credit cards through banks/financial institutions and their ground level functionaries

Recently, Kerala officially declared Bacillus subtilis as 'State microbe'

- Bacillus subtilis (B. subtilis) is a type of probiotic ("good" bacteria) found naturally in the human gut.
- **It's also found in fermented foods.**
- It is mostly found in soil and vegetation with an optimal growth temperature from 25-35 degrees Celsius.
- **B. subtilis has the ability to produce and secrete antibiotics.**
- Endospores of B. subtilis can tolerate harsh environmental conditions, such as UV exposure and high temperatures.
- Bacillus subtilis Transmission and Disease: B.subtilis is non-pathogenic but can contaminate food and be considered an opportunistic pathogen among the immuno-compromised.



Applications Bacillus Subtilis

- They are used on seeds, vegetables, and plants as a fungicide because of their ability to produce antibiotics.
- It **inhabits the root system of the plant competing with disease causing organisms.**

Andaman and Nicobar Islands

Union Minister Dr Jitendra Singh Launches India's First Open-Sea Marine Fish Farming Project at North Bay, Andaman Sea

- Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Science & Technology, Earth Sciences, and MoS PMO, Personnel, Public Grievances, Pensions, Atomic Energy and Space, Dr. Jitendra Singh, launched India's first-ever open-sea Marine Fish Farming project from the Andaman Sea.
- The pilot initiative focuses on **open-sea cultivation of marine finfish and seaweed in natural ocean conditions, integrating scientific innovation with livelihood generation.**

Himachal Pradesh

25th January - Himachal Pradesh Statehood Day

- Himachal Pradesh was officially declared a state on **25th January 1971, becoming the 18th state of India.**
- **1948:** HP formed as a Chief Commissioner's Province.



- **1950:** Became a Part C State
- **1956:** Became a Union Territory
- **1966:** Kangra & other Punjab hill areas merged; HP remained UT.
- **1970–71:** State of HP Act (18 Dec 1970) → Full state on 25 Jan 1971, 18th state of India

Ramsar Sites in Himachal Pradesh:

- **Chandertal Wetland** (Lahual Spiti)
- **Pong Dam Lake** (Kangra)
- **Renuka Wetland** (Sismaur)
- **CM** – Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu
- **Governor** – Shiv Pratap Shukla



National Park of Himachal Pradesh
Great Himalayan National Park
Pin Valley National Park
Inderkilla National Park
Khirganga National Park
Col. Sherjung Simbalbara National Park

Uttarakhand

Uttarakhand Implements Uniform Civil Code (Amendment) Ordinance, 2026

- The Uttarakhand Government has implemented the Uniform Civil Code (Amendment) Ordinance, 2026, to introduce necessary amendments to the UCC Act, 2024, following the approval of the Governor.
- The Chief Minister's Office, the ordinance has been promulgated by the Governor of Uttarakhand, under Article 213 of the Constitution of India and has come into force with immediate effect.
- On the completion of one year, "UCC Day" is being observed across the state.
- Its objective is to remove ambiguities, align penal provisions with new criminal laws and ensure smoother implementation.
- UCC is for all residents of the State, **except the Scheduled Tribes and natives who have migrated out of the State**
- **Online registration of marriages, divorce and live-in relationships mandatory;** govt launches new portal; **people can also upload their will.**
- Became the **second state** in the country, and the **first** to do so **in independent India**, to implement a Uniform Civil Code (UCC).
- **Goa continued** with its **Portuguese Civil Code of 1867** when it **became part of India in 1961**. Then it was a Union Territory.
- **Article 44 of the Indian Constitution** - state shall endeavour to secure for the citizens a **uniform civil code** throughout the territory of India.
- For Uttarakhand UCC, Retired Supreme Court judge **Ranjana Prakash Desai** was **appointed** as the **chairperson of expert committee to draft the UCC** – **submitted on February 2, 2024**
- **After legislative approval and President's assent**, Chief Minister **Pushkar Singh Dhami** declared **27th January, 2025** as the official **implementation date**.



Delhi

12th edition of Smile International Film Festival for Children and Youth begins in New Delhi

- The 12th edition of Smile International Film Festival for Children and Youth-SIFFCY, organised by Smile Foundation, has begun in New Delhi.
- **This seven-day event has been organised in collaboration with the Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities.**
- The event is organised with the support of the embassies of Ukraine, the Netherlands, Finland, the Czech Republic, Lithuania, Cyprus, Estonia, the Polish Institute, and the Italian Cultural Centre.



Haryana

39th Surajkund Festival begins with theme Local to Global – Atmanirbhar Bharat

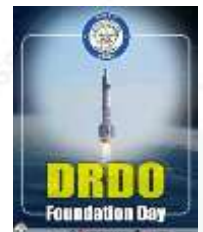
- Vice President C P Radhakrishnan on 31st January inaugurated the 39th Surajkund International Crafts Mela 2026 at Surajkund in Faridabad, Haryana. Mr Radhakrishnan also launched the Mela Sathi App during the event.
- This year, the central theme of the fair is Local to Global,
- Uttar Pradesh and Meghalaya are the theme state of this year's fair to cherish the visitors.
- This time, Egypt will participate as the partner nation in the fair.
- The festival will be held till 15th of next month.



Defence

1st January DRDO celebrates 68th Foundation Day

- Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) celebrated its 68th Foundation Day on January 01, 2026.
- **DRDO was formed in 1958 by merging the then-existing Technical Development Establishment (TDEs) of the Indian Army and the Directorate of Technical Development and Production (DTDP) with the Defence Science Organisation (DSO)**
- **Headed by:** It is headed by the Secretary, Department of Defence, R & D, and the Director General of DRDO.
- The DG is assisted by scientists designated as Chief Controllers in technology domains



DRDO conducts launch of two Pralay missiles in rapid succession from Odisha coast

- DRDO conducted a salvo launch of two indigenous Pralay missiles from the same launcher.
- Ministry of Defence confirmed both missiles met mission objectives; tracked by Integrated Test Range sensors.

Pralay missile:

- **Type:** Solid-fuel, surface-to-surface, quasi-ballistic
- **Range:** 150–500 km | Payload: 500–1,000 kg
- **Warheads:** Multiple types
- **Developed by:** Research Centre Imarat with other DRDO labs
- **Industry partners:** Bharat Dynamics Limited, Bharat Electronics Limited (and MSMEs)



Close Quarter Battle (CQB) Carbine

- **The Ministry of Defence recently signed defence procurement contracts worth ₹4,666 crore for the acquisition of Close Quarter Battle (CQB) Carbines for the Indian Army and Navy and Heavyweight Torpedoes for the Indian Navy.**
- CQB Carbine is an indigenously designed, developed, and manufactured (IDDM) compact firearm.
- **It has been designed by DRDO's Armament Research & Development Establishment (ARDE), Pune, and is being manufactured by Bharat Forge Ltd (a Pune based Indian multinational).**



- **CQB carbines are compact, lightweight weapons designed specifically for urban warfare**, close-range engagements and counter-terrorism operations.

Albert Ekka Brigade Marks 56th Raising Day in Agartala

- The Albert Ekka Brigade has earned the highest gallantry awards in war and peacetime, including the Param Vir Chakra (1971).
- **Recently relocated to Agartala Military Station, from where Operation Cactus Lily was launched.**
- **1971 war comprised two major operations** — Operation Cactus Lily and Operation Nut Cracker .
- **Both operations progressed from Agartala westwards towards Dhaka** and culminated on December 16, 1971, with the unconditional surrender of 93,000 Pakistani soldiers.
- Albert Ekka (14 Guards) made the supreme sacrifice clearing an enemy bunker threatening Agartala; awarded Param Vir Chakra (posthumous).

Rajnath Singh to commission ICG ship Samudra Pratap in Goa on Jan 5 Panaji

- Defence Minister Rajnath Singh will commission Indian Coast Guard ship 'Samudra Pratap', the first of two pollution control vessels, at Goa Shipyard Limited, Vasco, in South Goa .
- **The vessel has been designed and constructed by Goa Shipyard Limited (GSL) under the two-ship PCV project.**
- The vessel is equipped with advanced systems to detect oil spills, enabling comprehensive pollution response operations within the Exclusive Economic Zone and beyond.

The Indian Army, under the aegis of Trishakti Corps, establishes a 10kW solar power plant at Muguthang village

- The Indian Army, under the aegis of the Trishakti Corps, has established a 10 kW solar power plant in Muguthang village, located **near the India–China border in North Sikkim** at an altitude of approximately 15,000 feet.
- The project was implemented under the Government of India's Vibrant Villages Programme to provide reliable, year-round electricity to this remote and high-altitude settlement.

Pak Air Force successfully conducts flight test of indigenously developed Taimoor missile

- "Taimoor Air-Launched Cruise Missile is capable of engaging enemy land and sea targets with high precision at a range of 600 kilometers, carrying a conventional warhead,"

Suryastra rocket system

- The Indian Army has signed a ₹293-crore emergency procurement contract with NIBE Ltd., in collaboration with Elbit Systems, to induct the Suryastra rocket system, a long-range universal launcher with strike ranges up to 300 km.
- **Suryastra is India's first indigenous universal multi-calibre long-range rocket launcher system, capable of conducting precision surface-to-surface strikes at 150 km and 300 km ranges.**
- It is designed to integrate multiple rocket and missile types on a single launch platform.

Army set to deploy ramjet-powered shells for 155 mm artillery guns

- The Indian Army is set to become the first armed force in **the world to operationally deploy ramjet-powered artillery shells for its 155 mm guns.**
- Ramjet-powered artillery shells are advanced 155 mm projectiles fitted with an air-breathing ramjet propulsion module, allowing them to sustain thrust after being fired from a conventional artillery gun.

Key features:

- **Range:** 30–50% increase for 155 mm shells
- **Fit:** Retrofit on existing artillery (incl. M777)
- **Tech:** Air-breathing propulsion (>4000 Ns/kg)
- **Impact:** Deeper precision strikes
- **Made in India:** IIT Madras & Army Technology Board

About Ramjet technology:

- A ramjet is a type of air-breathing jet engine with no moving parts, designed to operate efficiently at supersonic speeds. Unlike rockets, it does not carry its own oxidiser and instead uses atmospheric oxygen for combustion.



Indian Army Declares 2026 as 'Year of Networking & Data Centricity'

- The Indian Army declared 2026 as the 'Year of Networking & Data Centricity'
- **This initiative will enhance connectivity, real-time decision-making and combat effectiveness, thereby strengthening resilience and agility for a future-ready force.**
- The Army had declared 2024-25 as the 'Year of Technology Absorption'.

**DRDO Develops Portable Desalination System for Soldiers in Remote Areas – SWaDeS**

- The Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) has developed a portable water desalination gadget to meet the drinking water requirements of a small group of soldiers in the field.
- Sea Water Desalination System (SWaDeS), can be operated manually or run by an engine.
- **Developed by the Defence Laboratory, Jodhpur.**
- The engine operated system has the capability of purifying sea water having a salinity of 35,000 milligrams per litre of total dissolved solids (mg/L TDS) to less than 500 mg/L TDS to meet the requirement of 20-25 soldiers.
- **The manual version of SWaDeS can be carried by a single person and can meet the emergency requirements of a group of 10-12 personnel** who may be out on a long range patrol or deployed in remote areas
- These systems include a Chemical Biological Radiological and Nuclear Water Purification System for use in contaminated environments.

**Indian Army Raises Bhairav Force for Drone Warfare**

- The Indian Army has developed a pool of more than one lakh drone-trained operatives and raised a new specialised force named Bhairav.
- **The force is being positioned to address the growing role of unmanned systems and high-tempo operations on the modern battlefield.** This initiative are trained to operate drones in live combat scenarios, including strikes against enemy bases and formations deep inside hostile territory.
- **Beyond Bhairav, the Army is also raising Rudra Brigades, integrated all-arms formations combining infantry, armour, mechanised elements, artillery, special forces, unmanned systems, and dedicated logistics and combat support, to enhance battlefield flexibility.**

**Long Range Anti-Ship Missile (LRASHM)**

- India's indigenous LR-ASHM missile will be on display at the Republic Day parade on January 26, highlighting the country's growing maritime strike capability.

About Long Range Anti-Ship Missile (LRASHM)

- It is a hypersonic glide missile developed by the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO).
- **Hypersonic glide vehicles (HGVs) like the LRASHM differ from traditional ballistic missiles, which follow a fixed trajectory.**
- HGVs are launched on a rocket, ascend to the upper atmosphere, and then glide towards their target in an unpredictable manner.
- It outperforms similar missiles like China's DF-17 in terms of range and technology.
- It is being built for anti-ship roles (to target enemy warships and carrier groups) and may also evolve into a land-attack variant.
- **It is reported to have a range of over 1,500 kilometers.**
- This missile operates at 10 Mach, making it 10 times faster than the speed of sound.
- **This missile can obliterate an enemy ship or warship within 7 to 8 minutes of being launched.**

Rajasthan CM Bhajan Lal Sharma inaugurates Know Your Army exhibition in Jaipur ahead of 78th Army Day

- As part of the events being held to mark the 78th Army Day, Know Your Army exhibition began at the Bhawani Niketan Education Committee campus in Jaipur.
- India will celebrate its 78th Army Day on 15 January 2026.
- **The five-day event held at Bhawani Niketan College Ground on Sikar Road featured an array of military equipment, including missiles, drones, tanks, and weapons used in Operation Sindoor against terror camps in Pakistan.**



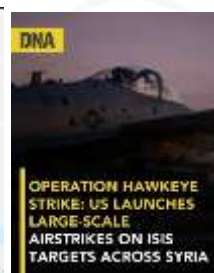
Amit Shah launches NSG's national IED data platform

- Union Home Minister Amit Shah launched a national IED data management platform created by counter-terrorist commando force NSG.
- It is the facility that connected the platform, located at the National Security Guard (NSG) garrison in Manesar Gurugram.**
- The platform will collect and analyse improvised explosive device (IED) data gathered from across the country and disseminate it to security agencies.
- Raised in 1984, the NSG's 'black cat' commandos are tasked to undertake specific counter-terrorist and counter-hijack operations besides protecting select high-risk VIPs.



The Directorate General of Mines Safety (DGMS)

- The Directorate General of Mines Safety (DGMS) marked its 125th Foundation Day (2026), reaffirming its role in mine workers' safety and welfare.
- DGMS is the statutory regulatory authority under the Ministry of Labour & Employment, Government of India,** responsible for occupational safety, health, and welfare of persons employed in coal, metalliferous, and oil mines.
- Established in:** 1902, making it one of India's oldest labour safety institutions.
- Headquarters:** Dhanbad, Jharkhand
- Aim:** To achieve risk- and hazard-free working conditions in mines and ensure the health, safety, and welfare of mine workers, in line with the vision of "First Safety".



Operation Hawkeye Strike Targets ISIS Across Syria

- The United States and allied forces have conducted large-scale airstrikes across Syria under Operation Hawkeye Strike, targeting multiple Islamic State positions.
- Operation Hawkeye Strike was launched on December 19, 2025.
- Syria Capital :** Damascus
- Syria, country located on the east coast of the Mediterranean Sea in southwestern Asia.
- Syria is bounded by Turkey to the north, by Iraq to the east and southeast, by Jordan to the south, and by Lebanon and Israel to the southwest.

Bhairav Battalions to make Army Day Parade debut in Jaipur on January 15

- The Indian Army's newly raised Bhairav Battalion will march for the first time on Kartavya Path during the Republic Day parade.
- These are compact, high-tech combat units, each with about 250 soldiers from multiple arms.
- Designed for swift, surprise, and high-impact operations.
- Unlike Para Special forces, they are deployed near borders for tactical, fast-response missions.**
- Built to "fight tonight"—ready for immediate action.
- They act as a bridge between Special Forces and regular infantry.



Indian Army Conducts Exercise Sanjha Shakti in Maharashtra

- The Indian Army recently conducted exercise 'Sanjha Shakti', a joint Military-Civil Fusion exercise, at the Dighi Hills Range under the aegis of the Maharashtra, Gujarat and Goa Area of the Southern Command.
- The exercise focused on strengthening coordination between the armed forces and civilian agencies to deal with complex security challenges and emergency situations.
- The drill brought together personnel from the Indian Army and 16 key civilian agencies, including the Maharashtra Police, Force One, and fire and emergency services.



Boeing E-4B Nightwatch Latest News

- Amid high geopolitical tensions, the Boeing E-4B Nightwatch made a rare appearance in Los Angeles, sparking panic.
- Known as the US military's "Doomsday Plane", it is among the most secretive aircraft in the US arsenal.



- It serves as the **National Airborne Operations Center (NAOC)** and functions as a **flying command post**.
- Designed to keep the US government operational during nuclear war, catastrophic attacks, or destruction of ground command centres.
- **4 aircraft in service; one always on alert.**
- **Activated only once in real crisis**—after 9/11 (2001).
- Built on a modified Boeing 747-200.

Man Portable Anti-Tank Guided Missile (MPATGM)

- DRDO successfully **flight-tested the Third-Generation Fire & Forget Man Portable Anti-Tank Guided Missile (MPATGM)** with top-attack capability against a moving target.
- MPATGM is a third-generation, fire-and-forget, shoulder-launched anti-tank guided missile system designed to destroy modern main battle tanks and armoured vehicles.
- **Tandem HEAT warhead:** A two-stage explosive first defeats reactive armour and then penetrates the main armour. **It has 200–4,000 m range.**
- **Developed by:** Developed by DRDO, led by Defence Research & Development Laboratory (Hyderabad).



Indian Army Inducts Solar-Powered MAPSS Surveillance Drone

- Indian Army has placed a Rs 168 crore order with Bengaluru-based startup **NewSpace Research & Technologies (NRT)** for its **Medium Altitude Persistent Surveillance System (MAPSS)**, a fully electric, solar-powered unmanned aerial vehicle (UAV).
- This is the first time when the Indian armed forces would be deploying solar-powered surveillance UAVs than the battery powered and tethered drones currently in use.
- The **drone is designed to provide long-endurance intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance (ISR)**, electronic intelligence (ELINT), and communications relay support
- The MAPSS will feature a lightweight construction, solar recharging for long endurance flights, and **modular payloads with advanced mission autonomy for operations in GNSS-denied zones**—while prioritising persistence without frequent refuelling or landings.
- The MAPSS delivers a first-of-its-kind sovereign hardware delivery via the iDEX's UAV development vector for India.



Indian Army Launches DIME Platform to Transform Logistics Management

- Indian Army has launched **Depot Integration Management Edition (DIME)**, a **pan-Army digital platform that delivers real-time visibility of logistic items from units to Army Headquarters, transforming Army logistics**,
- Developed jointly by the Indian Army and Bhaskaracharya National Institute for Space Applications and Geo-informatics (BISAG-N).
- DIME operationalises standardised digital workflows across all depots and units, while equipping commanders with integrated dashboards, exception alerts and predictive stock analytics for proactive logistics.

RBS-15 Missile

- **Saab (Sweden) showcased RBS-15 missile's capability** to destroy components of Russia's S-400 system.

RBS-15 Missile:

- **Type:** Fire-and-forget, anti-ship & land-attack (surface-to-surface, air-to-surface).
- **Developer:** Saab Bofors Dynamics.
- **Weight:** 800 kg (launch), 650 kg (in-flight).
- **Range & speed:** 200 km, Mach 0.9 (subsonic).
- **Features:** Low sea-skimming, evasive manoeuvres, low RCS & IR signature.
- **Guidance:** INS + GPS, radar altimeter, Ku-band radar seeker.

DOSTI-17 Coast Guard Exercise Strengthens Trilateral Maritime Cooperation

- India, Maldives and Sri Lanka have launched Exercise DOSTI in Male to enhance maritime cooperation and collective security in the Indian Ocean on January 19, 2026.
- **Hosted by the Maldives.**
- Exercise DOSTI-17 has commenced in Male with the participation of India, Maldives and Sri Lanka.
- **Frequency:** Biennial (every two years)



- **First Conducted:** 1991 (India–Maldives)
- **Sri Lanka Joined: 2012**
- The trilateral naval drill focuses on search and rescue, communication, and coordination to address shared regional security challenges.

BRICS Plus naval exercise

- India's decision to skip the BRICS Plus naval exercise "Will for Peace 2026" has drawn attention as New Delhi clarified that such drills are not institutionalised BRICS activities and reflected a considered political choice amid evolving geopolitics.
- **The BRICS Plus naval exercise is a host-led, non-institutionalised maritime drill involving selected BRICS members** and invited partner countries, conducted outside the formal BRICS framework.
- **Host nation:** South Africa
- Conducted off the coast of Simon's Town, near Cape Town.

Member participants:

- **Participating navies:** China, Russia, Iran, United Arab Emirates, South Africa
- **Observers:** Brazil, Egypt, Ethiopia, Indonesia
- Non-participants: India, Brazil (opted out of active participation)
- **Theme:** "Joint Actions to Ensure the Safety of Key Shipping Lanes and Maritime Economic Activities".

INS SAGARDHWANI FLAGS OFF FOR SAGAR MAITRI V

- INS Sagardhwani, **India's oceanographic research vessel under the Naval Physical and Oceanographic Laboratory (NPOL) of DRDO, was flagged off for the fifth edition of the Sagar Maitri (SM-5) initiative from Southern Naval Command, Kochi on 17 Jan 2026.**
- Sagar Maitri is a flagship collaborative initiative of the Indian Navy and DRDO, aligned with the Government of India's vision of 'Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions (MAHASAGAR)'.
- **The initiative aims to promote closer cooperation in socio-economic aspects and greater scientific interaction**, especially in ocean research, among Indian Ocean Rim (IOR) countries.
- Under the aegis of this programme, DRDO initiated a **scientific component titled 'MAITRI (Marine & Allied Interdisciplinary Training and Research Initiative)' to establish long-term collaboration with IOR countries** in the field of ocean research and development.
- Under the Sagar Maitri programme, INS Sagardhwani will retrace the historic routes of INS Kistna, which participated in the International Indian Ocean Expedition during 1962–65.
- The initiative seeks to build sustained scientific collaboration with eight IOR countries, namely Oman, Maldives, Sri Lanka, Thailand, Malaysia, Singapore, Indonesia, and Myanmar.
- INS Sagardhwani is a specialised marine acoustic research vessel designed by NPOL and built by Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers (GRSE).
- Commissioned in Jul 1994.



Type 096 Tang-Class Submarine

- China has unveiled the most significant upgrade to its undersea nuclear capability with the unveiling of the Type 096 Tang-Class ballistic missile submarine recently.
- The Type 096 (NATO reporting name of Tang-class) submarine is China's next-generation nuclear-powered ballistic missile submarine (SSBN).
- It is bigger, stealthier, and armed with longer-range missiles than its predecessors
- It will displace around 20,000 tons when submerged, placing it in the same weight class as the U.S. Navy's Ohio-class submarines.
- The submarine is expected to carry between 16 and 24 JL-3 submarine-launched ballistic missiles (SLBMs), each capable of ranges exceeding 10,000 to 12,000 kilometers and equipped with multiple independently targetable reentry vehicles (MIRVs).
- It can also launch wire-guided, high-speed Yu-6 torpedoes with a range of over 29 km.
-



Operation Trashi-I

- Operation Trashi-I - security forces intensified counter-terrorism operations in the dense forests of Kishtwar, Jammu & Kashmir.



- **Operation Trashi-I** is a multi-day counter-terrorism and area-domination operation aimed at tracking, neutralising, and dismantling terrorist groups operating in the forested belts of the Chatroo region in Kishtwar district.
- **Launched by:** The operation is being conducted jointly by the Indian Army, Jammu & Kashmir Police (including SOG), and Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), based on specific intelligence inputs.

Operation Megaburu

- Operation Megaburu, a major anti-Maoist offensive in Jharkhand's West Singhbhum district, led to the killing of 16 Maoists, including top CPI (Maoist) leader Anal alias Patiram Manjhi.
- **Operation Megaburu is a large-scale counter-insurgency operation** against the CPI (Maoist), conducted in the Saranda forest region, one of the last major Maoist strongholds in Jharkhand.
- **Launched in:** January 2026
- **Location:** Kumdi area, Kiriburu police station, West Singhbhum district, Jharkhand
- **Forces involved:** Central Reserve Police Force (elite CoBRA units) and Jharkhand Police

The Border Roads Organisation (BRO) carried out a high-altitude rescue and road restoration operation under Project Sampark at Chatergala Pass

- **Location:** It is situated at an altitude of 10,500 ft. in the Bhaderwah–Chatergala axis in Jammu region of Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir.
- It is a high mountain pass that connects Bani in the Kathua district to Bhaderwah in the Doda district.
- It is tucked in the Chamba-doda ranges of the greater Himalayas.
- **Terrain:** It is surrounded by alpine meadows, snow-covered peaks, and dense forest

Military Quantum Mission Policy Framework

- The Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) General Anil Chauhan has released the Military Quantum Mission Policy Framework to integrate quantum technologies into the Indian Armed Forces.
- **Aim:**
- To integrate quantum capabilities across tri-services through jointness and interoperability.
- **To align defence requirements with the National Quantum Mission using a civil–military fusion approach.**

QS Europe Rankings 2026: Oxford Leads, Top Universities Listed

- The QS World University Rankings Europe 2026 have been released.

Compiled by Quacquarelli Symonds (QS),

- The **University of Oxford** has secured the first position
- ETH Zurich followed closely at second place,
- Seven of the top 10 are UK universities.

Captain Hansja Sharma Makes History as Rudra Helicopter Pilot

- Captain Hansja Sharma has scripted a historic first by becoming the **Indian Army's first woman officer qualified to fly the Rudra Armed Helicopter.**
- Captain Sharma recently led the 251 Army Aviation Squadron during the Army Day Parade 2026 in Rajasthan. The formation showcased the HELINA anti-tank guided missile,
- **Rudra is officially designated as ALH-WSI (Weapon System Integrated).**
- It is a weaponised variant of the Advanced Light Helicopter Dhruv.

V-BAT Autonomous Drones.

- The Indian Army officially **selected the US-based firm Shield AI to supply its cutting-edge V-BAT autonomous drones.**
- The V-BAT is a Group 3 Vertical Take-Off and Landing (VTOL) Unmanned Aircraft System (UAS).
- **Unlike traditional drones that require runways, the V-BAT uses a unique ducted-fan design to take off and land vertically** like a rocket, then transition to horizontal flight for surveillance.
- **Developed By:** Original Equipment Manufacturer (OEM): Shield AI (US-based Deep-Tech firm).
- **Indian Partner:** JSW Defence, which is establishing a \$90 million manufacturing hub in Hyderabad to make India a global production base for the V-BAT.

Bengaluru-based defence equipment manufacturer Alpha Design Technologies Ltd (ADTL) has completed a major upgrade of the 's (IAF) Pechora



- The Pechora, officially known as the S-125 Neva/Pechora, is a **Soviet-origin, medium-range surface-to-air missile (SAM) system designed to intercept low- to medium-altitude targets.**
- It has been a mainstay of India's air defence network since the 1970s.
- The system consists of a radar-guided missile launcher and a fire control unit, typically employing the V-600 missile.
- It is particularly effective against slow-moving or low-flying targets, making it well-suited for countering drones and cruise missiles.
- **Range:** operational firing range of up to 30–35.4 km, with some upgraded versions reaching 35.4 km.
- **Altitude:** It can engage targets flying at altitudes from as low as 20 meters up to 20–25 km.
- **Detection:** can detect targets up to 100 km away.
- **Accuracy:** High kill probability of around 92% and can engage up to two targets simultaneously at speeds up to 900 m/s.



Science & tech

ISRO to launch PSLV-C62/EOS-N1 Mission on January 12

- ISRO's PSLV-C62 rocket is set to lift off from the first launchpad at Sriharikota, marking India's first space launch of 2026.

About PSLV-C62 Mission

- It is a multi-payload mission of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) that will carry one primary satellite and 18 secondary payloads into space.
- It is **ISRO's first space launch of 2026.**
- It is scheduled to lift off from Sriharikota.

PSLV-C62 Mission :

- **Primary payload:** EOS-N1 (Anvesha) — a hyperspectral Earth observation satellite developed mainly for DRDO for strategic purposes.
- **Uses:** National security, border surveillance, strategic monitoring, and civilian applications such as agriculture planning, urban mapping, mineral detection, and environmental monitoring.
- **Re-entry experiment:** Europe's Kestrel Initial Demonstrator (KID) — a small re-entry capsule developed with a Spanish startup. Expected to re-enter Earth's atmosphere and splash down in the South Pacific Ocean.
- **Historic first:** Bengaluru-based OrbitAID Aerospace's AayulSAT
- **India's first on-orbit satellite refuelling payload.**



Artemis II Mission

- NASA is on track to send humans around the moon as early as the first week of February as it makes final preparations for the imminent rollout of its Artemis 2 mega moon rocket.

About Artemis II Mission

- It will be the first mission to carry humans to the moon's vicinity since 1972.
- It is the **second scheduled flight of the Artemis program and the first crewed Artemis mission.**
- It is the first to fly astronauts aboard the Space Launch System (SLS) rocket and Orion spacecraft.
- **First crewed Orion mission beyond LEO in 50+ years** (Artemis I was uncrewed, 2022).
- 4 astronauts (3 NASA + 1 CSA) on a 10-day lunar flyby and return.
- **Tests systems for Artemis III (aim: lunar landing by 2028).**
- Carries payloads to study space radiation, human health/behaviour, and communications.
- **Artemis Program – Key Facts**
- NASA's program to return humans to the Moon and prepare for Mars.
- Goal: land the first woman and first person of colour on the Moon; explore lunar surface.
- **Upcoming**



- **Artemis III:** First crewed Moon landing since Apollo 17 (1972); aims to land first woman & first person of colour.
- **Artemis IV:** Delivers core of Gateway and lands two astronauts on the Moon.
-

Setback for ISRO: PSLV-C62 mission faces anomaly at the end of third stage

- ISRO's PSLV-C62 mission experienced an anomaly at the end of the PS3 stage, and a detailed investigation has been launched to analyze the issue.

PSLV-C62 Mission

- It is a multi-payload mission of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) that carries one primary satellite and 15 secondary payloads into space.
- It is **ISRO's first space launch of 2026**.
- It is scheduled to lift off from Sriharikota.
- EOS-N1 (Anvesha) is a hyperspectral Earth observation satellite developed mainly for DRDO for strategic use.
- It detects objects across hundreds of wavelengths, enabling high-precision material identification.
- **PSLV-C62 carries Europe's Kestrel Initial Demonstrator (KID), a small experimental re-entry capsule.**



Voyager 1

- Voyager 1 is expected to become the first human-made object to reach a distance of one light-day from Earth.

About Voyager 1

- It is a space probe launched by NASA in 1977.
- **Objective:** To explore the outer planets in our solar system.
- It is the first spacecraft to travel beyond the solar system and reach interstellar space.
- **It is currently the most distant human-made object from Earth.**
- Voyager 1's mission has included flybys of Jupiter and Saturn, with the goal of studying their moons, rings, and magnetic fields.
- **Instruments of Voyager 1:** Cosmic Ray Subsystem, Plasma Wave Subsystem, Infrared Interferometer Spectrometer and Radiometer (IRIS) etc..



Key Achievements of Voyager 1

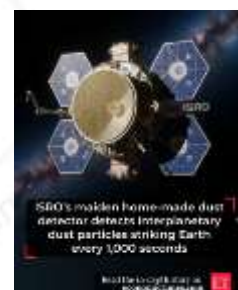
- It was the first spacecraft to cross the heliosphere, the boundary where the influences outside our solar system are stronger than those from our Sun.
- It crossed into interstellar space in August 2012, making it the first human-made object to venture out of the solar system.
- **It discovered a thin ring around Jupiter and two new Jovian moons: Thebe and Metis.**
- It also found five new moons and a new ring called the G-ring at Saturn

Dust Experiment (DEX)

- Recently, the Indian Space Research Organisation confirmed through its first-ever Dust Experiment (DEX) that an interplanetary dust particle enters Earth's atmosphere approximately every 1,000 seconds.

About Dust Experiment (DEX)

- It is the first Indian-made instrument to hunt for these high speed Interplanetary Dust Particles (IDPs).
- It is the **first-of-its-kind instrument designed to detect such high-transient particles.**
- It is **developed by the Physical Research Laboratory, Ahmedabad.**
- It was flown on PSLV Orbital Experimental Module (POEM) of the PSLV-C58 XPoSat Mission on January 1, 2024



Features of Dust Experiment (DEX)

- It is a compact instrument tuned to hear impacts, capturing vital data.
- At the core of the experiment lies a 3-kilogram dust detector based on the **cutting-edge hypervelocity principle designed to capture high-speed space dust impacts** with only 4.5 W power consumption.
- **It rocketed to an altitude of 350Km.**

- DEX is a blueprint of the detector which can study the cosmic dust particle at any planet having an atmosphere or no atmosphere.

Hubble Discovers Starless Dark Matter Cloud Near Messier 94

- Astronomers may have discovered a previously **unknown type of astronomical object, nicknamed "Cloud-9," that could shed light on dark matter, from NASA's Hubble Space Telescope.**
- Cloud-9 is scientifically classified as a Reionization-Limited H I Cloud (RELHIC).
- **"H I" refers to neutral hydrogen, meaning the gas is non-ionised**
- Located about 14 million light-years from Earth near the spiral galaxy Messier 94



Vera C. Rubin Observatory

- Scientists analyzing the first images from the Vera C. Rubin Observatory recently discovered the fastest-spinning asteroid in its size class yet named 2025 MN45.

About Vera C. Rubin Observatory

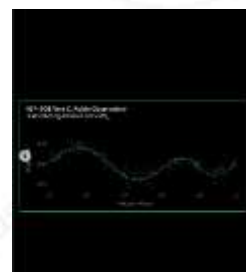
- It is located 8,684 feet **above sea level atop the Cerro Pachón mountain in the Chilean Andes, where dry air and dark skies provide one of the world's best observing locations.**
- It is named after American astronomer Vera C. Rubin, who provided evidence about dark matter for the first time in the 1970s.

The observatory has four main scientific goals:

- Understand the nature of dark matter and dark energy.
- Create an inventory of the asteroids, comets, and other objects in the solar system.
- Map the Milky Way and help reconstruct its history.
- Explore objects — like exploding stars and black holes — that change position or brightness over time.
- **The centrepiece of the observatory is the Simonyi Survey Telescope**

Key Facts about 2025 MN45

- It is a newly discovered asteroid.
- It resides in the main asteroid belt between Mars and Jupiter.
- It completes one rotation every 1.88 minutes, making it "the fastest-spinning asteroid with a diameter over 500 meters that astronomers have found."



W Ursae Majoris Star

- Astronomers from **Aryabhata Research Institute of Observational Sciences used data from Devasthal Fast Optical Telescope and NASA's TESS space telescope** to create detailed light curves of the W Ursae Majoris (W UMa) star.

About W Ursae Majoris Star

- It is also known as a low mass contact binary, is a type of eclipsing binary variable star.
- **They share a single outer atmosphere and they orbit around each other.**
- W UMa stars are easily recognized by their light curves with near equal minima and continuous light variation.
- **The idea of the contact binary seems to have been first introduced by Kuiper (1941).**
- The stars share outer layers and show slightly shifting orbits due to mutual pull.
- Some stars are lopsided, brighter on one side.
- **Uneven brightness is caused by dark magnetic star spots.**
- **These spots rotate, creating bumps in light curves.**



IIT Madras Launches Param Shakti Supercomputer

- Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) launched 'Param Shakti' at Indian Institute of Technology Madras.
- The project has been funded under the National Supercomputing Mission (NSM)

About Param Shakti

- It is an indigenously developed and manufactured 3.1 Petaflop supercomputing system.
- It is now among the most powerful computational systems available in Indian academic institutions.

About National Supercomputing Mission (NSM)

- **Launched: 2015**

- **Objective:** To connect national academic and R&D (research and development) institutions with a grid of over 70 high-performance computing facilities.
- NSM is steered jointly by the Department of Science and Technology (DST) and MeitY.
- **Implemented by the Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC), Pune,** and the Indian Institute of Science (IISc), Bengaluru.



India's Supercomputer

- PARAM 8000 is India's first supercomputer.
- Param Pravega is the largest supercomputer
- Param Shivay is first indigenously build supercomputer
- **AIRAWAT is a common compute platform for AI research and knowledge assimilation.**

India Develops 3D-Printed Automatic Weather Stations Under Mission Mausam

- The first batch of these **next-generation stations will be deployed in Delhi from February 2026**, marking a major step towards strengthening India's weather observation and forecasting network.
- The initiative is being led by the Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology under the Ministry of Earth Sciences as part of Mission Mausam, a ₹2,000 crore national programme aimed at upgrading meteorological infrastructure.
- **Mission Mausam focuses on eliminating data gaps in weather observations, especially in urban and climate-sensitive regions, to improve forecast accuracy.**



What is Rubin: Nvidia's AI supercomputing platform

- Nvidia has unveiled Rubin, a next-generation GPU architecture and **tightly integrated AI computing platform that is set to replace the US chip giant's current flagship Blackwell architecture.**
- **Rubin is Nvidia's first extreme-codesigned platform and will comprise six AI chips,** alongside various networking technologies and system software, all working together as a single computing unit.
- Nvidia also announced its latest series of open-weight AI reasoning models called Alpamayo that is designed specifically for autonomous vehicles like self-driving cars.



Indian scientists develop first supercomputer-powered simulation to capture Mpemba effect

- Indian scientists have developed the first supercomputer-powered simulation that **successfully captures the Mpemba effect, resolving a long-standing scientific paradox of hot water freezing faster than cold.**
- The Mpemba effect refers to the counterintuitive phenomenon **where hot water freezes faster than cold water under specific experimental conditions.**
- **Named after Erasto Mpemba,** a Tanzanian student who reported it scientifically in 1969, though it was noted earlier by Aristotle, Bacon, and Descartes.



SCORP Emerges as India's First Legged Mobile Manipulator

- India has marked a major milestone in advanced robotics with the unveiling of SCORP, the country's first legged mobile manipulator, developed by deep-tech startup xTerra Robotics.
- **Incubated at IIT Kanpur.**
- Legged mobile manipulators combine legged mobility with robotic arms.



White Dwarf

- Recently, astronomers have observed a white dwarf that is creating a colorful shockwave as it moves through space.

About White Dwarf

- It is the stellar core left behind after a dying star has exhausted its nuclear fuel and expelled its outer layers to form a planetary nebula.
- It is what stars like the Sun become after they have exhausted their nuclear fuel.
- It no longer supports nuclear fusion reactions that generate energy, but they are still extremely hot.
- Size: A typical white dwarf is half as massive as the Sun, yet only slightly bigger than Earth.



- This makes white dwarfs one of the densest collections of matter, surpassed only by neutron stars.

India Registers High-Yielding Synthetic Cattle Breeds

- Recently, India has registered two high-yielding synthetic cattle breeds namely Karan Fries and Vrindavani.

About Karan Fries

- It is developed by the National Dairy Research Institute (NDRI) in Karnal, Haryana.
- It is a cross between indigenous Tharparkar cows and Holstein-Friesian bulls.



About Vrindavani

- It is developed by ICAR-Indian Veterinary Research Institute (IVRI) in Bareilly, Uttar Pradesh.
- It is a blend of exotic breeds – Holstein-Friesian, Brown Swiss, and Jersey – with the indigenous Haryana cattle.

Key Facts about Indian Council of Agricultural Research

- It is an autonomous organisation under the Department of Agricultural Research and Education (DARE), Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare.
- It is the apex body for coordinating, guiding, and managing research and education in agriculture, including horticulture, fisheries, and animal sciences, throughout the country.
- **History:** Formerly known as the Imperial Council of Agricultural Research, it was established on 16 July 1929 as a registered society under the Societies Registration Act, 1860, in pursuance of the report of the Royal Commission on Agriculture.
- **Headquarters:** New Delhi

BSNL Launches Nationwide VoWiFi Service Across India

- BSNL has launched Voice over WiFi (VoWiFi) services nationwide across all telecom circles, enabling calls and messages over Wi-Fi.
- **Voice over WiFi (VoWiFi) is a technology that allows users to make and receive voice calls and SMS over a Wi-Fi network instead of a mobile tower.**
- It works using IMS (IP Multimedia Subsystem) and uses the same mobile number and phone dialer, without any third-party app.



How VoWiFi works :

- **Wi-Fi connection:** Phone uses home/office/public Wi-Fi instead of a mobile tower.
- **SIM authentication:** Secure login via SIM, same security as normal calls.
- **Internet routing:** Voice converts to digital data packets and travels over the internet.
- **Seamless handover:** If Wi-Fi weakens, call auto-switches to VoLTE without drop.

Govt bans manufacturing, sale and distribution of oral drug Nimesulide above 100 mg

- This move is in consultation with the Drugs Technical Advisory Board and has been banned under section 26A of the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940.
- **It said that the use of all oral formulations containing Nimesulide is likely to involve risk to human beings.**
- Nimesulide is a nonsteroidal antiinflammatory drug which is widely used in the treatment of acute pain.



First Oral Pill for Thalassemia Anaemia Approved by US FDA

- The US Food and Drug Administration's (FDA) approval of the **first-ever oral pill for anaemia in adults with thalassemia** mitapivat (to be marketed under the brand name Aqvesme) for the treatment of anemia in adults with alpha- or beta-thalassemia.
- **Mitapivat is the first medication indicated for both transfusion-dependent and non-transfusion-dependent forms of these rare, inherited blood disorders.**
- Mitapivat is a first-in-class medication designed to improve the energy balance within red blood cells.



Thalassemia

- It is an inherited blood disorder.
- It affects your body's ability to produce normal hemoglobin.
- **Hemoglobin is a protein in red blood cells (RBCs).** It allows your RBCs to transport oxygen throughout your body.

- If you have thalassemia, your body produces fewer healthy hemoglobin proteins, and your bone marrow produces fewer healthy RBCs

Webb Telescope Delivers Sharpest Dark Matter Map Yet

- **NASA's James Webb Space Telescope have made one of the most detailed, high-resolution maps of dark matter ever produced.** It shows how the invisible, ghostly material overlaps and intertwines with "regular" matter, the stuff that makes up stars, galaxies, and everything we can see.
- This is the largest dark matter map we've made with Webb, and it's twice as sharp as any dark matter map made by other observatories,"
- **Dark matter constitutes about 85% of all matter in the universe.**
- Dark matter - a mysterious substance that neither emits nor reflects light.



Researchers have used seismometers to detect the sonic booms created by debris from orbit falling back to the earth

- A sonic boom is a thunderous noise caused by an object, like an aircraft, moving faster than the speed of sound.

How is it Formed?

- As the object zooms through the sky, the air molecules around it are pushed aside with tremendous force, generating shock waves along its flight path.
- The release of pressure, following the shock waves' buildup, is heard as the sonic boom.

G4 (Severe) Geomagnetic Storm

- A powerful G4 (Severe) Geomagnetic Storm, caused by solar activity, has lit up the night skies with spectacular auroras visible across multiple continents.

About Geomagnetic Storms

- A geomagnetic storm is a major disturbance of Earth's magnetosphere that occurs when there is a very efficient exchange of energy from the solar wind into the space environment surrounding Earth.
- **These storms result from variations in the solar wind that produce major changes in the currents, plasmas, and fields in Earth's magnetosphere.**
- The solar wind conditions that are effective for creating geomagnetic storms are sustained (for several hours) periods of the high-speed solar wind and a southward-directed solar wind magnetic field (opposite the direction of Earth's field) at the dayside of the magnetosphere.
- **The largest such storms are associated with solar coronal mass ejections (CMEs), where a billion tons or so of plasma from the sun, with its embedded magnetic field, arrives at Earth.**
- **It results in intense currents in the magnetosphere, changes in the radiation belts, and changes in the ionosphere, including heating the ionosphere and an upper atmosphere region called the thermosphere.**
- These storms can heat the ionosphere, causing beautiful auroras on earth.

What is Solar Wind?

- It is a continual stream of protons and electrons from the sun's outermost atmosphere, the corona.
- These charged particles breeze through the solar system at speeds ranging from around 250 miles (400 kilometers) per second to 500 miles (800 km) per second, in a plasma state.
- **Solar magnetic field is embedded in the plasma and flows outward with the solar wind.**
- Different regions of the Sun produce solar wind of different speeds and densities.
- When the solar wind reaches Earth, it sends a flurry of charged particles into the magnetosphere and along Earth's magnetic field lines, towards the poles.

Intrinsically Disordered Proteins

- Researchers have developed a deep-learning tool named Disobind that can predict how intrinsically disordered proteins (IDP) latch on to their binding partners.

About Intrinsically Disordered Proteins

- Intrinsically disordered proteins are defined as proteins or regions of proteins that lack a fixed or ordered three-dimensional structure under biological conditions.
- **Other Names:** Also called natively unfolded or intrinsically unstructured proteins.
- These are important for cellular signaling and regulation.
- **They help proteins move and find partners within the cell, regulate which genes are switched on or off.**

Key Facts about Disobind Tool

- It is developed by the researchers of National Centre for Biological Sciences (NCBS), Tata Institute of Fundamental Research, Bengaluru.
- It is **open-source and freely available for researchers worldwide**.
- It analyses the protein sequences and uses protein language models (a form of AI trained on millions of known protein sequences).
- No structural info needed:** It does not require any structural information or sequence alignments, making it super convenient.
- Applications of the tool could span from disease biology to drug design.

Vitamin A

- Researchers recently uncovered new ways a vitamin A-derived molecule can interfere with the immune system's ability to fight cancer.

About Vitamin A

- It is a fat-soluble vitamin primarily stored in the liver.
- There are two types of vitamin A that are found in the diet.**
- Preformed vitamin A is found in animal products such as meat, fish, poultry, and dairy foods.
- Precursors to vitamin A, also known as provitamin A, are found in plant-based foods such as fruits and vegetables.
- These compounds are converted to the active form in your body.
- The most common type of provitamin A is beta-carotene.

Foods with the highest levels of vitamin A include:

- Beef liver and other organ meats
- Some types of fish such as herring and salmon and cod fish oil
- Eggs
- Dairy products such as cheese and fortified milk
- Fortified breakfast cereals
- Orange and yellow vegetables and fruits, such as carrots, sweet potatoes, mangos, and cantaloupe
- Broccoli, spinach, and most dark green, leafy vegetables

Function:

- Vitamin A helps form and maintain healthy teeth, skeletal and soft tissue, mucus membranes, and skin.
- It is also known as retinol because it produces the pigments in the retina of the eye.
- Vitamin A promotes good eyesight, especially in low light.
- It also has a role in healthy pregnancy and breastfeeding.
- If you do not get enough vitamin A, you have more risk of eye problems such as:
- Reversible night blindness
- Non-reversible corneal damage known as xerophthalmia
- It can also lead to hyperkeratosis or dry, scaly skin.

Borax

- In a tragic incident from Tamil Nadu, a 19-year-old college girl recently died after consuming borax for weight loss.

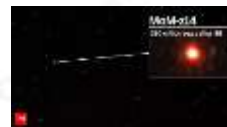
About Borax

- Borax, also known as sodium tetraborate decahydrate, is a powdery white mineral.
- It's a combination of boron, sodium, and oxygen.
- Chemical Formula: $\text{Na}_2\text{B}_4\text{O}_7 \cdot 10\text{H}_2\text{O}$**
- It is used in many ways—as a component of glass and pottery glazes in the ceramics industry,** as a solvent for metal-oxide slags in metallurgy, as a flux in welding and soldering, and as a fertilizer additive, a soap supplement, a disinfectant, a mouthwash, and a water softener.
- Borax occurs naturally in evaporite deposits produced by the repeated evaporation of seasonal lakes.
- Borax can also be produced synthetically from other boron compounds.**
- Naturally occurring borax is refined by the process of recrystallization.



James Webb Telescope Detects Most Distant Galaxy MoM-z14

- The James Webb Space Telescope (JWST) has found the most distant galaxy ever observed, named MoM-z14.
- **The newly discovered galaxy existed just 280 million years after the Big Bang.**
- MoM-z14's light has travelled over 13.5 billion years to reach Earth



The James Webb Space Telescope .

- Launched: December 25, 2021.
- Developed by: NASA, in collaboration with ESA (European Space Agency) and CSA (Canadian Space Agency).



The IIT-Kanpur team developed a new way to predict solar cycles

- **The solar cycle describes an approximately 11-year cycle of solar activity driven by the sun's magnetic field.**
- It is indicated by the frequency and intensity of sunspots visible on the surface.
- Every 11 years or so, the Sun's magnetic field completely flips.
- This means that the Sun's north and south poles switch places.
- **As the magnetic fields change, so does the amount of activity on the Sun's surface.**
- It can be tracked by counting the number of sunspots.



Doomsday Clock is 85 seconds to midnight

- The Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists has moved the Doomsday Clock to 85 seconds to midnight, the closest ever to global catastrophe (January 2026).
- **It is a symbolic clock showing how close humanity is to global annihilation ("doomsday"), with midnight representing catastrophe.**
- The clock's hands move closer to or farther from midnight based on threats from nuclear weapons, climate change, and disruptive technologies.
- **The clock was created in 1947 by the Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists (BAS).**

Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists (BAS)

- A non-profit organization formed to warn the public about the dangers of nuclear weapons.
- **Founded in September 1945** at the University of Chicago by the Atomic Scientists of Chicago.
- Its founding members and sponsors were scientists who had contributed to the development of the first atomic bombs as part of the Manhattan Project, including physicists Albert Einstein, J. Robert Oppenheimer, and Eugene Rabinowitch.

Nipah Virus

- India recently confirmed two Nipah virus cases in West Bengal since December, with **health authorities containing the situation amid misinformation and heightened airport screenings in parts of Asia.**
- Nipah virus (NiV) is a zoonotic virus (it is transmitted from animals to humans) and can also be transmitted through contaminated food or directly between people.
- **Fruit bats of the Pteropodidae family are the natural hosts of Nipah virus.**
- In infected people, it causes a range of illnesses from asymptomatic (subclinical) infection to acute respiratory illness and fatal encephalitis.
- **No specifically approved treatment or vaccine** is currently available for Nipah virus infection in humans or animals.



Environment

Eastern Imperial Eagle

- **Wildlife enthusiasts recently confirmed the presence of an Eastern Imperial Eagle visiting the Mudumalai Tiger Reserve (MTR) during the winter migratory season.**

About Eastern Imperial Eagle

- It is a large bird of prey.
- It breeds in southeastern Europe and extensively through West and Central Asia.
- Most populations are migratory and winter in northeastern Africa, the Middle East and South and East Asia.



- It is classified as 'Vulnerable' under the IUCN Red List

Mudumalai Tiger Reserve (MTR)

- It is located in the Nilgiris District of Tamil Nadu, spread over 321 sq. km. at the tri-junction of three states, viz., Karnataka, Kerala, and Tamil Nadu.
- It is **part of the Nilgiris Biosphere Reserve**, the first biosphere reserve in India.
- The name Mudumalai means "the ancient hill range". Indeed, it is as old as 65 million years, when the Western Ghats were formed
- The Oscar-winning 'Elephant Whisperers' was filmed at the Theppakadu Elephant Camp, located inside the Mudumalai Tiger Reserve**

Amazonian Stingless Bees Granted Legal Rights in Peru

- The **Satipo Municipality (Peru) has adopted the Declaration of Rights for Native Stingless Bees (Tribe Meliponini)** through a municipal ordinance, granting legal rights to Amazonian stingless bees, to preserve Peru's biocultural heritage.
- This establishes **the first legal recognition of insect rights globally**, strengthening biocultural conservation and nature-rights governance models.



What are Amazonian Stingless Bees?

- They are native stingless pollinators of the Amazon rainforest, traditionally protected and cultivated by Indigenous communities.
- They are among the oldest bee species on Earth, responsible for pollinating over 80% of Amazonian flora.**
- They are **not completely devoid of a stinger**; rather they possess a vestigial stinger that is too small to be used for defense.
- Hence, they defend their hives by biting or secreting irritating resins.

India loses 166 tigers in 2025, forty more than last year; Madhya Pradesh accounts for 55 deaths

- India recorded a total of 166 tiger deaths in 2025 according to National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA) data — an increase of 40 deaths compared to 2024, when 126 tiger deaths were recorded.
- Madhya Pradesh recorded the highest number of tiger deaths** at 55, accounting for about one-third of the national total



US Bomb Cyclone Disrupts Holiday Travel Nationwide

- A powerful winter storm, Winter Storm Ezra, rapidly intensified into a bomb cyclone over the US, disrupting peak holiday travel with mass flight cancellations, blizzards, power outages, and hurricane-force winds across multiple states.
- A bomb cyclone is a powerful mid-latitude weather system that undergoes explosive cyclogenesis, marked by an exceptionally rapid fall in central air pressure within 24 hours, resulting in severe and wide-ranging weather impacts.**



How it forms?

- Bomb cyclones form when cold, dense polar air collides with warm, moisture-rich air, typically over oceans where sharp temperature contrasts provide abundant latent heat energy.
- The rapid upward movement of warm air lowers surface pressure sharply, drawing surrounding air inward at high speeds and causing the storm to intensify explosively.

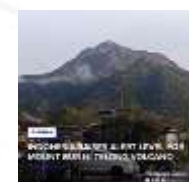


Indonesia Raises Alert for Mount Bur Ni Telong Volcano

- Indonesian authorities recently raised the alert for Mount Bur Ni Telong volcano due to increased activity, including numerous earthquakes

About Mount Bur Ni Telong

- It is an active stratovolcano.
- It is **located in Indonesia's westernmost province of Aceh.**
- It is formed by multiple layers of lava and eruptive materials, making it prone to explosive eruptions and highly hazardous.



What is a Stratovolcano?

- It is a tall, steep, and cone-shaped type of volcano.
- Unlike flat shield volcanoes, they have higher peaks.
- They are typically found above subduction zones**, and they are often part of large volcanically active regions, such as the Ring of Fire that frames much of the Pacific Ocean.
- Strato Volcanoes comprise the largest percentage (~60%) of the Earth's individual volcanoes**, and most are characterized by eruptions of andesite and dacite, lavas that are cooler and more viscous than basalt.

Karnataka Spots Its First 'Sandalwood Leopard'

- An ultra-rare leopard colour morph has been documented for the first time in Karnataka, in Vijayanagara district.
- Most leopards (*Panthera pardus*) possess tawny coats with black rosettes.** However, this exceptionally rare colour morph exhibits a pale reddish-pink coat—resembling the hue of sandalwood—with light-brown rosettes.
- In India, Sandalwood Leopards are extremely rare.**



Lucknow To Get India's First Urban Night Safari At Kukrail Forest Area

- Lucknow is set to introduce India's first urban night safari at the Kukrail Forest Area, marking a unique blend of wildlife conservation and city-based tourism.
- India's first urban night safari—a controlled nocturnal wildlife viewing experience within city limits, designed for education, conservation awareness, and low-impact tourism rather than entertainment-driven spectacle.
- Kukrail Forest Area, along the Kukrail River is Existing conservation hubs for crocodiles, gharials, and turtles.
- Eco-friendly infrastructure: bamboo huts, nature walk trails, interpretation centres.



Asian Waterbird Census records 1,310 birds at Delhi Zoo

- The Asian Waterbird Census (AWC) conducted by the National Zoological Park in Delhi on, National Bird Day, recorded a total of 1,310 birds across 18 species in the zoo's wetlands.
- Of the 1,310 birds, 930 are Painted Storks.**
- Other species included Little Grebe, Little Cormorant, Black-crowned Night Heron, Indian Pond Heron, Little Egret, Large Egret, Red-naped Ibis, Indian Spot-billed Duck, Common Teal, Northern Shoveler, Red-wattled Lapwing, Common Sandpiper, White-breasted Waterhen, Common Moorhen, Rosy Pelican, Small Blue Kingfisher and White-breasted Kingfisher.

Asian Waterbird Census (AWC)

- A citizen-science programme for wetland and waterbird conservation.
- Part of the International Waterbird Ce
- nsus (IWC) by Wetlands International, with parallel regional counts worldwide.

Census In India

- Started in 1987; now spans Asia from Afghanistan to Japan, including Southeast Asia and Australasia.
- In India, coordinated by Bombay Natural History Society and Wetlands International.

Calamaria Mizoramensis

- A new species of reed snake was recently found in Mizoram, which the researchers named after the state where it was found, calling it Calamaria Mizoramensis.

About Calamaria Mizoramensis

- It is a new species of non-venomous reed snake.
- The new species is nocturnal and semi-fossorial, inhabiting humid, forested hill environments.
- Its occurrence in other parts of India remains unverified**, but it is likely to be present in adjoining states such as Manipur, Nagaland, and Assam.



India has inaugurated the world's second National Environmental Standard Laboratory (NESL)

- India has inaugurated the world's second National Environmental Standard Laboratory (NESL) and the **world's fifth National Primary Standard Facility for Solar Cell Calibration at CSIR-NPL, New Delhi.**
- The National Environmental Standard Laboratory is an apex national facility for testing, calibration, and certification of air pollution monitoring equipment under Indian climatic



and environmental conditions.

- **An advanced metrology facility for high-precision solar cell (PV) calibration at global standards.**
- **Located at:** CSIR–National Physical Laboratory, New Delhi.

Fierce winds battered France and Britain as Storm Goretti barrelled through northern Europe



Aralam declared as Kerala's first butterfly sanctuary

- **The Kerala government has officially renamed the Aralam Wildlife Sanctuary the Aralam Butterfly Sanctuary, making it the first butterfly sanctuary in the State.**
- India's first protected forest dedicated entirely to butterflies.
- Declared a sanctuary in 1984, Aralam spans 55 sq km of evergreen and semi-evergreen forests in Kannur district.
- **The region is known for large-scale butterfly migration and mud-puddling and is also a special habitat of the Schedule 1 Slender loris.**



Pufferfish

- Recently, scientists have confirmed India's first case of pufferfish poisoning.

About Pufferfish

- **Pufferfish belong to the order Tetraodontiformes.**
- **Other names:** They are locally known by names such as toadfish, patkafish, balloonfish and fugu.
- **Habitat:** Pufferfish are omnivorous and benthic in habitat.
- **Distribution:** It is primarily found in the Western Ghats and major basins such as the Ganga, Brahmaputra and Mahanadi.
- Freshwater pufferfish species reported from India are often endemic to specific geographical areas and serve as indicators of healthy river ecosystems.
- **Conservation Status** :IUCN: Vulnerable



Pufferfish Poisoning

- Some puffer fish carry tetrodotoxin (TTX) which is one of the most potent neurotoxins known in nature.
- **Tetrodotoxin blocks nerve sodium channels and can cause paralysis, respiratory failure and death.**
- TTX is heat-stable, water-soluble, and a non-protein quinazoline derivative.

Hemileccinum Indicum

- Researchers exploring the temperate forests of the Indian Himalayas have discovered a previously unknown species of mushroom named Hemileccinum indicum.
- **It is a new species of mushroom.**
- It was found growing among oak trees in the Bageshwar district of Uttarakhand.
- It marks the first time the genus Hemileccinum has been documented in India.



Coconut root wilt disease

- Coconut Root Wilt Disease is in the news due to its rapid spread across major coconut-growing regions of Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Karnataka, affecting lakhs of palms.
- **A debilitating, non-fatal disease of coconut caused by a phytoplasma (phloem-limited pathogen),** leading to chronic decline and major yield loss.
- First reported over 150 years ago from Erattupetta (Kerala) and has remained a persistent endemic problem.
- **Spread is vector-borne,** and is accelerated by continuous coconut belts, wind-assisted vector movement, and rising abiotic stress (temperature extremes) plus biotic stress (new sucking pests like whiteflies) that increase palm susceptibility.

Gegeneophis Valmiki

- Indian scientists recently discovered a rare subterranean amphibian species in the northern Western Ghats of Maharashtra and named it Gegeneophis valmiki.

About Gegeneophis valmiki



- The name Gegeneophis valmiki honors the historic Maharshi Valmiki Mandir located near the discovery site.
- Caecilians, often called “hidden amphibians”, are limbless, worm-like creatures that spend most of their lives underground.
- They look and move so much like earthworms.

Microscopic crustacean discovered in Kavaratti established as a new genus and species, say researchers

- Recently, a microscopic crustacean was discovered in Kavaratti which has been named Indiaphonte bijoyi, with the generic name Indiaphonte.

About Indiaphonte Bijoyi

- It is a tiny crustacean discovered from the Kavaratti lagoon in the Lakshadweep islands.
- It belongs to the family Laophontidae within the Copepoda class.
- **Habitat:** It lives in sediments in aquatic environments.



Ecological Role

- They are sensitive to pollution, oil spills, heavy metals, and climate change and are considered reliable bio-indicators of environmental change.
- They are widely used in aquaculture and fisheries, especially as live feed for fish larvae.
- **They produce and convert omega-3 fatty acids such as Eicosapentaenoic Acid (EPA) and Docosahexaenoic Acid (DHA) that are essential for the growth of fish and shellfish and contribute significantly to human nutritional security.**

Brandt's Hedgehog Discovered in Jammu and Kashmir

- A new species of hedgehog, Brandt's hedgehog, not so far found in India, has been recently discovered in Jammu and Kashmir, DNA analysis and morphological studies reveal.
- **Brandt's Hedgehog :** It is a species of desert hedgehog.
- It inhabits arid and semi-arid regions, including rocky deserts, scrublands, and dry mountain slopes.
- **It is still capable of digging dens when absolutely needed.** It hibernates during colder weather.
- It is **classified as 'Least concern' under the IUCN Red List**



Two new rare ant fly species discovered in Delhi and Western Ghats

- Researchers have discovered two new, extremely rare ant fly species from Delhi and the Western Ghats, underscoring the hidden biodiversity of urban forests and biodiversity hotspots.
- **Ant flies belong to the subfamily Microdontinae (family Syrphidae) and are renowned for myrmecophily**—their larvae live inside ant nests and feed on ant brood. This specialised ecology makes them exceptionally rare and hard to detect.



Metadon ghorpadei

Discovery site: Northern Ridge Forest, Delhi Ridge (urban, disturbed habitat)

Metadon reemeri

- **Scientific name:** Metadon reemeri
- **Discovery site:** Siruvani Hills, Western Ghats, Tamil Nadu
 - Part of a poorly studied insect group despite the region's strong protection.



Indian Skimmer

- The Bombay Natural History Society (BNHS) and the National Mission for Clean Ganga (NMCG) have launched a new conservation project to protect the endangered Indian Skimmer and its breeding habitats across the Ganga Basin.
- The Indian Skimmer (Rynchops albicollis) is a riverine bird species known for its unique feeding behaviour of skimming the water surface with an elongated lower mandible to catch fish.



Habitat:

- Large, slow-flowing rivers with exposed sandbars and islands.
- Breeds mainly along river systems such as the Ganga, Chambal, Yamuna, and their tributaries.
- Uses coastal areas during the non-breeding season.

IUCN status: Endangered (EN) on the IUCN Red List

Striped Tiger Butterfly declared 'State Butterfly' of Chandigarh

- The State Board of Wildlife (SBWL) declared the Striped Tiger Butterfly as the State Butterfly of Chandigarh
- The Striped Tiger Butterfly is seen as a symbol of resilience and strength,



Chatham Islands

- **A bloom of phytoplankton—tiny photosynthetic organisms that become visible to satellites when their numbers explode—**encircled the Chatham Islands in austral summer recently.



About Chatham Islands

- It is an island group in the South Pacific Ocean, about 800 km east of New Zealand.
- Composed of 10 islands, they are primarily of volcanic formation, but areas of limestone indicate that they may once have been part of New Zealand.
- **Only the two main islands are inhabited:** Chatham Island and Pitt Island.
- **Chatham Island, the largest of the islands, has a high southern tableland flanked by towering cliffs** and a gentle northern portion encompassing extensive waterways, low peatlands and long sandy beaches.
- Pitt Island has a heartland of forest and a coast of wild cliffs, headlands, and sandy beaches.
- **The Chatham Islands is the first inhabited place in the world to see the rising sun each day.**
- The islands were first inhabited by Moriori, who named the islands 'Rekohu' – translated as 'misty skies' or 'misty sun'.

Tropical Storm Nokaen Raises Lahar Risk at Mayon Volcano

- **The first tropical cyclone of the year, Tropical Storm Nokaen, locally named Ada, is posing fresh risks for communities around Mayon Volcano in the Philippines.**
- Authorities have warned that the storm could trigger dangerous lahars and muddy streamflows
- **Lahars are volcanic mudflows composed of water and volcanic debris.**
- Mayon Volcano is one of the most active volcanoes in the Philippines.



China Satellite Tracks Final Breakup of Giant Iceberg A23a

- China's Fengyun-3D meteorological satellite has detected that iceberg A23a, once the largest iceberg in the world by surface area, has entered the final stage of disintegration.
- **A23a was the world's largest iceberg by area, about 4,170 square kilometres when it broke away in 1986.**
- It broke away from Antarctica's Filchner Ice Shelf.
- Hydrofracturing is a key mechanism behind iceberg breakup.
- Polar-orbiting satellites monitor cryospheric changes.



Second range-wide Dolphin Survey

- The second range-wide Dolphin Survey has been launched from Bijnor, Uttar Pradesh under Project Dolphin to update population estimates, assess habitats and threats.
- A pan-India scientific estimation exercise to assess population, distribution, habitat condition and threats to riverine and estuarine dolphins, conducted in two phases across major river systems and coastal/estuarine stretches.



Implementation & coverage

- **Phase I:** Main stem of the Ganga (Bijnor to Ganga Sagar) and the Indus River.
- **Phase II:** Brahmaputra, Ganga tributaries, Sundarbans, and Odisha.
- **Coordinated by** Wildlife Institute of India, with State Forest Departments and conservation partners.
- **Project Dolphin** is a national conservation initiative of the Government of India aimed at protecting riverine and oceanic dolphins through habitat protection, scientific monitoring, and stakeholder participation.
- **Launched in:** 15 August 2020
- **Nodal ministry:** Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change.
- **Aim:** To safeguard India's dolphin diversity by addressing threats such as habitat degradation, pollution, by-catch, and flow alteration, while empowering local communities in conservation.

High Seas Treaty enters into force after decades of negotiations

- **The UN Biodiversity Beyond National Jurisdiction (BBNJ) Treaty, also known as the High Seas Treaty, has entered into force after crossing the required 60 ratifications**, creating the first legally binding global framework to protect biodiversity in international waters.
- The BBNJ Agreement is a legally binding international treaty under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) to conserve and sustainably use marine biodiversity in areas beyond national jurisdiction (the High Seas).



Origin and history:

- Negotiations began in 2008 amid growing concern over unregulated exploitation of the high seas.
- After 15 years of negotiations, the treaty was finalised in March 2023.
- It entered into force 120 days after the 60th ratification, which was achieved in September 2025.

Targets:

- **Achieve the “30 by 30” goal:** protect 30% of the global ocean area by 2030.
- Enable large-scale conservation across two-thirds of the ocean, which lies beyond national control.

Arabian Sea

- **Unusual boiling or bubbling of seawater has been reported in the Arabian Sea off the Gujarat coast, raising concerns among fishermen and authorities.**
- The Arabian Sea is a northwestern arm of the Indian Ocean, forming a crucial maritime space linking Europe, West Asia, Africa, and South Asia, and serving as one of the world’s busiest sea routes.



Bordering nations:

- India, Pakistan, Iran, Oman, Yemen, and Somalia.
- **Connected to the Persian Gulf via the Strait of Hormuz and to the Red Sea via the Bab-el-Mandeb Strait.**

Issue of the ‘boiling’ phenomenon:

- Characterised by intense churning and bubbling of seawater, resembling surface boiling

Possible causes under examination:

- Natural methane or gas seepage from seabed.
- Underwater tectonic or volcanic activity along submarine ridges.
- **Industrial causes, such as leakage from undersea pipelines or shipping-related disturbances.**



Key geological features:

- Formed ~50 million years ago due to the collision of the Indian Plate with Eurasia.
- **Dominated by deep basins:** Arabian Basin and Somali Basin.
- **Presence of Carlsberg Ridge and Murray Ridge – seismically active submarine ridges.**
- Upwelling zones along Somali and Arabian coasts during the southwest monsoon.

Cold winter storm ‘Fern’ set to take over United States

- The storm is being driven by a powerful surge of Arctic air arriving during what is typically the coldest time of the year. The cold front is expected to strengthen in the Southwest on Thursday before moving eastward
- **Several states have already declared emergencies ahead of the storm.**
- Officially, the storm has not been given a name. However, the Weather Channel uses its own naming system and has labeled this storm Fern.



Pangolakha Wildlife Sanctuary

- Recently, a forest fire continued to rage inside Sikkim’s Pangolakha Wildlife Sanctuary along the Indo-China border at an altitude of 13,000 feet.
- **Location:** It is located in the state of Sikkim.
- It is connected to the forests of Bhutan and Neora Valley National Park in West Bengal.
- **The Pangolakha Range, extending below the Chola Range, separates Sikkim from Bhutan.**
- Lakes: Lake Tsongmo which is a biodiversity hotspot for migratory birds.



Kumbhalgarh Wildlife Sanctuary Declared Eco-Sensitive Zone

- The Centre recently declared the biodiversity-rich area, ranging from zero to one kilometre around Kumbhalgarh Wildlife Sanctuary, located in one of the most fragile ecosystems of the Aravali Range in Rajasthan, as an eco-sensitive zone (ESZ).
- **About Kumbhalgarh Wildlife Sanctuary**
- It is situated in the Rajsamand district of Rajasthan.
- It spreads in an area of 610.5 sq.km. stretching across the Aravalli ranges.
- It covers four hill and mountain ranges of the Aravallis – the Kumbhalgarh Range, the Sadri Range, the Desuri Range, and the Bokhada Range.
- Once the hunting grounds of royals, this area was declared a wildlife sanctuary in 1971.
- **It encompasses the historic Kumbhalgarh Fort and is also named after the fort.**
- The sanctuary's landscape is varied. The eastern part has hills ranging from 500 to 1300 meters high, while the western part borders the Marwar plains.



Drainage:

- The eastern section is the starting point for the Banas River, which flows into the Bay of Bengal.
- Meanwhile, rainwater from the western slopes forms small rivers like Sukdi, Sumer, Mithdi, and Kot, all of which are tributaries of the Luni River that eventually flow into the Arabian Sea.

Gandak River

- The Gandak River has emerged as the second major river after the Chambal with the highest number of gharials, also known as fish-eating crocodiles.
- **The Gandak River, also known as the Narayani and Gandaki, is one of the major rivers in Nepal and a left-bank tributary of the Ganges in India.**
- It is mentioned in the ancient Sanskrit epic Mahabharata.
- It originates to the north of Dhaulagiri Mountain in Tibet near the Nepal border.
- After flowing through Tibet, it crosses Nepal, where it is also known as Narayani, to enter the Indian Territory.
- **The river enters India from Valmikinagar in the West Champaran district of Bihar. The entry point of the river is at the Indo–Nepal border and is known as Triveni.**
- In India, it flows southeast, across the upper Gangetic plain in eastern Uttar Pradesh and northwestern Bihar.
- Gandak joins Ganga near Patna in Vaishali district of Bihar.
- While flowing through the Nepal Himalayas, it forms the Kali Gandaki gorge, one of the deepest river gorges in the world.
- **Two important protected areas**, Chitwan National Park in Nepal and the adjacent Valmiki Tiger reserve in India, have been established in the basin.
- **Major Tributaries:** Daraudi, Seti, Madi, Marsyandi, and Budhi Gandaki.

Key Facts about Gharial

- It is a freshwater crocodile.
- **Scientific Name:** Gavialis gangeticus
- The name 'gharial' comes from the Hindi word ghara, meaning pot or vessel, referring to the bulbous snout tip of adult males, which resembles an inverted pot.
- **Historically, the gharial's range spanned rivers of Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Myanmar, Nepal and Pakistan.**
- **The Gharial reserves of India are located in three States:** Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, and Rajasthan.
- In India, the National Chambal Sanctuary holds about 90% of the surviving gharials.
- **IUCN Red List:** Critically Endangered.

Hoya Nagaensis

- Recently, a new plant species has been discovered in Nagaland and it's named as Hoya Nagaensis.
- It is a new plant species found in the high-altitude forests of Nagaland.
- **It is a member of the 'wax plant family' discovered in the Kavunhou Community**



Reserved Forest in Phek district.

- It is currently known from only a single location, making it highly vulnerable
- The plant displays unique leaf shapes and floral features.
- It belongs to the Hoya genus, a group known for its ornamental value.**
- It produces distinctive star-shaped flowers and exudes milk-like latex, a characteristic of many species in the Apocynaceae or milkweed family.

Rising Freshwater Threatens Lonar Meteor Crater Ecosystem

- India's only basaltic meteor impact crater, Lonar lake in Maharashtra's Buldhana district,** is facing an environmental crisis
- It was created due to a meteorite.
- Formed 50,000 years ago, the lake has long served as a terrestrial mirror for Mars and a habitat for specialised microbes.
- Lonar lake, a designated Ramsar wetland, has traditionally maintained high salinity and a pH of 11.5,** conditions in which no fish could survive.
- Last year, fish were spotted for the first time, marking an alarming shift in its ecosystem,
- One of the most striking aspects is its color,** which changes from green to pink depending on the season and the water conditions.



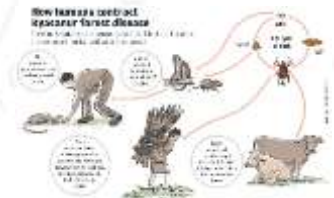
Sonamarg Avalanche

- Massive avalanches struck the Sonamarg tourist resort in Jammu and Kashmir, engulfing buildings and vehicles following heavy snowfall that disrupted the Jammu-Srinagar National Highway and forced the cancellation of all flights.
- An avalanche is a rapid downslope movement of a large detached mass of snow, ice, and associated debris, such as rocks and vegetation.**
- It occurs when the force of gravity on the snow cover exceeds its mechanical strength, causing the snowpack to fracture and descend rapidly down a mountainside.



Kyasanur Forest Disease

- It is a tick-borne viral haemorrhagic disease mostly found in southern India.
- The disease was first reported from the Kyasanur Forest of Karnataka in India in 1957; hence, it is known as KFD.
- The causal agent, KFD Virus (family Flaviviridae, genus Flavivirus), is a member of the tick-borne encephalitis (TBE) complex.**
- It is also known as "monkey disease/monkey fever" because of its association with monkey deaths
- Hard ticks (Hemaphysalis spinigera)** spread the KFD virus to people and to animals, like monkeys and rodents.
- KFD does not spread between people.**
- The epidemic period usually begins in October or November and peaks from January to April, then declines by May and June.



Symptoms

- Sudden onset of high-grade fever, prostration, nausea, vomiting, diarrhea, and occasionally neurological and haemorrhagic manifestations.
- There is no cure for KFD.**
- A vaccine for KFD is available and recommended in the parts of India where KFD is found.

Indo-Pacific Leopard Shark

- Recently, conservationists have initiated Thailand's first rewilding effort with the release of a young Indo-Pacific leopard shark into the waters off Maiton Island.
- Indo-Pacific leopard sharks are also called zebra sharks.
- These are slow-swimming reef sharks whose bodies have either a spotted or striped pattern depending on their age.
- Habitat: Found in tropical waters of the Indo-Pacific usually in the coastal waters.
- Conservation Status: IUCN: Endangered.



National

Republic Day 2026 Highlights

J&K woman officer to command all-male CRPF marching contingent on Republic Day

- Simran Bala, a 26-year-old CRPF Assistant Commandant hailing from Jammu and Kashmir, will lead an all-male contingent of her force during the Republic Day parade at Kartavya Path in Delhi on January 26.
- While there have been instances when women Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) officers commanded various Republic Day contingents, this is the first time that a lady officer will command a party of more than 140 male personnel during the annual national event.**
- Ms. Bala hails from Rajouri in Jammu and Kashmir and is the first female from the district to join the country's largest paramilitary force in the officer rank.
- The about 3.25 lakh personnel-strong CRPF is the country's top internal security force, with its three main theatres of combat being anti-Naxal operations, counter-terrorist offensives in Jammu and Kashmir, and counter-insurgency duties in the Northeast.
- A joint team of women 'dare devils' from the CRPF and Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB), riding Enfield Bullet bikes, will also be part of the parade.**
- The Central Industrial Security Force will have a marching and band contingent while the Border Security Force will be represented by its famed camel-mounted troops and band teams.



Ministry of Power to Showcase 'Prakash Ganga' Tableau at Republic Day Parade 2026

- The Ministry of Power will present its grand tableau titled "Prakash Ganga: Powering an Aatmanirbhar and Viksit Bharat" at the Republic Day Parade on January 26, 2026.
- The theme Prakash Ganga - meaning "River of Light" - symbolises the seamless and continuous flow of power across the interconnected national grid.**



Akshita Dhankar Unfurls Tricolour With President on Republic Day

- Flight Lieutenant in the Indian Air Force, Akshita Dhankar, created history after she unfurled the national flag alongside President Droupadi Murmu at the 77th Republic Day parade.
- Born in Kasni village in Haryana.**
- She was selected for the Administration branch and commissioned as a flying officer in June 2023.



India displays military might, cultural pride at Kartavya Path

- India celebrated its 77th Republic Day (January 26, 2026) with a grand display of military prowess and cultural heritage, as missiles, armed forces battalions and artists competed for attention at the Kartavya Path.
- Thirty tableaux, including 17 from states and Union Territories and 13 from ministries and departments, marched down Kartavya Path, highlighting 150 years of 'Vande Mataram' and India's progress.
- The theme of the The 77th Republic Day tableaux centred around two main themes : "Svatantrata Ka Mantra – Vande Mataram" and "Samriddhi Ka Mantra – Aatmanirbhar Bharat".
- Swatantrata ka Mantra : Vande Mataram : Celebrating 150 years of the national song Vande Mataram (composed by Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay in 1875).
- Samriddhi ka Mantra : Aatmanirbhar Bharat : Highlighting India's journey toward self-reliance and economic prosperity.
- The event featured an array of indigenous military platforms, including BrahMos and Akash weapon systems, the Main Battle Tank Arjun, and the rocket launcher 'Suryastra'.
- A tri-services tableau highlighted the Indian military's Operation Sindoor, with replicas of major weapon systems on display.**
- The parade also showcased the Indian Army's 'Battle Array Format', including its aerial component, with the Dhruv Advanced Light Helicopter and Rudra in Prahar formation.



- The Indian Navy and Air Force contingents marched past, featuring indigenous platforms like INS Vikrant and Rafale jets.
- The Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) showcased its hypersonic glide missile LR-ASHM, capable of engaging static and moving targets.
- The event concluded with a thrilling fly-past by 29 aircraft, including fighter jets, transport planes, and helicopters, in formations like 'Arjan' and 'Vijay'.
- For the **first time in India's history**, double-humped Bactrian camels from Ladakh marched down Kartavya Path.

Recently, during the Republic Day Parade more animals were represented the Indian Army's Remount and Veterinary Corps.

- It is a specialised Corps of the Indian Army responsible for the breeding, rearing, and training of Army animals, including horses, mules and Army dogs.
- It ensures the operational readiness of these animals for combat, reconnaissance, and logistics and also provides veterinary care and supporting counter-terrorism operations.
- **Headquarters:** Meerut
- **Motto:** 'Pashu Seva Asmakam Dharma (Service to animals is our duty)'.

Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation launches new logo and mascot

New logo:

- Ashoka Chakra symbolising truth, transparency, and good governance.
- Rupee symbol highlighting the role of statistics in economic planning and policymaking.

Aim:

- Promote the theme "Data for Development" by making statistics accessible, relatable, and trustworthy.
- Enhance public participation in surveys and improve transparency and accuracy in India's statistical system.



Mascot – "सांख्यिकी":

- Citizen-centric character designed to simplify complex statistical concepts.
- To be used across surveys, awareness campaigns, educational initiatives, digital platforms, and public events.

Indian Army animal contingent to march on Kartavya Path during Republic Day Parade 2026

- For the first time, the Indian Army's animal contingent will march on Kartavya Path in the national capital during the Republic Day Parade 2026.
- **The contingent will feature two Bactrian camels, four Zanskar ponies, four raptors, 10 Indian-breed Army dogs, along with six conventional military dogs currently in service.**
- The specially curated animal contingent of the Remount and Veterinary Corps (RVC) will highlight the contribution of animals in safeguarding the nation's frontiers.
- A major highlight of the parade will be the Army dogs, often referred to as the "Silent Warriors" of the Indian Army.



New Excise Duty and Cess on Tobacco, Pan Masala

- Centre notified Central Excise (Amendment) Act, 2025; effective 1 Feb 2026.
- GST compensation cess ends; excise duties revised to raise tobacco prices for public health + fiscal goals.
- Amends Central Excise Act, 1944; tobacco remains outside full GST.

GST restructuring:

- Beedis: 18% GST
- All other tobacco: 40% GST
- **GST Compensation Cess:** Additional levy to compensate States' revenue loss due to GST.
- **Started:** July 2017 (with GST), originally till June 2022.
- **Extended:** Till 31 March 2026 (COVID-19 shortfalls).
- **Levy:** Over and above GST (and excise for tobacco).
- **Phase-out:** Fully withdrawn from 1 Feb 2026, including on tobacco.



- **Covered items:** Tobacco & products, pan masala, aerated/caffeinated drinks, luxury cars, >350 cc motorcycles, specified firearms.

What is the 'Beating Retreat' Ceremony 2026?

- Beating Retreat is a ceremony that **marks the end of Republic Day festivities in India. It is held on the evening of January 29**, three days after Republic Day, at the **Vijay Chowk, New Delhi.**
- Beating Retreat — a centuries-old military tradition — dates back from the days when troops disengaged from battle at sunset.
- The ceremony features **a musical performance by the bands of the Indian Army, Navy, Air Force, Delhi Police, and the Central Armed Police Force (CAPF).**
- **The ceremony is presided over by the President of India, who is the supreme commander of the Armed Forces.**
- **The principal conductor in 2026- Squadron Leader Lamapokpam Roopchand Singh**
- The beating retreat ceremony in India was first held in 1950s, during the **state visit of Queen Elizabeth and Prince Philip.**
- Since then, the ceremony has become an annual event to pay tribute to the valour and sacrifice of the Indian Armed Forces



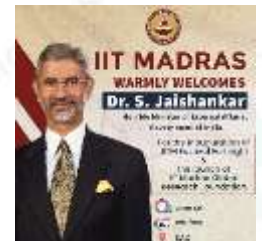
E-Bill System for fertiliser subsidies

- The Union Government has launched an integrated e-Bill System to digitally process fertiliser subsidies worth about ₹2 lakh crore.
- The e-Bill System is an end-to-end digital platform for submission, processing, tracking, and payment of fertiliser subsidy bills, replacing the earlier manual, paper-based workflow.
- **Ministry involved:** Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers
- **Aim:** Ensure timely, transparent, and accountable disbursal of fertiliser subsidies.



S Jaishankar launches IIT-Madras Global, move to make institute a multinational university

- External Affairs Minister Dr S Jaishankar launched the IITM Global Research Foundation, a major international initiative of the Indian Institute of Technology Madras (IIT Madras), aimed at positioning the institute as the world's first multinational university.
- **HE also inaugurated the 'IITM Festival Fortnight'**, which includes the institute's Open House — allowing public access to laboratories and innovation centres .



Battery Pack Aadhaar System

- Recently, the central government has released draft guidelines for a Battery Pack Aadhaar system.

About Battery Pack Aadhaar System

- It is an indigenous digital identification and data storage system developed to ensure end-to-end traceability of batteries throughout their entire lifecycle.
- **Objective:** This system aims to bring transparency, accountability, and sustainability to the battery ecosystem by enabling accurate tracking of performance, and environmental impact



Features of Battery Pack Aadhaar System

- The battery producer or importer shall have the **obligation of assigning a unique Battery Pack Aadhaar Number (BPAN) to each battery** that they introduce in the market and the battery they put to self-use.
- Every Electric Vehicle battery pack and industrial battery above 2 kWh will be assigned a 21 character Battery Pack Aadhaar Number, or BPAN, along with a QR code.

Pro-Active Governance and Timely Implementation (PRAGATI)

- **Land acquisition has emerged as the single largest bottleneck in infrastructure development**, accounting for 35% of project delays, the Cabinet Secretary said after the 50th PRAGATI meeting.
- PRAGATI is a centralised, ICT-enabled governance platform for grievance redressal, programme implementation, and project monitoring, enabling real-time review of projects of national importance.



- **Established in:** Launched on 25 March 2015 by the Government of India, under the Prime Minister's leadership.
- **Aim:** Ensure timely implementation of infrastructure and development projects.
- **Resolve inter-ministerial and Centre-State coordination issues.**
- Promote e-transparency, accountability, and outcome-based governance.

Rah-Veer

- The **Ministry of Road Transport and Highways reiterated protections and incentives under the Rah-Veer (Good Samaritan) Scheme** to encourage bystanders to help road accident victims without fear of legal or procedural harassment.
- Rah-Veer is a **Good Samaritan initiative notified under Section 134A of the Motor Vehicles (Amendment) Act, 2019**, protecting citizens who help road accident victims during the Golden Hour from legal, police, or hospital-related harassment.

Key features:

- **Legal protection:** No civil or criminal liability for helpers acting in good faith.
- **Right to anonymity:** Rah-Veers cannot be forced to disclose personal details or become witnesses.
- **Limited police interaction:** Only one voluntary statement, at a time and place convenient to the helper.
- **Hospital safeguards:** Hospitals must provide emergency care without demanding payment from the helper and issue an acknowledgement.
- **Recognition & incentive:** ₹25,000 reward and Certificate of Appreciation, up to five times a year for repeat acts.



CBSE launches Psycho-Social Counselling Support for students to address exam-related stress

- The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) launched Psycho-Social Counselling Support for Students to address examination-related stress.
- The first phase of free Psycho-Social Counselling Services for examinees of class 10th and 12th will continue till the 1st of June this year.
- This initiative is aimed at addressing examination-related stress and emotional well-being, enabling students to approach their forthcoming exams, scheduled to begin from 17th February, with confidence, balance, and mental clarity.



Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana Completes Nine Years

- The Government of India is implementing the Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana (PMMVY) with effect from 1st January 2017.
- It is **executed by the Ministry of Women and Child Development**
- It is a **centrally sponsored scheme under Mission Shakti's sub-scheme 'Samarthya'**, providing direct financial assistance through the Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) mode.
- It is designed to support pregnant women and lactating mothers.
- The scheme is to provide maternity benefits to women belonging to socially and economically disadvantaged sections of society.
- **It aims to improve health-seeking behaviour among pregnant women and lactating mothers and ensure better maternal and child health outcomes across the country.**
- The **benefit is available to a woman for the first two living children provided the second child is a girl.**
- In case of the **first child the amount of ₹5000** in two instalments and **for the second child, the benefit of ₹6000** will be provided subject to second child is a girl child in one instalment after the birth.



Govt aims to make India child marriage-free by 2030 under Bal Vivah Mukht Bharat campaign

- The Bal Vivah Mukht Bharat campaign aims to reduce the prevalence of child marriage by 10% by 2026 and make India child marriage free by 2030.
- Balod district in Chhattisgarh achieved a milestone by becoming India's first child marriage-free district in 2025.
- On September 17, 2025, the district administration of Surajpur, Chhattisgarh, declared 75 village panchayats as "Child Marriage-Free Panchayats."



- 'Bal Vivah Mukht Bharat' Campaign: It was launched by the Ministry of Women and Child Development, Government of India.

Prohibition of Child Marriage Act, 2006 (PCMA)

- The Prohibition of Child Marriage Act, 2006[4] replaced the Child Marriage Restraint Act, 1929 (Sarda Act), with the aim to prohibit rather than merely restrain child marriages while providing stronger protection and relief for victims.
- **The Act clearly states that a "child" is a male under 21 years or female under 18 years. Child marriage involves either party being a child.**
- Child marriages are prohibited and voidable[5] at the option of the child party (petition to District Court within 2 years of attaining majority). They are void ab initio in cases of trafficking, force, deceit, or immoral purposes.
- **Punishments:** Cognizable and non-bailable offences include up to 2 years rigorous imprisonment and/or ₹1 lakh fine for adult males marrying children, solemnizing/performing/abetting/promoting/attending such marriages (including parents/guardians). Women offenders face no imprisonment.
- **States appoint Child Marriage Prohibition Officers (CMPOs)** to prevent marriages, gather evidence, raise awareness, and report data. Magistrates issue injunctions to stop impending marriages (violation makes marriage void).

Prasar Bharati Launches 'Creator's Corner' on DD News to Empower Digital Creators Nationwide

- Prasar Bharati launched "Creator's Corner", a dedicated platform for showcasing content created by digital creators from across the country on DD News.
- **The initiative aims to promote the digital economy by encouraging the creation of quality content and expanding its reach through a partnership between Prasar Bharati and individual content creators.**
- Creator's Corner will feature content on a wide range of themes including News and Current Affairs, Culture, Travel, Cuisine, Art and Literature, Music and Dance, Health and Wellness, Education, Science and Technology, inspiring stories, Environment and Sustainable Development, and Entertainment.



Prasar Bharati Launches 'Creator's Corner' on DD News to Empower Digital Creators Nationwide

- Prasar Bharati launched "Creator's Corner", a dedicated platform for showcasing content created by digital creators from across the country on DD News.
- **The initiative aims to promote the digital economy by encouraging the creation of quality content and expanding its reach through a partnership between Prasar Bharati and individual content creators.**
- Creator's Corner will feature content on a wide range of themes including News and Current Affairs, Culture, Travel, Cuisine, Art and Literature, Music and Dance, Health and Wellness, Education, Science and Technology, inspiring stories, Environment and Sustainable Development, and Entertainment.

Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS)

- **The 79th Foundation Day of the Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) was celebrated**, where Union Minister highlighted BIS's shift from a regulatory to a facilitative approach, aligned with ease of doing business and quality culture.
- BIS is India's National Standards Body, responsible for standardisation, certification, hallmarking, and quality assurance of goods and services to protect consumers and enhance global competitiveness.
- **Established in:** 1987 (came into force on 1 April 1987)
- Currently governed under the BIS Act, 2016
- **Headquarters:** New Delhi



History:

- **1947:** Indian Standards Institution (ISI) established (origin traced to a 1946 memorandum).
- **1952–56:** ISI Certification Marks Scheme launched (ISI mark).
- **1987:** ISI transformed into BIS with wider powers.
- **2016:** BIS Act, 2016 strengthened mandate, consumer participation, and global alignment.
-

Recently, at the 79th Bureau of Indian Standards Foundation Day union ministers launched the SHINE scheme in New Delhi.

About SHINE Scheme

- The Standards Help Inform & Nurture Empowered Women (SHINE) is a new scheme of the Bureau of Indian Standards.
- It places women at the center of India's quality journey.
- It empowers women with knowledge that protects families and strengthens livelihoods.
- Through this BIS spreads awareness about standards, safety, and quality within households, self-help groups, and communities.



Indian Railways becomes the biggest electrified rail system globally

- **Indian Railways has become the largest electrified rail network in the world, with about 99.2% of its broad-gauge network electrified by November 2025.**
- Indian Railways is India's national transporter, operating one of the world's largest rail networks.
- **Initiative under:** Mission 100% Railway Electrification
- **Launched in:** The electrification drive began historically in 1925, but Mission-mode acceleration was undertaken post-2014.
- 99.2% rail electrification (~70,000 km); 25 States/UTs covered
- **Solar power:** 3.7 MW → 898 MW



India's first Hydrogen train trial run begins

- The trial run of India's first hydrogen-powered train has commenced, with testing being carried out by the Research Designs & Standards Organisation (RDSO).
- **Developed by Chennai-based Integral Coach Factory (ICF).**
- The trial run of the hydrogen-powered train is being conducted on the Jind–Sonipat section of the Northern Railway.
- **India will join an elite global league of countries including Germany, Sweden, Japan and China – that operate hydrogen-powered trains.**
- Presently, it is the **world's longest (10 coaches) and most powerful (2400 kW) Hydrogen Train-set on Broad Gauge platform.**
- Zero CO2 emissions; only emission is water vapour.

Ministry of Women and Child Development launches PANKHUDI

- The Ministry of Women and Child Development launched PANKHUDI, an integrated digital portal designed to streamline Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) and partnership initiatives focused on women and child development.
- The **portal aims to consolidate contributions and collaborations from NGOs, companies, CSR contributors, NRIs, government agencies and individuals working in areas such as nutrition, health, early childhood care and education, child welfare, rehabilitation, women's safety and empowerment.**

India becomes first country to commercially produce bio-bitumen

- India has **become the first country** to commercially produce bio-bitumen for road construction, marking a global milestone in green infrastructure.
- **Bio-bitumen is a bio-based alternative to conventional petroleum bitumen, used as a binder in road construction.**
- It is produced from agricultural residues (especially rice straw) and can partially replace fossil-fuel-derived bitumen without compromising road performance.
- **Organisations involved:** Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR) ; CSIR-Central Road Research Institute (CSIR-CRRI), New Delhi; CSIR-Indian Institute of Petroleum (CSIR-IIP), Dehradun

ECI to Host IICDEM 2026 Global Democracy Conference

- The Election Commission of India (ECI) **will host the inaugural India International Conference on Democracy and Election Management (IICDEM)-2026 from 21st to 23rd January, 2026** at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi.
- The **three-day international conference is being organised by India International Institute of Democracy and Election Management (IIIDEM) under the aegis of ECI.**
- The central theme of the conference is "Democracy for an inclusive, peaceful, resilient and sustainable world."
- IICDEM 2026 will be the largest global conference of its kind hosted by India

UIDAI Launches 'Udai' Mascot to Simplify Aadhaar Communication

- The **Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI)** has launched Aadhaar mascot '**Udai (उदय)**' to make Aadhaar-related information more relatable and people-friendly.
- A resident-facing communication companion (official mascot) designed to simplify public understanding of Aadhaar services such as updates, authentication, offline verification, selective data sharing, and responsible usage.
- **Aim:** To simplify, humanise, and standardise Aadhaar communication, enhance citizen trust through participation, and improve accessibility for over a billion residents.



India–AI Impact Summit

- India has announced the India–AI Impact Summit 2026, scheduled for 19–20 February 2026 in New Delhi, making it the first-ever global AI summit hosted in the Global South.
- The India–AI Impact Summit is a high-level multilateral forum **announced by the Prime Minister at the France AI Action Summit, designed to advance responsible, inclusive, and development-oriented AI cooperation, with a strong Global South.**



Key features:

- **Global South leadership:** First global AI summit hosted in a developing country, amplifying Southern perspectives in AI governance.
- **Multilateral continuity:** Builds on G20 AI Principles, UN & GPAI resolutions, African Declaration on AI, and Hamburg Declaration on Responsible AI.

Three Sutras framework:

- **People:** Human-centric, inclusive, culturally sensitive, and trustworthy AI.
- **Planet:** Responsible AI aligned with climate action, sustainability, and reduced energy footprint.
- **Progress:** AI for equitable growth across health, education, governance, agriculture, and public services.

India Launches Raisina Science Diplomacy Initiative 2026

- The **Office of the Principal Scientific Adviser to the Government of India (OPSA)** and the **Observer Research Foundation (ORF)** have announced a partnership for the inaugural edition of the Raisina Science Diplomacy Initiative (2026).
- The **Raisina Science Diplomacy Initiative is scheduled to be held alongside the Raisina Dialogue from 5–7 March 2026 in New Delhi.**
- The SDI initiative aims to create a dedicated platform within the Raisina Dialogue to deliberate on the intersection of science, technology, and diplomacy.
- The **initiative marks a new institutional effort to embed science diplomacy within India's flagship geopolitical dialogue framework**, reflecting the growing strategic importance of science and technology in international relations.



EU Council President Costa, Commission President von der Leyen to be Chief Guests at 77th Republic Day

- The **President of the European Council, António Luís Santos da Costa, and the President of the European Commission, Ursula von der Leyen**, will be Chief Guests at India's 77th Republic Day celebrations, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) announced.
- During their visit, President Costa and President von der Leyen will co-chair the 16th India-EU Summit on January 27, 2026.
- **India and the European Union have been strategic partners since 2004.** The 15th India–EU Summit was held virtually on July 15, 2020.



Home Minister Amit Shah Inaugurates 3rd International Kite Festival in New Delhi

- Union Home Minister Amit Shah inaugurated the **3rd International Kite Festival 2026 in New Delhi at Baansera Park along the Yamuna river.**
- The festival coincides with the harvest and seasonal celebrations around Makar Sankranti and related festivals such as Lohri, Pongal, Magh Bihu and Uttarayan — marking it as a celebration of cultural unity and traditional festivities.



Bharat Electricity Summit 2026 Announced in New Delhi

- Bharat Electricity Summit 2026, a global conference-cum-exhibition for the power and electricity sector, will be **held from 19-22 March 2026 at Yashobhoomi, New Delhi**, as announced by Union Power Minister Manohar Lal.
- **The theme of the summit is "Electrifying Growth. Empowering Sustainability. Connecting Globally."**
- The four-day event will feature more than 50 high-level conference sessions, expert-led panel discussions, thematic pavilions and technology showcases.



PM CARES Fund Privacy Rights Under RTI Act: Delhi High Court

- The Delhi High Court orally remarked that the PM Cares Fund, **despite being a juristic or government entity, cannot be denied the right to privacy under the Right to Information Act.**
- The court's reasoning relied on **Section 8(1)(j) of the RTI Act**, which exempts disclosure of personal or third party information unless a larger public interest is established.
- The bench clarified that this **right to privacy is statutory, not derived from Article 21 of the Constitution.**
- It applies equally to all third parties under RTI, regardless of whether they are public or private entities.



PM CARES Fund:

- The Prime Ministers Citizen Assistance and Relief in Emergency Situations Fund (PM CARES Fund) was created on 28 March 2020, **following the COVID-19 pandemic in India.**
- It was created for combating, and containment and relief efforts against the coronavirus outbreak and similar pandemic like situations in the future.
- **It has been registered as a Public Charitable Trust.**

India to roll out vehicle-to-vehicle technology by 2026

- Govt. of India to roll out Vehicle-to-Vehicle (V2V) nationwide by end-2026 to reduce road crashes.
- What is V2V? Wireless system enabling vehicles to directly exchange data with nearby vehicles in real time, without mobile networks.

Aim:

- Prevent collisions and pile-ups via real-time alerts .
- Improve safety in blind spots and low visibility (hidden, stationary, fog-covered vehicles).

How it works:

- Each vehicle gets a SIM-like device to send/receive signals.
- Uses a dedicated radio band 5.875–5.905 GHz (DoT-approved), works without mobile internet.



India Post Launches Speed Post 24 and Speed Post 48 Services

- Union Minister for Communications **Jyotiraditya Scindia has announced two new India Post services, Speed Post 24 and Speed Post 48, which will ensure delivery within 24 and 48 hours.**
- Speed Post 24 and Speed Post 48 will set a new standard of punctual, reliable and fast delivery.



Govt to merge agricultural schemes, link funds to state reforms

- **The Union Ministry of Agriculture has proposed merging three schemes with PM-RKVY:** Krishonnati Yojana (KY), National Mission on Natural Farming (NMNF), and National Bee and Honey Mission (NBHM).
- PM-RKVY was launched to accelerate agricultural growth and increase farmers' income.

About PM-RKVY

- A Centrally Sponsored Scheme (CSS) under the Ministry of Agriculture & Farmers Welfare.
- Aims to boost agricultural growth and improve farmers' income.

About Pradhan Mantri-Rashtriya Krishi Vikas Yojana

- It is a Centrally Sponsored Schemes (CSS) operating under the Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare.
- It is aimed at accelerating agricultural growth and improving farmers' income.

Objectives

- Increase public investment in agriculture and allied sectors.

- Improve productivity and overall farm growth.
- Strengthen agricultural and post-harvest infrastructure.
- Promote diversification into high-value crops, horticulture, livestock, and fisheries.
- Encourage modern, innovative, climate-resilient practices.
- Reduce regional disparities in agricultural development.

Features

- State-led, decentralized approach with flexibility in planning.
- Growth-oriented: Targets ~4% annual growth in agriculture and allied sectors.
- Wide coverage: Crops, horticulture, livestock, fisheries, organic farming, R&D, marketing infrastructure.
- Incentive-based funding linked to states' public investment.

Funding Pattern

- General States: 60% Centre + 40% State
- North-Eastern & Hilly States: 90% Centre + 10% State
- Union Territories: 100% Central funding

What is the India-China dispute over Shaksgam Valley in Kashmir?

- China has rejected India's territorial claim over the Shaksgam Valley in the Jammu & Kashmir region, insisting the area is part of Chinese territory.

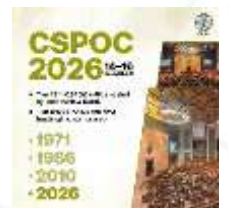
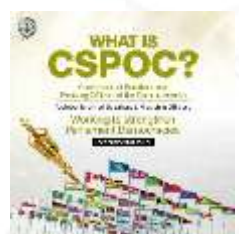
About Shaksgam Valley

- The **Shaksgam Valley, or Trans Karakoram Tract, is part of the Hunza-Gilgit region of Pakistan-Occupied Kashmir (POK)** and is a disputed territory claimed by India but controlled by Pakistan.
- It borders Xinjiang Province of the People's Republic of China (PRC) to the north, the Northern Areas of POK to the south and west, and the Siachen Glacier region to the east.
- **It was ceded to China by Pakistan in 1963**, when both countries signed a boundary agreement to settle their border differences.
- However, Article 6 of the agreement clearly stated that "the two parties have agreed that after the settlement of the Kashmir dispute between Pakistan and India, **the sovereign authority concerned will reopen negotiations with the Government of the People's Republic of China, on the boundary as described in Article Two of the present agreement, so as to sign a formal Boundary Treaty to replace the present agreement.**"
- The agreement laid the foundation of Karakoram highway, which was built jointly by Chinese and Pakistani engineers in the 1970s.



India to Host 28th Commonwealth Speakers Conference in New Delhi

- India will host the 28th Conference of Speakers and Presiding Officers of Parliaments of Commonwealth Countries (CSPOC) in 2026.
- **As Chairperson of the 28th CSPOC, Om Birla will preside over this meeting.**
- The Standing Committee set the agenda for the 2026 CSPOC and discussed challenges facing parliaments globally.
- India's history of hosting the conference in 1970-71, 1986, and 2010, and invited presiding officers from Commonwealth nations to join the 2026 event in New Delhi.
- **Established in:** 1969 by Speaker Lucien Lamoureux, Canada.
- **Structure:**
- **Two-year cycle:** Full membership conference every two years, Standing Committee meeting in the intervening year.
- **Chairperson:** Rotates based on the host country.



ADMM-Plus Counter Terrorism Meet Begins in New Delhi

- **The meeting of 16th ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting (ADMM)-Plus Experts Working Group (EWG) on Counter Terrorism (CT) and Final Planning Conference for Table Top Exercise is scheduled to be held in New Delhi from January 14 to 16,**



2026.

- India and Malaysia will co-chair the 16th EWG on CT meeting.
- This will be the third meeting for the ongoing cycle from 2024-2027.

MeitY to Host BHASHINI Samudaye Workshop on Language AI Ecosystem

- BHASHINI Samudaye is being organised by MeitY in New Delhi to strengthen India's language AI ecosystem.
- BHASHINI Samudaye is a collaborative ecosystem platform under BHASHINI that enables co-creation, governance and scaling of Indian-language AI tools**, datasets and services through partnerships with academia, civil society and technology developers.
- Developed by:** It is led by the Digital India BHASHINI Division (DIBD) under the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) as part of the National Language Translation Mission (NLTM).



Key Features:

- BHASHINI platform & APIs:** enables real-time translation, speech-to-text and text-to-speech in Indian languages.
- BhashaDaan:** citizen contribution platform for building open Indian-language datasets.

Union Minister Dharmendra Pradhan releases 55 literary works developed by classical language centres

- The collection features works from Kannada, Telugu, Malayalam, Odia, Tamil, and the sign language series of Tirukkural by the Tamil poet Thiruvalluvar.
- In **2024**, the Modi government officially conferred classical language status on five **additional languages**, such as Marathi, Pali, Prakrit, Assamese and Bengali. In India, there are eleven official classical Indian languages.
- Six Indian languages —Tamil, Sanskrit, Kannada, Telugu, Malayalam, and Odia—were earlier accorded the status of classical languages between 2004 to 2024.**



January 11 - former Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri death anniversary

- Lal Bahadur Shastri was a humble leader who became India's second Prime Minister (1964-66) after the death of Jawaharlal Nehru.
- Lal Bahadur Shastri was born in an ordinary family on October 2, 1904, in Uttar Pradesh.
- Shastri died suddenly in Tashkent on 11th January 1966.
 - Tashkent Declaration:** The Tashkent Declaration was signed in January 1966, between India and Pakistan.
 - It aimed to restore peace and resolve issues arising from the 1965 Indo-Pak war, promoting mutual understanding.

NCERT launches official WhatsApp Channel to share curriculum updates

- The **National Council of Educational Research and Training announces its official WhatsApp Channel.**
- The Council aims to provide authentic updates on curriculum, textbooks, teacher training, educational research, workshops, and initiatives that promote quality, equity, and holistic education.



Beti Bachao Beti Padhao campaign completes 11 years

- The Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao (BBBP) scheme was launched on January 22, 2015, initially in 100 districts, to combat the alarming decline in the sex ratio at birth and promote female education across India.
- The Union Ministry of Women and Child Development is the nodal ministry that implements the Beti Bachao Beti Padhao Scheme in collaboration with other ministries of the government of India.



Goals and Objectives

- Initially aimed at saving the girl child and educating her.
- Expanded goals include improving menstrual health and promoting sports participation among girls.
- Responded to societal issues like sex-selective abortions and female infanticide.**
- Part of a broader BJP manifesto focusing on women empowerment, promising measures like 33% reservation for women in legislatures.
- Sex Ratio at Birth refers to the number of girls born for every 1000 male children born.

SAMPANN pension portal developed by Office Of Controller General of Communication Accounts, integrates with UMANG Portal



- The SAMPANN pension management system developed by the office of Controller General of Communication Accounts has been integrated with the UMANG (Unified Mobile Application for New-age Governance) platform.
- **This initiative facilitates pensioners in retrieving their Pension Payment Order (PPO) number and Life Certificate (LC) validity status via the UMANG web portal or mobile application.**
- **About SAMPANN:** SAMPANN (System for Accounting and Management of Pension) is a flagship digital platform of the Department, developed, owned, and operated by the Office of the Controller General of Communication Accounts for pension administration and allied financial management functions.
- **Dedicated to the nation by the Hon'ble Prime Minister on 29th December 2018.**

What is UMANG?

- UMANG is a single unified platform (mobile app + web portal) to access government services offered by Central, State, and Local bodies—anytime, anywhere.
- **It's part of the Digital India initiative and available on Android, iOS, and the web.**

The President of India inaugurated Granth Kutir at Rashtrapati Bhavan.



- It has a rich collection of manuscripts and books in 11 classical languages of India which are Tamil, Sanskrit, Kannada, Telugu, Malayalam, Odia, Marathi, Pali, Prakrit, Assamese, and Bengali.
- **Aim:** The aim of developing the Granth Kutir is to enhance awareness among the citizens regarding the rich cultural and literary heritage of India.
- **It showcases India's rich and diverse cultural, philosophical, literary and intellectual heritage.**
- **It supports the vision of Gyan Bharatam Mission.**

GSI to Host 65th CGPB Meeting on Geoscience Priorities

- The Geological Survey of India (GSI) under the Ministry of Mines will host the 65th Central Geological Programming Board (CGPB) meeting in Delhi on January 21.
- **The CGPB functions as a key platform where GSI presents its Annual Field Season Programme (FSP) for discussion,** ensuring coordinated survey and exploration activities across the country and preventing duplication of efforts.
- The 65th meeting will be chaired by Piyush Goyal, Secretary, Ministry of Mines, in the presence of GSI Director General Asit Saha,

Internet Governance Internship & Capacity Building Scheme (IGICBS)

- National Internet Exchange of India (NIXI) has completed one year of its Internet Governance Internship & Capacity Building Scheme (IGICBS) and marked the milestone with a national-level event in New Delhi.
- **IGICBS is a national internship and capacity-building programme designed to train India's youth in internet governance, enabling informed participation in national and global internet policy, standards, and technical forums.**
- Launched in: 2025 (completed one year in January 2026)

Organisations involved:

- National Internet Exchange of India (NIXI) – Nodal implementing body
- Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) – Administrative ministry

Key features:

- **Structured internships:** 6-month and 3-month terms combining research + practical outreach.
- **Mentorship model:** Each intern mentored by senior experts from government, academia, or global IG bodies.
- **Capacity building & outreach:** Mandatory awareness programmes in colleges, universities, NGOs, and local communities.
- **Global exposure:** Engagement with international internet governance institutions and processes.
- **NIXI Internet Influencer pathway:** High-performing interns certified to act as long-term ambassadors of internet governance.

- **Interdisciplinary focus:** Technology, law, public policy, cybersecurity, digital identity, and Universal Acceptance (UA).

Centre approves continuation of Atal Pension Yojana till 2030-31

- The Union Cabinet, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, approved the continuation of the Atal Pension Yojana (APY) till the financial year 2030-31, along with the extension of government funding support for promotional and developmental activities as well as gap funding.
- **Launched on May 9, 2015, the APY provides a guaranteed minimum pension ranging from Rs 1,000 to Rs 5,000 per month** from the age of 60, depending on the subscriber's contribution.
- As of January 19, 2026, the scheme has enrolled over 8.66 crore subscribers, emerging as a key pillar of India's social security framework



Womaniya Initiative

- Recently, the Government e-Marketplace (GeM) marked seven years of the Womaniya initiative.

About Womaniya Initiative

- It was **launched on 14 January 2019**.
- It is a flagship programme aimed at strengthening the participation of women-led Micro and Small Enterprises (MSEs) in public procurement.
- **Womaniya was conceived to address the limited access of women entrepreneurs and Self-Help Groups (SHGs) to government markets.**
- It spurs Women entrepreneurship by aligning them with opportunities to sell their products to various Government ministries, departments and institutions.
- **By providing a direct, transparent and fully digital interface with government buyers, the initiative eliminated intermediaries and reduced entry barriers that had historically constrained participation.**
- **Impact:** The initiative seeks to develop women entrepreneurship to achieve gender-inclusive economic growth.



What is a GeM Portal?

- Government e-Marketplace, shortly known as GeM, is a digital platform that enables buying and selling of goods and services.
- It is the **Public Procurement Portal for procurement of goods and services for all Central Government and State Government Ministries, Departments, Public Sector Units (PSUs) and affiliated.**
- It was launched in August 2016, by the Ministry of Commerce & Industry.
- The sole purpose of GeM is to enhance efficiency; transparency and speed in public procurement.

ECI to host IICDEM-2026 from Jan 21st to 23rd

- The Election Commission of India (ECI) will host the inaugural India International Conference on Democracy and Election Management (IICDEM) 2026 from January 21 to 23 at Bharat Mandapam in the national capital.
- Organised by the India International Institute of Democracy and Election Management (IIIDEM), the three-day conference is expected to be the largest international gathering hosted by India in the field of democracy and election management.
- **Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, along with Election Commissioners Dr. Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Dr. Vivek Joshi, will receive the delegates and formally flag off the conference at the inaugural session on January 21.**
- As part of the conference, 36 thematic groups will conduct detailed deliberations.
- **These groups will be led by Chief Electoral Officers of States and Union Territories and supported by national and international academic experts.**
- Leading academic institutions, including four Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs), six Indian Institutes of Management (IIMs), 12 National Law Universities (NLUs), and the Indian Institute of Mass Communication (IIMC), will also take part in the discussions.
- **Additionally, the docuseries "India Decides", which documents the conduct of the Lok Sabha 2024 elections, will be screened on the opening day of IICDEM 2026.**



Supreme Court Rules Unreserved Seats Open to All Candidates on Merit

- The Supreme Court of India ruled that unreserved seats are not reserved for the general category alone.

- Candidates from SC, ST, or OBC categories who qualify without availing any relaxation must be counted against unreserved seats, not reserved quotas.
- **The Bench comprising M. M. Sundresh and Satish Chandra Sharma clearly held that the unreserved category is an open competition pool.**
- It is not a separate quota for the general category, but a space where any citizen who meets the prescribed standards of merit can be selected.

Lok Sabha to launch digital attendance system

- The Lok Sabha will introduce a digital attendance system from the Budget Session 2026 to ensure the physical presence of MPs inside the House.
- A seat-based biometric attendance mechanism where Members of Parliament mark attendance electronically from their designated seats inside the House, replacing the earlier lobby register system.
- Announced by: Om Birla, Speaker of the Lok Sabha

Aim:

- Ensure actual presence of MPs during sittings.
- **Improve transparency, discipline, and productivity of Parliament.**
- Link attendance with daily allowance strictly to House presence.

How it works?

- Every designated seat in the Lok Sabha chamber is fitted with a digital console, ensuring attendance can be marked only from within the House and not elsewhere in the Parliament complex.
- MPs authenticate their presence using biometric thumb verification, eliminating proxy marking and ensuring that attendance reflects the actual physical presence of the member.
- **Once the House is adjourned—whether due to protests or completion of business—the system is locked, preventing members from retroactively marking attendance.**
- If an MP fails to record attendance during a sitting, it results in the forfeiture of daily allowance and related entitlements, creating a direct financial accountability mechanism.

Key features:

- The earlier practice of signing a register outside the chamber is abolished, ensuring MPs remain present during proceedings, not just for formality.
- Biometric verification enhances accuracy, tamper-resistance, and transparency, aligning parliamentary functioning with modern e-governance standards.
- **The strict time-bound system discourages strategic delays and reinforces the principle that attendance equals participation, not mere appearance.**
- MPs can no longer mark attendance and leave immediately, promoting serious legislative engagement and debate continuity.
- **The system complements initiatives like real-time multilingual translation, paperless proceedings, and AI-assisted workflows, advancing a more efficient and citizen-centric Parliament.**

Trucks-on-Trains

- Indian Railways, through its Dedicated Freight Corridor (DFC) network, is scaling up the Trucks-on-Trains (ToT) service to shift long-haul freight from roads to electrified rail.
- Trucks-on-Trains (ToT) is a multimodal freight service under the DFC **that allows loaded trucks to be carried on specially designed flat wagons for the long-haul rail leg**, while trucks handle only the first- and last-mile by road.

Key features:

- **Multimodal integration:** Combines road flexibility with high-speed, electrified freight rail.
- **Dedicated Freight Corridor backbone:** Operates on high-capacity, fully electrified DFC routes.
- **Competitive pricing:** Transparent weight-based tariffs; GST exemption for milk tankers, aiding perishables.
- **Environmental benefits:** Significant reductions in CO₂, NO_x, particulate matter, diesel use, and road dust.
- **Operational resilience:** Less affected by fog, rain, and extreme weather than highways.

The Budget Session of Parliament begins with President Droupadi Murmu addressing the joint sitting



- The Budget Session of Parliament commenced with an address by President Droupadi Murmu to a joint sitting, following which both the Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha were adjourned for the day.
- **The session will span 30 sittings over 65 days, concluding on April 2.**
- The two Houses will adjourn for a recess on February 13 and reconvene on March 9 to enable the Standing Committees to examine the Demands for Grants of various ministries and departments.
- **Economic Survey** : The Economic Survey will be tabled on January 29, followed by the Union Budget 2026–27 on February 1.
- **Prepared by the Economic Division of the Finance Ministry**, under the chief economic adviser, the Survey reviews economic performance and key indicators for 2025–26 and presents an outlook for the next fiscal year.
- A joint sitting involves both houses of Parliament (Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha) meeting together.

Types of Joint Sittings in the Constitution:

- There are two main types of joint sittings in the Indian parliamentary system.
- First is the presidential address under Article 87 and
- Second is the resolution of legislative deadlocks under Article 108.

Article 87 of the Indian Constitution outlines when the President addresses both Houses of Parliament.

- The President addresses the Rajya Sabha and Lok Sabha at the beginning of the first session after each general election.
- The President also addresses both Houses at the beginning of the first session of each year.

The Union Minister of State for Panchayati Raj launched the PANCHAM – Panchayat Assistance and Messaging Chatbot

- It is a digital tool developed in collaboration with UNICEF.
- **Aim:** It is a flagship digital initiative aimed at empowering Panchayat Elected Representatives and Functionaries.
- It is **designed as a digital companion for Panchayats, providing timely and contextual guidance, simplified workflows, and easy access to information** to support day-to-day governance and service delivery functions.



Features of PANCHAM

- It enables, for the first time, a direct digital connect between the Government of India and Elected Representatives and Panchayat Functionaries across the country.
- It is integrated with BHASHINI and will support 22 Indian languages, enabling Panchayat representatives to interact with the platform in their preferred local language.
- Citizens would be able to access PANCHAM through a QR-code-based entry mechanism.
- **PANCHAM facilitates two way communication and officials can send feedback, ask questions, and flag local problems directly to the ministry.**

Plea challenges new UGC Regulations, asks why quota only for SC/ST/OBC

- A petition has been filed in the Supreme Court assailing the constitutional validity of Regulation 3(c) of the **University Grants Commission (Promotion of Equity in Higher Education Institutions) Regulations, 2026**
- These **regulations are aimed at tackling caste-based discrimination** in higher education institutions (HEIs), are much stronger and binding than the previous 2012 guidelines
- **Applies to all** Indian higher education institutions (HEIs) — public, private, deemed universities, colleges, etc
- **Key components include:**
 - Establishing **Equal Opportunity Centres (EOCs)** - primary grievance redressal and support mechanism.
- The EOC must:
 - maintain an **online complaints portal and a 24x7 equity helpline**
 - set up an **Equity Committee** to investigate and decide on complaints within **strict timelines**
- EOCs must **publish bi-annual and annual reports**
- The UGC will set up a **national monitoring committee**
- If an institution fails to comply with the regulations, the **UGC may impose consequences** such as Debarment from UGC schemes and funding, Suspension of degree-granting privileges, Removal of recognition, etc



- **Criticism - No explicit penalty for false or malicious complaints** in the regulations, raising concerns about potential misuse

University Grants Commission

- **Statutory (legal) body, formally established in 1956** under the **UGC Act, 1956**
- Responsible for regulating, coordinating, and maintaining standards in **higher education** across the country.
- It functions under the **Ministry of Education**
- Consists of a **Chairman, Vice-Chairman, and ten other members** appointed by the Central Government.
- Headquarter - **New Delhi**

Sampoornata Abhiyan 2.0

- NITI Aayog CEO Shri B.V.R Subrahmanyam launched 'Sampoornata Abhiyan 2.0'—a 3-month intensive campaign to achieve 100% saturation of critical development indicators in India's most underserved regions.
- **Sampoornata Abhiyan 2.0 is a mission-mode, time-bound campaign** designed to accelerate progress in 112 Aspirational Districts and 513 Aspirational Blocks.
- **Start Date:** January 28, 2026, **End Date:** April 14, 2026 (Dr. B.R. Ambedkar Jayanti)
- **Duration:** 3 Months
- **Aim & Objectives:** Achieving full coverage of essential government services in health, nutrition, and education.



Minister of State for Electronics & IT Jitin Prasada launched the new Aadhaar app

- The Government of India **has launched the New Aadhaar App in January 2026, dedicated to the nation.**
- This next-generation app, introduces a Privacy-First approach, allowing users to update mobile numbers from home.
- **Developed by:** Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI).
- With the new Aadhaar app, users can make their Aadhaar information more secure, keep it updated, and share it safely with others.
- **The app allows citizens to update their mobile number and home address online, perform secure online verification,** and manage multiple Aadhaar cards of family members at the same time.
- Many services that earlier required a visit to an Aadhaar centre can now be completed digitally.



India submits Meghalaya's living root bridges to UNESCO for World Heritage status

- Meghalaya has moved a step closer to global recognition of its unique living heritage, **with India formally submitting the nomination dossier of the State's living root bridges, titled "Jingkieng Jri / Lyu Chrai Cultural Landscape", to UNESCO for consideration under the 2026-27 World Heritage evaluation cycle.**
- The dossier was submitted by India's Ambassador and Permanent Representative to UNESCO, Vishal V. Sharma, to the Director of UNESCO's World Heritage Centre, Lazare Assomo Eloundou.



Meghalaya's Living Root Bridge:

- Meghalaya is known for its living root bridges, locally known as jingkieng jri.
- **They are on the tentative list of UNESCO's World Heritage sites.**
- Many bridges across the State are over a century old.
- A living root bridge is like a suspension bridge formed by guiding the pliable roots of the rubber fig tree (*Ficus elastica*) across a stream or river and allowing the roots to grow and strengthen over time.
- **They are common in the southern part of the Northeast Indian state of Meghalaya.**

PAIMANA Portal

- The **Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI)** has operationalised a new web-based portal, **PAIMANA portal** for the mandated monitoring of Central Sector Infrastructure Projects worth ₹150 crore and above.
- The **Project Assessment, Infrastructure Monitoring & Analytics for Nation-building (PAIMANA)** is a flagship initiative of the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI).
- It functions as a centralised national repository of infrastructure projects, enabling web-generated analytical reports and enhancing data accuracy, and operational efficiency.

- It is integrated with DPIIT's Integrated Project Monitoring Portal (IPMP/IIG-PMG) through APIs

Recently, the union Minister of Jal Shakti inaugurated 25 JALAJ Livelihood Centres

- It is a joint initiative of the Namami Gange Mission and the Wildlife Institute of India (WII).
- Aim:** It is aimed at integrating river conservation with sustainable livelihoods in the Ganga river basin.
- Jalaj is based on the circular economy model where the local people will be trained in sustainable livelihood practices and mobilized to contribute to biodiversity conservation and clean river ecosystem..

US Museum to Return Ancient Bronze Sculptures to India

- The Smithsonian's National Museum of Asian Art, United States, announced that it would return three sculptures:

- The Chola-period sculptures of the Nataraja from the 10th Century
- the Somaskanda from the 12th Century
- and Saint Sundarar with Paravai from the Vijayanagara period (16th Century)
- The bronze sculptures had been photographed in temples in Tamil Nadu between 1956 and 1959



Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav announces addition of two new wetlands to India's Ramsar network

- The wetlands in Kutch in Gujarat and Etah in Uttar Pradesh have been recognised as Ramsar sites
- the designation of Patna Bird Sanctuary in Etah and Chhari-Dhand in Kutch as Ramsar sites.
- Chhari-Dhand is a seasonal saline wetland located between the famous Banni grasslands and salt flats of Kutch.
- It is an important wintering site for waterfowl, supporting species such as critically endangered sociable lapwing, the vulnerable common pochard, and, notably, approximately 30,000 common cranes (Grus grus) annually,
- The Patna bird sanctuary wetland consists of freshwater marshes, woodlands and grasslands, and is surrounded by agricultural landscapes
- Patna Bird Sanctuary is particularly important in supporting waterbird populations and has been designated an Important Bird and Biodiversity Area (IBA) by BirdLife International
- The designation of these two sites under the Ramsar Convention takes the total number of such wetlands in India to 98.
- Siliserh Lake in Alwar district, Rajasthan, and Kopra Jalashay near Bilaspur, Chhattisgarh, have been added to the List of Wetlands (95th – 96th).
- Ramsar sites are wetlands that are designated as being of international importance under the Ramsar Convention.
- The Ramsar Convention is an Intergovernmental treaty established by UNESCO - provides the framework for the conservation and wise use of wetlands and their resources.
- Adopted on 2nd February 1971 in Ramsar, Iran. Came into force from 21st December, 1975.
- India is one of the Contracting Parties to Ramsar Convention, signed it on 1st Feb 1982.
- February 2 is celebrated as the International Wetlands Day



SC says menstrual health fundamental right under Article 21

- The Supreme Court of India, in a landmark verdict Dr. Jaya Thakur vs Government Of India, declared the right to menstrual health a fundamental right under Article 21, ordering all schools to provide free sanitary pads and gender-segregated toilets.
- The Court also directed the pan-India implementation of the Union's national policy, 'Menstrual Hygiene (MH) Policy for School-going Girls' in schools for adolescent girl children from Classes 6-12.

Key Highlights of the judgment

- Menstrual Health as a fundamental right: Right to life under Article 21 of the Constitution includes the right to menstrual health.

- Link to Article 14 (Right to Equality): Inaccessibility of MH measures strips away the right to participate on equal terms in schools.
- Dignity must translate into living conditions free from humiliation, stigma, and exclusion.
- Inaccessibility of sanitary products affects fundamental right to education under Article 21A and Right to Education (RTE) Act.
- All schools must provide Sensitisation of male teachers and students, gender-segregated toilets, free sanitary napkins (preferably through vending machines), and dedicated MHM corners.

Indian Railways Launches First LNG-Diesel Dual-Fuel DEMU Train

- Indian Railways has successfully operationalised the nation's first-ever LNG-Diesel dual-fuel DEMU train at Sabarmati in Ahmedabad.
- Under this initiative, the driving power cars of the 1,400 HP DEMU train have been converted to a dual-fuel system, utilising Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG) to replace approximately 40 per cent of the traditional diesel consumption.

Digital Food Currency

- The Government of India is set to launch a pilot program for Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC), also termed Digital Food Currency, in February 2026.
- This initiative targets beneficiaries in Chandigarh, Puducherry, and three districts of Gujarat (Anand, Sabarmati, and Dahod) to streamline the world's largest free food security program.
- Regulatory Body: Reserve Bank of India (RBI).
- Digital food coupons are a programmed form of e-Rupee (CBDC). Instead of physical grains or cash transfers, beneficiaries receive digital tokens specifically locked for use at authorized ration shops.
- Implementing Authority: Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, in coordination with the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) and State Governments.

Eminent Personalities in News

PM Modi and HM Amit Shah pay tribute to Mannathu Padmanabhan on his birth anniversary

- **Mannathu Padmanabha Pillai (2 January 1878 – 25 February 1970), was an Indian social reformer and freedom fighter from the south-western state of Kerala.**
- His birthday (2 January) is observed as Mannam Jayanti every year.
- He is recognised as the **founder of the Nair Service Society (NSS)**, which represents the Nair community.
- **Actively supported the Vaikom Satyagraha (1924–25) for temple entry rights** for lower castes, even though he was not directly involved in the satyagraha

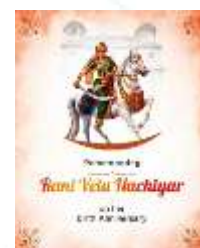


RaniVelu Nachiyar birth anniversary

- Prime Minister Pays Tribute to Rani Velu Nachiyar on Her Birth Anniversary on 3rd January.

About Rani Velu Nachiyar (1730-96)

- **Born:** In 1730 as the princess of Ramnad (Ramanathapuram), Tamil Nadu.
- **Skills:** Trained extensively in warfare, including horse riding, archery, and martial arts like Silambam and Valari.



Key Contributions:

- Forged an alliance with Hyder Ali of Mysore.
- **Established the "Udaiyaal" battalion:** one of the first all-women army units in world history.
- **Pioneer of Suicide Tactics:** Her loyal commander, Kuyili, is credited with the first recorded suicide attack in Indian history by setting herself on fire to destroy a British ammunition depot in 1780.
- In 1780, she successfully recaptured Sivaganga, defeating the British nearly 77 years before the 1857 Revolt.

Savitribai Phule on her 195th birth anniversary (Jan 3, 2026)

- Prime Minister paid tributes to Savitribai Phule on her birth anniversary, recalling her lifelong commitment to education, equality, and social transformation.
- Savitribai Phule (1831–1897) was a pioneering social reformer, poet, and educator, widely regarded as the first female teacher of modern India and a foundational figure of Indian feminism.



Early life:

- Born in Naigaon (present-day Maharashtra), she was married in childhood to Jyotirao Phule and later moved to Pune.
- Her early exposure to learning ignited a lifelong mission to reform society through education.

Education and training:

- Encouraged by Jyotirao Phule, she learned to read and write and undertook teacher training at institutions in Ahmednagar and Pune, becoming a qualified teacher in 1847—an extraordinary achievement for women of that era.

Key contributions:

- Pioneer of girls' education: In 1848, she co-founded India's first girls' school at Bhidewada, Pune, and went on to help establish 18 schools for girls and marginalized communities.
- Social reform for the oppressed: Opened shelters for widows, destitute women, and child brides (1854; expanded in 1864); campaigned against child marriage, caste discrimination, and untouchability.
- Institution building: Played a central role in nurturing the Satyashodhak Samaj.



Prime Minister Modi pays tribute to Lala Lajpat Rai on his birth anniversary

- Lala Lajpat Rai was **born on 28 January 1865** in Dhudike village, **Punjab**.
- Lala Lajpat Rai, also known as **Punjab Kesari (Lion of Punjab)**, was a prominent nationalist leader, freedom fighter, and social reformer.
- Alongside **Bal Gangadhar Tilak and Bipin Chandra Pal**, forming the famous **Lal-Bal-Pal trio** - pushed for **Swaraj, Swadeshi, and Boycott** of British goods during the Swadeshi Movement.
- Lala Lajpat Rai led the protests against the Simon Commission, famously raising the slogan "**Simon Go Back.**" - **martyrdom on November 17, 1928**
- **He co-founded the Punjab National Bank in 1894**. He founded and **edited several newspapers**, including **Vande Mataram**, and **Arya Gazette**. founding force behind **the influential newspaper Punjab Kesari**.
- Rai also **authored several books**, including **Young India, England's Debt to India, The Story of My Deportation**, and **Unhappy India**
- Lala Lajpat Rai wrote **biographies of Mazzini, Garibaldi, Shivaji, Dayanand, and Shri Krishna**.



Bharat Ratna Karpuri Thakur ji birth anniversary

- **Karpoori Thakur, called as "Jan Nayak"**, was a prominent Indian politician who served as the 11th Chief Minister of Bihar twice, from 1970-71 and 1977-79.
- Karpoori Thakur, born on 24 January 1924 in Pitaunjhia (now Karpoori Gram) in Darbhanga, Bihar.
- **Represented the Nai community, listed as an Extremely Backward Class (EBC) among OBCs.** In 2024, the **President of India** announced the **Bharat Ratna** awarded to **socialist leader and former Chief Minister of Bihar Karpoori Thakur**, posthumously.



Parbati Giri

- Prime Minister of India paid tribute to Parbati Giri on her birth centenary, highlighting her role in the freedom struggle and her lifelong dedication to social service.
- Parbati Giri (1926–1995) was an Indian freedom fighter and social reformer from Odisha, widely known as the "Mother Teresa of Western Odisha" for her humanitarian work among the poor, tribals, and marginalised communities.



Early days:

- Born on 19 January 1926 at Samlaipadar village, Bargarh district (Odisha).
- Inspired by nationalist activities led by Congress leaders, including her uncle Ramachandra Giri.
- Left formal education at a young age and joined Congress organisational work by 1938, adopting Gandhian principles as a way of life.

Contributions to the freedom movement:

- Actively participated in Individual Satyagraha (1940) and mobilised villagers for the Khadi and Charkha movement.
- Joined the Quit India Movement (1942) at the age of 16, leading rallies and openly defying British authority.

- Known for bold acts of resistance, including urging Indians to boycott British institutions; arrested and imprisoned for two years.
- Earned the epithet “Banhi Kanya” for her fearless nationalism and mass mobilisation.

Literary and social work:

- While not primarily known for literary writings, her legacy lies in grassroots activism, institution-building, and community service.
- After Independence, devoted herself to relief work during the 1951 Odisha famine, prison reforms, eradication of leprosy, and welfare of tribal communities.

End days and recognition:

- Awarded by the Department of Social Welfare, Government of India (1984) for exemplary service.
- Conferred an Honorary Doctorate by Sambalpur University (1988).
- Passed away on 17 August 1995, leaving behind a legacy of service-driven nationalism and ethical public life.



28th January K. M. Cariappa Jayanti

- Field Marshal K.M. Cariappa (1899-1993)
- He was independent India's first Commander-in-Chief of the Indian Army—a role previously reserved for the British.
- Army Day, celebrated every January 15, marks the day he took over as Commander-in-Chief, replacing General Sir Francis Roy Bucher.

Military Career: 1919-1953

- He is the first Indian to command a battalion in the Indian Army.
- During World War II, he served in the Middle East and Burma.
- Following his retirement, he served as Indian high commissioner to Australia & New Zealand.
- The Government conferred the rank of Field Marshal on Cariappa in 1986.

National/ international festivals

13 January - Lohri Festival

- Lohri is a popular **Indian Punjabi folk festival** primarily celebrated in the country's northern regions.
- Lohri is a festival that signifies the **end of winter and the start of spring**. The January **sugarcane harvest** is celebrated in the Lohri festival
- it is celebrated **one night before Makar Sankranti** festival.
- Dulla Bhatti: The festival is associated with the legend of **Dulla Bhatti, a local hero who rescued Punjabi girls from the Mughals**. Folk songs about Dulla Bhatti are a part of the Lohri festival.
- It is commemorated by the **lighting of a holy bonfire**, which is considered as a symbol of fertility, auspiciousness, and good fortune, especially for new brides and newborn children.



Pongal 2026

Pongal, one of the most significant Hindu festivals of South India, **especially in Tamil Nadu**.

- The word Pongal **means 'overflow' or 'boiling over'**.
- Also known as Thai Pongal, the four-day occasion** is observed in the month of Thai, when crops such as **rice are harvested** and people show their gratitude to the almighty and the generosity of the land.
- The Pongal dish dates back to the Chola dynasty

Festival Day	Date
Bhogi Pandigai	Tuesday, Jan 13, 2026
Thai Pongal / Makar Sankranti	Wednesday, Jan 14, 2026
Mattu Pongal	Thursday, Jan 15, 2026
Kaanum Pongal	Friday, Jan 16, 2026



- Tamilians celebrate the occasion by making **traditional designs known as kolams in their homes**

- Additionally, the traditional Pongal dish is made from newly harvested rice and is further offered to the Sun God.

The four days of Pongal

- **Bhogi Pongal:** The first day of Pongal, when people burn old items and celebrate new possessions.
- **Surya Pongal or Thai Pongal:** The second day of Pongal, when people worship the Sun God.
- **Mattu Pongal:** The third day of Pongal, when people worship cattle.
- **Kaanum Pongal:** The fourth day of Pongal, when people perform songs and dances, and exchange gifts

“Boda Tyohar”, the biggest annual festival of the Hati tribe commenced

- “Boda Tyohar”, the biggest annual festival of the Hati tribe in Himachal Pradesh’s Sirmour .
- Boda Tyohar, also called Magho ko Tyohar, is the biggest annual festival of the Hatti tribe.
- The Hattis are a close-knit community who take their name from their age-old professional practice of selling their homegrown crops at small markets called ‘Haat’ in nearby cities.
- These tribal people reside in the Himachal-Uttarakhand border in the basin of the Giri and Tons rivers, both tributaries of the Yamuna.
- **The Hatti tribe has two clans:** Trans-Giri (Himachal Pradesh) and Jaunsar-Bawar (Uttarakhand), with similar traditions and common intermarriage.
- **They practise Jodidara, a form of polyandry where a woman marries two or more brothers; it is legally recognised in Himachal Pradesh.**
- The community is governed by a traditional council called Khumbli.
- Their economy depends on agriculture and cash crops.
- In 2023, the Hattis of Himachal Pradesh were granted Scheduled Tribe (ST) status.



Makar Sankranti & Magh Bihu

Makar Sankranti 2026 - January 14

- As **the sun moves north**, bringing **longer days and warmer nights**, India prepares to celebrate Makar Sankranti
- It is a significant shift in the astrological and agricultural cycles and is observed throughout India **to worship Lord Surya**, the Sun God **when the sun enters Makara (Capricorn) from the Dhanu Rashi (Sagittarius).**
- According to Hindu mythology, **Sankranti was a divinity who slew the demon Sankarasur on the day after Makar Sankranti**, also known as Karidin or Kinkrant.



Different Names of Sankranti Festival in Different States

- In UP and Gujarat, the festival is known as Uttarayan or Kicheri.
- In Odisha, it is called Makara Chaula
- In Bihar - Til Sakraat or Dahi Chura.
- Kerala – Makara vilakku.
- Karnataka - Suggi.
- Tamil Nadu - as Pongal
- In Maharashtra and Goa - Haldi Kumkum or Maghi Sankrant.
- In Himachal Pradesh - Magha Saaji.
- In Assam - Magh Bihu or Bhogali Bihu.
- In West Bengal - Poush Sankranti.

Bihu:

- People celebrate **Magh Bihu/Bhogali Bihu** (celebration of the harvest season).
- Bihu is the **main festival of Assam. It is celebrated three times a year:**
 - **Rongali or Bohag Bihu** is observed in **April** (Assamese New Year and the onset of spring.).
 - **Kongali or Kati Bihu** observed in **October** .
 - **Bhogali or Magh Bihu** observed in **January** (festival of food).
- **Festive food - pitha** (rice cake) and **larus** (traditional food made of rice, coconut) are prepared. The **Dimasa Kacharis tribe** is known to be the festival's first-known ancestors.
- **Rituals**
 - **Magh Bihu is celebrated over two days.**

- The **first day** is known as **Uruka or Bihu eve**.
- On this day, **Meiji (bonfire)** is **burnt** with people singing Bihu songs, beating Dhol, and celebrating with their loved ones.
- The main Magh Bihu is observed the next day.

Bhogi is being celebrated with traditional fervour in Tamil Nadu & Telangana

- Bhogi is the beginning of the three-day Sankranti festival, which holds deep cultural and spiritual importance across South India.
- It is celebrated with great zeal and fervour, especially in the states of Tamil Nadu, Telangana, and Andhra Pradesh.
- **Bhogi is also commemorated as the beginning of the harvest festival and is observed as the last day of the Tamil month, Margazhi.**
- One of the most recognisable sights of Bhogi is the Bhogi Mantalu, or ceremonial bonfire.



Sabarimala Prepares for Makara Vilakku Festival

- In Kerala, the hill shrine of Sabarimala will celebrate the Makaravilakku festival, coinciding with Makara Sankrama night, when devotees will witness the appearance of the Makarajyothi
- The Makarajyothi is sighted at Ponnambalamedu on Makara Sankranti night.
- **Thiruvabharanam refers to the sacred ornaments of Lord Ayyappa.**
- Pilgrims traditionally observe a 41-day vrata before darshan.

Vasant Panchami 2026

- In 2026, Vasant Panchami will be observed on 23 January.
- **Saraswati Puja, also known as "Vasant Panchami", is celebrated in honour of the Hindu goddess Saraswati, as her birth anniversary.**
- The festival also marks the arrival of spring and is commemorated differently across the country. It is marked by kite flying in North India, while in states like Bihar, West Bengal, Odisha, and Assam, Saraswati Puja is observed.
- Basant means 'spring', and Panchami is the fifth day of the Hindu month of Magha (corresponding to January-February in the Gregorian calendar), on which the festival is held.
- During this sacred festival, people dress in yellow, adorn their homes with yellow flowers, and recite shlokas, mantras, hymns, and the Saraswati Vandana.



Banking

FSS Achieves ISO IEC 42001 Certification Lead Status

- Financial Software and Systems (FSS) a global leader in payments technology and transaction processing, has become the first payments company in India, the Middle East, APAC and South Africa to be certified as an ISO IEC 42001 Certification Lead.
- **ISO/IEC 42001 represents a significant evolution in how organizations govern AI, moving beyond ad-hoc adoption to a structured, organization-wide AI governance framework.**
- ISO IEC 42001 is a new and globally evolving standard, and only a limited number of organisations currently meet its stringent requirements



Budget session from January 28; Union Budget on February 1

- The Budget session of Parliament is likely to commence on January 28 and the Union Budget is set to be tabled on February 1.
- President Droupadi Murmu will address a joint sitting of the two Houses on January 28.
- Parliament will sit on January 30 when the Economic Survey is likely to be tabled.
- After discussions on the Motion of Thanks on the President's address and Union Budget, Parliament will adjourn for a near month-long recess on February 13.
- Parliament will reconvene on March 9 and the session will conclude on April 2.

About Union Budget

- A budget is an annual financial statement for a specific period of time, usually a year, that outlines projected income and expenses.
- It is used as a tool for managing financial resources and achieving specific goals such as mobilization of resources, fiscal consolidation, etc.
- **Article 112 of the Constitution requires the government to present to Parliament a statement of estimated receipts and expenditure in respect of every financial year, from April 1 to March 31.**
- This statement is called the annual financial statement.
- **It is divided into three parts** – Consolidated Fund, Contingency Fund and Public Account.
- For each of these funds, the government has to present a statement of receipts and expenditure

Urban Cooperative Banks

- The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) proposed resuming the issuance of licenses for Urban Cooperative Banks (UCBs) after nearly two decades.

About Urban Cooperative Banks

- **Urban Cooperative Banks are not formally defined but refers to primary cooperative banks located in urban and semi-urban areas**
- **History:** The first formal co-operative legislation in India came with the Co-operative Credit Societies Act of 1904 (During Lord Curzon's tenure) and also enacted the more comprehensive Co-operative Societies Act of 1912.
- **The first urban cooperative credit society, (Anyonya Sahakari Mandali)** was established in 1889 in Baroda.
- **Functions:** Provide services like housing finance, personal loans, MSME credit, and deposits to small borrowers, traders, and small-scale industries.
- They are **registered as cooperative societies** under the provisions of, either the State Cooperative Societies Act of the State concerned or the Multi State Cooperative Societies Act, 2002.
- **Regulation:** The Reserve Bank regulates and supervises the banking functions of UCBs under the provisions of Banking regulation Act, 1949. The Reserve Bank has vested powers to issue licenses to UCBs

RXIL Makes History By Becoming India's First TReDS Platform to Announce Interim Dividend

- Receivables Exchange of India Ltd (RXIL), India's first Trade Receivables Discounting System (TReDS) platform, has announced an interim dividend of 21.6 per cent on its shares.
- **This marks a historic milestone, as RXIL becomes the first TReDS platform in the country to distribute returns to its shareholders,** reflecting its financial maturity, strong performance, and sustained focus on strengthening liquidity for micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs).
- RXIL received approval from the Reserve Bank of India in 2016 and commenced operations in January 2017.

UPI Set to Launch in Japan, Expanding India's Digital Payments Reach

- India's Unified Payments Interface (UPI) is set to debut in Japan, marking another milestone in the global expansion of the country's flagship digital payments system.
- **Japanese IT services firm NTT Data is partnering with the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI)** to enable UPI acceptance in Japan on a trial basis in fiscal 2026.
- **Unified Payments Interface or UPI is a real-time payment system developed by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI)** that enables instant money transfers between two bank accounts using a mobile platform.
- **Launched in 2016.**
- UPI revolutionized the digital payments landscape by allowing users to transfer funds instantly-24x7 through mobile apps using just a Virtual Payment Address (VPA), which negates the need to share sensitive bank details.



Economic Survey 2025-26

- The Economic Survey is an **annual document presented by the government ahead of the Union Budget to review the state of the economy.**
- It is **prepared by the Economic Division of the Department of Economic Affairs** in the Ministry of Finance **under the supervision of the Chief Economic Adviser** (currently **V. Anantha Nageswaran**).

- It is **tabled in both houses of Parliament** by the Union Finance Minister .
- It is released every year before the Union Budget to provide an economic background for policy formulation.
- **Economic Survey Historical Context:**
 - First presented in 1950-51.
 - Initially, it was a part of the budget documents.
 - Became a separate volume in 1964.

Purpose:

- To **review the developments** in the **Indian economy** over the **previous 12 months**.
- To **summarise the performance on major development programs**
- To highlight the **policy initiatives of the government**
- To **analyse the economic trends and provide an outlook for the coming year**

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman :

- **On January 27, 2026** participated in a **traditional 'halwa' ceremony**.
- The ceremony is a customary ritual in which traditional dessert '**halwa**' is **prepared and served** to officials and staff **members of the Finance Ministry who are involved in the preparation of the budget**.
- **Record-Longest Speech:** Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman holds the record for the longest Union Budget speech in Indian history, delivered in 2021 for 2 hours and 40 minutes.

First Woman to Present the Budget?

- Indira Gandhi became the first woman to present India's Budget in 1970–71 after the then finance minister resigned.
- The first paperless Union Budget was presented in 2021 during the pandemic, with all documents digitally stored and accessed.

Which FM presented the most number of Budgets?

- **Morarji Desai holds the record for presenting the highest number of Union Budgets (10) in India's history.**
- 6 Budgets during his first term as Finance Minister (1959–1964)
- 4 Budgets during his second term (1967–1969)
- Nirmala Sitharaman is set to present her 9th consecutive Union Budget on 1 February 2026.
- If she presents one more Budget after this, she will equal Morarji Desai's record of 10 Budgets.

First Woman to Present the Budget?

- Indira Gandhi became the first woman to present India's Budget in 1970–71 after the then finance minister resigned.
- The first paperless Union Budget was presented in 2021 during the pandemic, with all documents digitally stored and accessed.

Which FM presented the most number of Budgets?

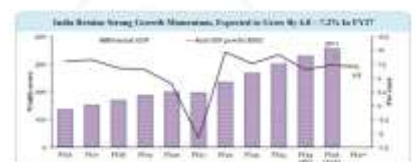
- **Morarji Desai holds the record for presenting the highest number of Union Budgets (10) in India's history.**
 - 6 Budgets during his first term as Finance Minister (1959–1964)
 - 4 Budgets during his second term (1967–1969)
- Nirmala Sitharaman is set to present her 9th consecutive Union Budget on 1 February 2026.
 - If she presents one more Budget after this, she will equal Morarji Desai's record of 10 Budgets.

Economic Survey 2025- 26 Key Highlights

- The Survey advocates "**Disciplined Swadeshi**" through a three-tier framework focusing on strategic urgency, feasibility and cost-effectiveness.

Overall State of the Economy

- **real GDP growth** for FY26 is projected at 7.4%,
- while **GVA growth** is estimated at 7.3%,
- **Inflation Trends:** India recorded the lowest inflation rate since the beginning of the CPI series, with April-Dec '25 average headline inflation coming in at 1.7%.



Consumption and Investment

- **Private Final Consumption Expenditure** (PFCE) grew by 7% in FY26, reaching 61.5% of GDP, the highest level since 2012
- **Gross Fixed Capital Formation** (GFCF) rose by 7.8%, remaining steady at 30% of GDP.

Fiscal Developments

- Centre's **revenue receipts** increased to 9.2% of GDP in FY25.
- **Effective capital expenditure** of the Centre rose to about 4% of GDP in FY25.

Monetary Management and Banking Sector

- The banking system showed strong resilience, with Gross NPAs declining to 2.2% in September 2025
- Credit growth of scheduled commercial banks accelerated to 14.5% (YoY) by December 2025.

Financial Inclusion and Capital Markets: Under **PM Jan Dhan Yojana**, 55.02 crore bank accounts were opened by March 2025, with 36.63 crore accounts in rural and semi-urban areas.

Agriculture and Allied Sectors

- **Foodgrain production** reached 3,577.3 LMT in AY 2024–25, an increase of 254.3 LMT over the previous year.
- **Horticulture**, contributing about one-third of agricultural GVA surpassing foodgrain output.
- **Livestock and fisheries sectors** - increasing by more than 140 per cent during 2014-2024.
- Under **PM-KISAN**, more than ₹4.09 lakh crore has been transferred to farmers. **e-NAM** enhanced price discovery by integrating farmers, traders and FPOs across States.

External Sector Performance

- India's share in global **merchandise exports** nearly **doubled** from 1% in 2005 to 1.8% in 2024, while services export share rose from 2% to 4.3%.
- **Total exports reached** a record USD 825.3 billion in FY25.
- **Services exports** touched an all-time high of USD 387.6 billion, growing by 13.6%.
- India remained the **largest recipient of remittances globally**, with inflows of USD 135.4 billion in FY25, approximately 3.5% of GDP.
- **Foreign exchange reserves** rose to USD 701.4 billion (January 2026).

Infrastructure and Connectivity

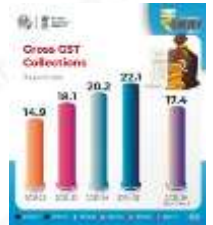
- Central government **capital expenditure increased over four times**, reaching ₹11.21 lakh crore in FY26 (BE).
- **High-speed highway corridors** expanded nearly ten-fold to 5,364 km.
- **Railway network expanded** with near-total electrification (99.1%).
- India became the **3rd largest domestic aviation** market, with airports increasing from 74 (2014) to 164 (2025).

Social Sector: Education, Health and Employment

- School enrolment **improved with GERs** exceeding 90% at primary and upper primary levels.
- **Expansion of premier institutions:** 23 IITs, 21 IIMs and 20 AIIMS, including overseas IIT campuses in Zanzibar and Abu Dhabi.
- **e-Shram portal registered** over 31 crore unorganised workers, with women forming 54%.

Poverty Reduction and Rural Development

- **India's poverty** rates in 2022-23 **were 5.3 per cent** for extreme poverty and **23.9 per cent** for lower-middle-income poverty.
- **Multidimensional Poverty Index (MPI)** declined sharply from 55.3% (2005–06) to 11.28% (2022–23) as per NITI Aayog.
- **Social Services Expenditure** increased to 7.9% of GDP in FY26 (BE).



International

Rare Kushan Coins, Lapis Lazuli Unearthed at Taxila's Bhir Mound

- Pakistani archaeologists found rare decorative stones and coins **while excavating a UNESCO-listed site near the historic city of Takshashila**, providing a rare view of the earliest urban settlement of the extensive ancient civilisation.



- The discoveries were made at the ancient Bhir Mound, where experts unearthed decorative stones dating to the 6th century BC and coins from the 2nd century AD.
- The decorative stones are lapis lazuli, a prized semi-precious stone, while the coins belong to the Kushan period.

US Launches Strikes on Venezuela, Trump Claims Maduro Captured

- The United States reportedly captured Nicolás Maduro, President of Venezuela, following a large-scale strike.
- Operation Absolute Resolve (executed in the early hours of 3 January 2026) was described as a major US military mission aimed at capturing Nicolás Maduro and his wife Cilia Flores and bringing them into US custody.
- **The US cited migration, drug trafficking, and “narco-terrorism”** as the primary reasons for action against Venezuela and Nicolás Maduro.



About Venezuela

- **Location:** Northern coast of South America
- **Borders:** Guyana (east), Brazil (south), Colombia (south-west and west)
- **Capital:** Caracas
- **Major Rivers:** Orinoco (shared with Colombia), Rio Negro (shared with Colombia & Brazil)
- **Major Lakes:** Lake Maracaibo (largest in South America), Lake Guri
- **Highest Point:** Pico Bolívar
- **World's Highest Waterfall:** Angel Falls (Guiana Highlands)

RQ-170 Sentinel

- A rare U.S. Air Force RQ-170 “Sentinel” stealth surveillance drone was recently spotted returning to Roosevelt Roads Naval Station in eastern Puerto Rico, following U.S. military strikes conducted overnight against targets in Venezuela.
- It is an American high-altitude long-endurance unmanned aerial vehicle.
- It is **designed to execute intelligence, surveillance, target acquisition, and reconnaissance (ISTAR) and electronic warfare missions over a target area.**
- The aircraft entered service in the mid-2000s and has previously been associated with U.S. operations in the Middle East and Asia.



Delcy Rodríguez, the interim President of Venezuela

- Venezuela's Supreme Court ordered that Vice President Delcy Rodríguez assume the role of acting president in the absence of President Nicolás Maduro, who was detained earlier in the day during an operation carried out by US forces.
- **Rodríguez served as Venezuela's minister of communication and information** from 2013 to 2014, before becoming foreign minister from 2014 to 2017.



Monroe Doctrine

- The U.S. action against Venezuela and the capture of its president has been **justified by Donald Trump by invoking the Monroe Doctrine, a 19th-century U.S. policy.**
- The Monroe Doctrine is a U.S. foreign policy principle asserting that the Western Hemisphere is the exclusive sphere of influence of the United States, and that any external (especially European) interference would be treated as a hostile act against the U.S.
- **Established in:** Proclaimed on December 2, 1823 by James Monroe, the 5th President of the United States.
- **Announced during his State of the Union address to the U.S. Congress.**



China's proposal of the Global Governance Initiative

- China has reiterated its four global initiatives—**with the Global Governance Initiative (GGI) at the core**—as a people-centred framework for peace, security, and development.
- The **Global Governance Initiative (GGI) is China's proposal to reform and**



improve the existing global governance system so that it becomes more inclusive, representative, and people-centred, ensuring that all nations and peoples benefit from globalisation and international cooperation.

Four major proposals:

- **GDI – Global Development Initiative:** Inclusive development, poverty reduction, people-centric growth.
- **GSI – Global Security Initiative:** Cooperative security, peaceful dialogue, respect for sovereignty and non-interference.
- **GCI – Global Civilization Initiative:** Mutual respect among civilisations, cultural dialogue, diversity as strength.
- **GGI – Global Governance Initiative:** People-centred global governance, institutional reforms, cooperation on climate change, AI, finance, and trade.

Bulgaria joins eurozone

- Bulgaria officially adopted the euro on January 1, 2026, becoming the 21st member of the eurozone and retiring its national currency, the lev.
- **Bulgaria is a Balkan nation in southeastern Europe and a member of the European Union** (since 2007) and NATO (since 2004). It replaced the Bulgarian lev (in use since 1881) with the euro after fulfilling EU convergence criteria.
- **Bulgaria:** Located in the eastern Balkan Peninsula; strategic crossroads of Europe–Black Sea–West Asia.
- **Borders:** Romania, Greece, Turkey, Serbia, North Macedonia; Black Sea coast.



Eurozone (Euro Area):

- Group of EU states using the euro (€) with a common monetary policy.
- **Founded:** 1992 Maastricht Treaty → created EMU with convergence criteria.
- **1999:** Euro launched as book money.
- **2002:** Euro notes & coins introduced.



Ecuador President Daniel Noboa declares 60-day emergency amid surge in criminal violence

- This comes due to an increase in criminal violence, which has caused serious internal commotion.
- **Capital City:** Quito.
- **Borders:** Colombia (N), Peru (S & E)
- **Terrain:** Coastal lowlands + Andes (Occidental & Oriental)
- **Highest peak:** Mount Chimborazo (6,268 m)
- **Active volcano:** Cotopaxi
- **Equator** Passes through it.



India launches New E-Business Visa for Chinese Nationals.

- India has introduced an e-Production Investment Business Visa called e-B-4 Visa that Chinese businessmen can apply for to travel to India for specific business activities, including installation and commissioning of equipment.
- **The e-B-4 Visa, was introduced on January 1, can be applied online without visiting the embassy or agents.**
- The new visa will be issued in about 45 to 50 days, with permission to stay in India for up to six months.
- **The visa can be applied for installation and commissioning, quality check and essential maintenance, production, IT and ERP ramp-up, training, supply chain development for empanelling vendors, plant design and bring-up, according to the advisory.**



OPEC+ Latest News

- Recently, the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC)+ has agreed in principle to maintain steady oil output despite rising political tensions among key members.

About OPEC+

- It is the alliance of major oil-exporting nations.
- It is an extension of the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries formed in 1960.

- It consists of 22 oil-exporting countries which meet regularly to decide how much crude oil to sell on the world market.
- Members of OPEC+: It comprises 12 OPEC countries plus Azerbaijan, Bahrain, Brunei, Kazakhstan, Russia, Mexico, Malaysia, South Sudan, Sudan, and Oman.
- These nations aim to work together on adjusting crude oil production to bring stability to the oil market.

Key Facts about Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries

- It is a permanent intergovernmental organization of oil-exporting countries.
- **It was established in 1960 by the five founding members** Iran, Iraq, Kuwait, Saudi Arabia, and Venezuela.
- Currently, it has 12 members, including Algeria, Congo, Equatorial Guinea, Gabon, Libya, Nigeria, and the United Arab Emirates.
- Angola withdrew its membership effective 1 January 2024.
- **Headquarters:** Vienna, Austria.



TRUMP ORDERS U.S. WITHDRAWAL FROM 66 INTERNATIONAL ORGANISATIONS, INCLUDING 31 UN BODIES

U.S. Withdraws from 66 International Organisations Under Trump Order

- US President Donald Trump has announced that the United States will withdraw from 60 international organisations, including UN bodies and the India-France-led International Solar Alliance.
- **Among them was the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), the main global agreement through which countries cooperate on climate change.**
- It is often described as the foundation of global climate action because it led to later agreements, including the 2015 Paris climate deal.

International Solar Alliance

- It is a treaty-based international intergovernmental organization.
- **It was launched in 2015 by India and France** at the COP21 summit in Paris to promote solar energy as a sustainable solution for energy access and climate change.
- **Headquarters:** National Institute of Solar Energy (NISE) in Gurugram.
- It is the **first international organization established in the country.**
- Membership is **open to those solar-resource-rich States which lie fully or partially between the Tropic of Cancer and the Tropic of Capricorn, and which are members of the United Nations.**
- Partner country status may be granted to the States which fall outside the Tropic of Cancer and the Tropic of Capricorn, are members of the United Nations.

United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change

- UNFCCC is the principal global treaty for coordinating international responses to climate change.
- It provides the foundation for subsequent legal instruments, including the Kyoto Protocol and the landmark Paris Agreement.
- **The purpose of the UNFCCC is to harness international cooperation to limit the rise of average global temperatures to minimize the impacts of climate change to enable timely adaptation, avoid threats to food production, and ensure sustainable economic development.**
- It is one of three conventions that was adopted at the Rio Earth Summit in 1992 to promote a sustainable planet for future generations.



Weimar Triangle Welcomes India to Discuss EU-India Partnership

Weimar Triangle

- India's External Affairs Minister recently participated in India's first-ever engagement in the Weimar Triangle, with French and Polish counterparts along with German representatives.

About Weimar Triangle

- It is a **regional political grouping of France, Germany, and Poland.**
- It was formed on 29 August 1991 by a joint declaration issued in Weimar, Germany, by the Foreign Ministers of the three countries.

It had three objectives:

- To involve France in German-Polish reconciliation by building on the Franco-German experience;

- **Greenland** To strengthen dialogue and political cooperation between the three countries.
- To support Poland in its process of integration into NATO and the European Union (EU).
- **Although the Weimar Triangle still has no institutional structure, it remains a framework of reference at the political level.**



Greenland

- The proposal by US President Donald Trump to acquire Greenland has resurfaced, triggering strong opposition from Denmark and European allies, who cite sovereignty and international law constraints.
- **Greenland (Kalaallit Nunaat) is the world's largest island and a self-governing territory with extensive internal autonomy, while remaining within the Kingdom of Denmark.**



Located in:

- North Atlantic Ocean and Arctic region
- Largely within the Arctic Circle, between North America and Europe

Key geological features:

- **Greenland Ice Sheet:** Covers about 80% of the island, second only to Antarctica, and a critical indicator of global climate change.
- **Ancient shield rocks:** Geologically part of the Canadian Shield, composed mainly of Precambrian rocks.
- **Fjords and glaciers:** Deeply indented coastlines with fast-moving outlet glaciers such as Jakobshavn Glacier.

Currently governed by:

- Denmark retains control over defence, foreign affairs, and currency.
- Greenland's elected government manages domestic affairs, under the Self-Rule Act (2009), which recognises the right to self-determination.

India Launches BRICS Presidency 2026 Website and Logo

- India has formally launched the official logo and website for its BRICS 2026 Presidency.
- The **BRICS India 2026 Logo symbolises inclusivity, dialogue and shared growth.**
- **The BRICS 2026 Theme** is "Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation, and Sustainability".
- It draws inspiration from Prime Minister's "Humanity First and People-centric" vision for BRICS.
- The logo blends tradition with modernity, with petals reflecting the vibrant colours of all BRICS members and symbolising collective strength and unity.
- At the centre, the "Namaste" gesture conveys warmth, respect, and harmonious collaboration.
- Brazil has formally handed over the **BRICS (18th) presidency to India for 2026.**
- **India will serve as the rotating Chair of BRICS in 2026.**
- As Chair, India will set priorities, convene meetings, and host the annual summit for the year.



Origins (BRIC): Brazil, Russia, India, China

- The first summit of heads of state/government took place in 2009 (Yekaterinburg).
- **BRICS formed:** South Africa joined in 2011, turning BRIC into BRICS.
- **Headquarters:** No permanent HQ.
- **Members:** Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, **Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, United Arab Emirates, Saudi Arabia, Indonesia.**

India-Israel Joint Declaration on Fisheries and Aquaculture

- India and Israel signed a Joint Ministerial Declaration of Intent to deepen cooperation in **fisheries and aquaculture during the Global Summit on Blue Food Security 2026 in Eilat.**
- A bilateral declaration between India and Israel to strengthen collaboration in fisheries and aquaculture through technology transfer, joint research, innovation, and capacity building, aligned with sustainable and climate-resilient development goals.



Key features:

- **Advanced aquaculture technologies:** Cooperation on RAS, biofloc, cage culture, aquaponics, mariculture, seaweed farming, and aquarium systems.
- **Genetic & seed improvement:** Joint work on high-yield species, pathogen-free seed, brood stock development, and genetic enhancement programmes.
- **Water & resource efficiency:** Adoption of Israeli water-saving and water-management technologies in aquaculture systems.
- **Innovation & startups:** Promotion of startups and R&D ecosystems to advance the Blue Economy.
- **Monitoring & traceability:** Technology-driven fisheries monitoring, data systems, transparency, and traceability for responsible fishing.

FDA Approves Zycubo For Rare Menkes Disease

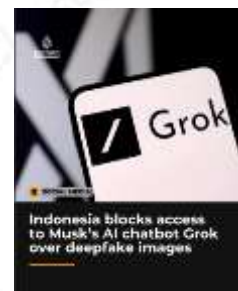
- **The U.S. Food and Drug Administration recently approved the Zycubo (copper histidinate) as the first treatment for Menkes disease in pediatric patients.**

Menkes Disease

- It is a **genetic disorder that affects your body's ability to process copper.**
- It is **caused by a mutation of the ATP7A gene located on the X chromosome. This ATP7A gene affects how the body transports copper and maintains copper levels.**
- While the body only uses a small amount of copper, even this tiny amount is required for many functions.
- **Copper helps with metabolism**, brain functioning, blood vessel and blood cell formation, wound healing, and the immune system.
- **Copper also helps to convert iron into a usable form in the body.**
- Because the condition prevents the body from using copper correctly, **Menkes disease can lead to serious damage to the brain and nervous system and can harm a child's development.**
- It occurs mostly in male infants and is characterized by coarse, kinky hair (leading to its nickname of "kinky hair disease"), as well as failure to grow and thrive.
- **There isn't a cure for Menkes disease, but early treatment with copper can help reduce symptoms and prolong life.**

**Indonesia Blocks Grok Chatbot Over Explicit Deepfake Risks**

- Indonesian government temporarily blocked access to Grok, the artificial intelligence chatbot developed by Elon Musk's xAI, citing serious concerns about its ability to produce **AI-generated explicit and non-consensual deepfake imagery.**
- Indonesia is the first country globally to implement a nationwide block specifically over this issue.

**International Renewable Energy Agency**

- Recently, the Union Minister for New and Renewable Energy delivered India's national statement at the **16th Assembly of the International Renewable Energy Agency (IRENA) in Abu Dhabi, United Arab Emirates.**

About International Renewable Energy Agency

- It is an intergovernmental organisation that was founded in 2009 to support countries in their transition to a sustainable energy future.
- It serves as the principal platform for international cooperation, a centre of excellence, and a repository of policy, technology, resource and financial knowledge on renewable energy.
- **Member countries:** It has 170 Members (169 States and the European Union). India is also one of the founder members of IRENA.

**Governance of International Renewable Energy Agency**

- **Assembly:** It is IRENA's ultimate decision-making authority, made up of one representative from each Member.
- **Council:** It is composed of 21 Member States elected for a two-year term and is accountable to the Assembly.
- Council members serve on a rotating basis to ensure the effective participation of both developing and developed countries and a fair and equitable geographical distribution.

- Its headquarter is in Abu Dhabi, United Arab Emirates.
- It is an official United Nations observer.

Pax Silica Initiative

- The United States has announced that India will be invited to join the US-led Pax Silica initiative next month as part of efforts to stabilise and deepen India-US strategic and trade ties.
- **Pax Silica is a US-led economic security and technology partnership to build a secure, resilient and innovation-driven global supply chain for silicon, semiconductors, artificial intelligence, critical minerals and advanced manufacturing.**
- First Pax Silica Summit held in December 2025.
- **Nations involved:** Japan, South Korea, Singapore, Netherlands, United Kingdom, Israel, United Arab Emirates, Australia
- **Guest partners:** Taiwan, European Union, Canada, OECD

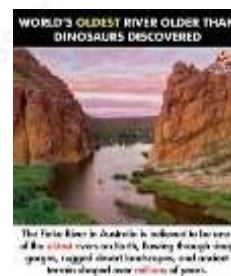


Finke River

- **The Finke River, known to the Arrernte people as Larapinta, is believed to be the world's oldest river system.**

About Finke River

- It is a major but intermittent river of central Australia.
- **It starts in the MacDonnell Ranges in the Northern Territory.**
- It flows for about 600 kilometers (370 miles) towards the Simpson Desert in South Australia.
- A combination of geological records, weathering profiles, and radionuclide measurements in the surrounding sediments and rocks has enabled scientists to date this river system to the Devonian (419 million to 359 million) or Carboniferous (359 million to 299 million) period.



India-EU FTA — Mother of All Deals.

- The free trade agreement (FTA) between India and the European Union (EU) has been termed "mother of all deals"
- **The signing of the India-EU trade deal was announced amid European Council President Antonio Costa and EU Commission President Von der Leyen's two-day India visit.**
- The trade agreement is expected benefit the most labour-intensive sectors such as textiles, leather, chemicals, electronics and jewellery as they do not compete with European manufacturers.
- According to the European Union, the agreement will remove or reduce duties on over 90% of EU goods exported to India.
- The deal is expected to double EU exports to India by 2032 and also includes climate support funding to back India's emissions-cutting efforts.



Key announcements from the EU

- EU exporters to save up to €4 billion a year in duties
- Biggest trade opening India has ever given to any partner
- Simplified customs procedures to make exports faster and cheaper
- The EU and India are currently negotiating a separate agreement on Geographical Indications (GIs)
- Strong protection for EU trademarks, designs, copyrights and trade secrets
- Digital trade chapter to ensure secure, fair and predictable online commerce.
- Privileged access for EU service providers in financial and maritime services

Product	2024 exports (EUR)	Current tariffs	Future Tariffs
Machinery and electrical equipment	€16.3 billion	Up to 44%	0% for almost all products
Aircraft and spacecraft	€6.4 billion	Up to 11%	0% for almost all products
Optical, medical and surgical equipment	€3.4 billion	Up to 27.5%	0% for 90% of the products
Plastics	€2.2 billion	Up to 16.5%	0% for almost all products
Pearls, precious stones and metals	€2.1 billion	Up to 22.5%	0% for 20% of the products and tariff reduction for another 30% of the products
Chemicals	€3.2 billion	Up to 22%	0% for almost all products
Motor vehicles	€1.6 billion	110%	30% (quota of 250K)
Iron and steel	€1.5 billion	Up to 22%	0% for almost all products
Pharmaceuticals	€1.1 billion	11%	0% for almost all products

EU agri-food sectors that will benefit:

Product	Current tariffs	Future Tariffs
Wine	150%	20% (premium range); 30% (medium range)
Spirits	Up to 150%	40%
Beer	110%	50%
Olive Oil, margarine and other vegetable oils	Up to 45%	0%
Kiwis and pears	33%	10% in-quota
Fruit juices and non-alcoholic beer	Up to 53%	0%
Processed food (breads, pastries, biscuits, pasta, chocolate, pet food)	Up to 50%	0%
Sheep meat	33%	0%
Sausages and other meat preparations	Up to 110%	50%

India Makes Historic Debut as Partner Country at Gulfood 2026 in Dubai

- India is participating as a partner country at Gulfood 2026, the world's largest annual food and beverage sourcing event, which opened in Dubai across two venues for the first time in its 31-year history.
- The Agricultural and Processed Food Products Export Development Authority (APEDA), under the Ministry of Commerce and Industry, is leading India's participation at the event.**
- The pavilion features 161 exhibitors from 25 states and regions across India.



Global Future Councils (GFCs)

- The United Arab Emirates and the World Economic Forum (WEF) have signed an MoU for Dubai to host the annual Global Future Councils (GFCs) meetings for the next five years.
- The Global Future Councils (GFCs) are the World Economic Forum's flagship multistakeholder knowledge network, designed as time-bound, invitation-only think tanks that generate forward-looking insights on emerging global challenges and opportunities.**
- Established in:** 2013 (as part of WEF's future-oriented knowledge architecture)
- Organisations involved:** World Economic Forum
- Strategic partner host (2026–2030):** United Arab Emirates

United Arab Emirates

- The President of the United Arab Emirates Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan is visiting India and will hold official talks with the Prime Minister of India.

About United Arab Emirates

- Location:** It is a Middle East country that is located on the north east edge of the Arabian Peninsula.
- Bordering Countries:** It is bordered by Saudi Arabia in the south and west; and Oman in the east.
- Maritime Boundary:** Gulf of Oman (East), Persian Gulf (North).
- Capital City:** Abu Dhabi



Geographical Features of United Arab Emirates

- Terrain:** The emirates comprise a mixed environment of rocky desert, coastal plains and wetlands, and waterless mountains.
- Climate:** The climate is hot and humid along the coast and is hotter still, but dry, in the interior.
- Highest point:** Jabal Bil 'Ays 1,905 m Mountain
- Major Ports:** Port Rāshid and Port Jebel Ali
- Natural Resources:** It mainly consists of petroleum and natural gas.
- Tropic of Cancer passes through UAE, specifically Abu Dhabi emirate.
- India and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) have agreed to double bilateral trade to USD 200 billion by 2032 and jointly condemned terrorism in all its forms, following high-level talks.
- A comprehensive strategic understanding between India and the UAE to deepen cooperation across trade, defence, energy, space, infrastructure, finance, and people-to-people ties, reinforcing the India-UAE Comprehensive Strategic Partnership.



Key provisions:**Trade and economic cooperation:**

- Commitment to double bilateral trade to USD 200 billion by 2032.
- Builds on the India–UAE CEPA (2022) to expand goods, services, and investment flows.

Energy partnership:

- USD 3 billion LNG deal: ADNOC Gas to supply LNG to HPCL for 10 years.
- India becomes UAE's largest LNG customer.
- Cooperation in civil nuclear energy and broader energy infrastructure.

Defence and security:

- Letter of Intent to conclude a Strategic Defence Partnership.
- Joint condemnation of terrorism in all its forms and manifestations.

Space and technology:

- LoI on joint space infrastructure development and commercialisation.
- Agreement to establish a supercomputing cluster in India.

Investment and infrastructure:

- UAE participation in developing a Special Investment Region at Dholera, Gujarat.
- DP World and First Abu Dhabi Bank to set up operations in GIFT City.

Culture and people-to-people ties: Establishment of the House of India in Abu Dhabi, showcasing Indian art, heritage, and archaeology.

80 years of the United Nations Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)

- The United Nations Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) will commemorate its 80th anniversary on 23 January 2026, marking eight decades of coordinating global action on development.
- ECOSOC is one of the six principal organs of the United Nations, serving as the central forum for international economic, social and environmental policy coordination, consensus-building and follow-up to global development commitments.
- **Established in:** 1945 under the UN Charter
- **First meeting:** 23 January 1946, London

Key functions:

- **Policy coordination:** Guides and coordinates UN development system, including specialised agencies and programmes.
- **Global platform:** Facilitates debate, consensus and innovative thinking on development challenges.
- **SDG follow-up:** Reviews progress on SDGs via the HLPF.
- **Inclusive engagement:** Grants consultative status to 6,500+ NGOs, enabling civil society participation.
- **Institutional linkage:** Oversees functional commissions, regional commissions and expert bodies.
- **UN system governance:** Elects executive boards of agencies like UNICEF, UNDP and UNHCR.

Trump Announces new 'Board of Peace' to Lead Second Phase of Gaza Peace Plan

- US President Donald Trump has announced the members of a new Board of Peace **to lead the second phase of his 20-Point Peace Plan aimed at ending the Gaza conflict.**
- The board will oversee efforts on governance, regional cooperation, reconstruction, investment, funding, and long-term stability in Gaza.
- Trump will serve as Chairman of the Board of Peace.

**Pratas Islands**

- A Chinese reconnaissance drone briefly **flew over the Taiwan-controlled Pratas Islands at the top end of the South China Sea recently**, in what Taiwan's defence ministry called a "provocative and irresponsible" move.

About Pratas Islands

- The Pratas Islands, also known as the Dongsha Islands, are a small group of three islands located in the northern part of the South China Sea.
- These islands are characterized by a circular atoll structure, with Dongsha Island being the only island above sea level, while the other two are submerged.



- Once discovered during the ancient Han Dynasty, Dongsha Island became an important point along trade and fishing routes through the Taiwan Strait, which separates Taiwan from mainland China, and the Bashi Channel between Y'Ami Island of the Philippines and Orchid Island of Taiwan.
- They are strategically important positions along the major sea route connecting the Pacific and Indian ocean.

WEF Davos 2026 Begins With India in Spotlight

- The "World Economic Forum" Annual Meeting 2026 begins in Davos, Switzerland.
- Jan 19-23, 2026
- Held under the theme "A Spirit of Dialogue",
- The five-day summit aims to revive cooperation between governments, businesses, and institutions amid mounting global uncertainty.



Japan restarts world's biggest nuclear plant

- Japan has restarted a reactor at the world's largest nuclear plant nearly 15 years after a disaster at the Fukushima power plant forced the country to shut all its nuclear reactors.
- Reactor no.6 at the Kashiwazaki-Kariwa plant
- Kashiwazaki-Kariwa Nuclear Plant: It is the world's largest nuclear power plant by installed capacity, located near Tokyo.**
- Fukushima Nuclear Disaster (2011):** The 2011 earthquake and tsunami disabled the cooling systems at the nuclear plant, leading to core meltdowns in three reactors and large-scale radiation release, making it the worst nuclear accident since Chernobyl (1986).



UNESCO Media and Information Literacy (MIL) Alliance

- The UNESCO Media and Information Literacy Alliance has announced the election of its first-ever Global Board, marking a major milestone in its institutional governance.
- The MIL Alliance is a global collaborative network coordinated by UNESCO, bringing together organisations and experts to advance media and information literacy (MIL) and counter disinformation, misinformation, and hate speech.



Launched in:

- 2013, at the Global Forum for Partnerships on MIL in Abuja, Nigeria.
- Relaunched in 2025 during Global MIL Week with the Cartagena Declaration, alongside a renewed strategic action plan.

Organisation(s) involved:

- UNESCO (coordination through its MIL Unit).
- 300+ organisations and 180 individual experts from 100+ countries.

Muna Island

- The painted outline of a human hand inside a cave on the Indonesian island of Muna represents what researchers are calling the oldest example of rock art in the world, created at least 67,800 years ago.

About Muna Island

- It is situated in the Southeast Sulawesi province of Indonesia.
- With an area of 1,704 sq.km., it has a hilly surface, rising to 1,460 feet (445 metres). The north and northeast have teak forests.
- It is known for its diverse culture and natural beauty, including lush forests and pristine beaches.**
- The island is home to the Muna people, who have a rich cultural heritage and are known for their traditional crafts and dances.
- The economy of Muna Island is primarily based on agriculture, fishing, and local crafts.
- The main town and principal port is Raha, on the northeastern coast across the Strait of Buton from the neighbouring island of Buton to the east.**
- One of the most famous natural attractions on Muna Island is the Liangkobori Cave, which contains prehistoric paintings.
- Additionally, there is Napabale Lake, which has a natural tunnel connecting it directly to the sea.



Spain joined Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI)

- Spain has formally joined the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI), with its Foreign Minister handing over the Declaration of Accession to S. Jaishankar.
- The Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI) is a non-treaty, voluntary, cooperative framework for practical maritime collaboration among like-minded countries in the Indo-Pacific region.**
- Launched in:** 2019 (announced at the East Asia Summit, Bangkok).
- Launched by:** India, building on the SAGAR (Security and Growth for All in the Region) doctrine
- Key features:**

Seven thematic pillars:

- Maritime Security
- Maritime Ecology
- Maritime Resources
- Capacity Building & Resource Sharing
- Disaster Risk Reduction & Management
- Science, Technology & Academic Cooperation
- Trade, Connectivity & Maritime Transport

The 4B movement

- The 4B movement, a radical feminist current originating in South Korea, has resurfaced in public debate amid renewed discussions on patriarchy, gender violence, and women's autonomy.

The 4B movement is a feminist resistance framework where women refuse participation in four core institutions associated with patriarchy:

- No marriage
- No childbirth
- No dating
- No sex
- It represents a political and social rejection, not merely a lifestyle choice, of traditional heterosexual norms.
- Emerged in South Korea in the late 2010s.**
- Gained visibility through social media during South Korea's #MeToo movement.

**First National Coordinators Meeting in Beijing & SCO**

- The first meeting of the SCO Council of National Coordinators (CNC) for 2026 opened in Beijing, under the chairmanship of the Kyrgyz Republic, to finalize the agenda for high-level summits later this year.
- The Council of National Coordinators (CNC) is the primary coordination and management mechanism of the SCO.
- It serves as the vital link between the standing bodies of the organization and the member states.

About Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO):

- The Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) is a permanent intergovernmental international organization that has evolved into the world's largest regional body in terms of geographic scope and population.
- Headquarters (Secretariat): Beijing, China.
- Established In: June 15, 2001.
- Predecessor: The Shanghai Five (established in 1996).
- Official Languages: Russian and Chinese

News in short

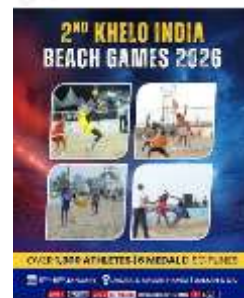
- ☐ **The Malaysian Communications and Multimedia Commission (MCMC) has temporarily blocked access to Grok, the AI chatbot developed by Elon Musk's xAI**
- ☐ **The United States has designated Muslim Brotherhood organisations in Egypt, Lebanon and Jordan as "terrorist" groups, as Washington intensifies its crackdown on Israel's rivals across the world.**

Sports

Khelo India games

2nd Khelo India Beach Games set to begin at Ghoghla Beach in Diu

- The second edition of the Khelo India Beach Games will be held in Diu from January 5 to 10, 2026.
- The event includes athletes from 25 States and six Union Territories.
- Competition is scheduled across six medal disciplines:** Beach Soccer, Beach Volleyball, Beach Sepaktakraw, Beach Kabaddi, Beach Pencak Silat and Open Water Swimming.
- Mallakhamb and Tug of War** will be conducted as non-competitive demonstration events.



Khelo India Beach Games concluded

- The Khelo India Beach Games 2026, held in the Union Territory of Diu, concluded with Karnataka emerging as the winners after clinching 11 medals - three gold, two silver and six bronze.
- With the top three states - Karnataka, Tamil Nadu and Manipur** - claiming three gold and two silver medals each, the overall standings of KIBG 2026 .
- Karnataka topped the standings with three gold, all from Open Water swimming, two silver and six bronze to win the overall crown in the second edition of KIBG.



KIBG 2026 medal table					
Rank	State/UT	Gold	Silver	Bronze	Total
1	Karnataka	3	2	6	11
2	Tamil Nadu	3	2	3	8
3	Manipur	3	2	2	7
4	Madhya Pradesh	3	1	1	5
5	Haryana	2	4	2	8

- Diu hosted all the sporting events in the Khelo India Beach Games 2026.
- The Khelo India Beach Games 2026 **logo** embodies the event's spirit, blending sports and Diu's coastal charm with vibrant colors, local elements, and bilingual typography, under the catchy slogan "Khel Ke Sitare, Diu Ke Kinare".
- Mallakhamb and tug of war were demonstration sports at KIBG 2026 and featured 336 athletes.**
- The **Mascot** - "Pearls – the Dolphin", embodies Diu's coastal spirit and marine heritage, symbolizing intelligence, energy, and sportsmanship.

Hockey

Chief coach Sjoerd Marijne appointed for Indian women's hockey team



Indian Women's Hockey End 2025 With Asia Cup Silver

- The Indian women's hockey team concluded 2025 with a silver medal at the Women's Asia Cup.
- Women's Asia Cup is a key continental hockey tournament.**
- In the final match, **India lost 1–4 to host China.**
- China topped the 2025 Women's Hockey Asia Cup.



ITBP win Ladakh Gorkha Cup Ice Hockey Championship after beating Ladakh Scouts in Kargil final

- In Ladakh, the 5th LG Cup Ice Hockey Championship concluded at the Biamathang Ice



Hockey Ground, Kargil.

- ITBP clinching the title after defeating the Ladakh Scouts team of the Indian Army .

NEWS IN SHORT

- The International Cricket Council (ICC) ejected Bangladesh from the Men's T20 World Cup 2026 after the team refused to travel to India, citing security concerns.

Cricket

Australian cricketer Usman Khawaja announces retirement

- Veteran Australia batter Usman Khawaja has announced he will retire from international cricket after the upcoming fifth Ashes test at the Sydney Cricket Ground.
- Usman Khawaja became the first Muslim and first Pakistani-born Australian player to play Test cricket for Australia.



Steve Smith pips Sachin Tendulkar with 37th Test century at SCG

- Steve Smith recorded his 37th Test century on Day 3 of the fifth Ashes Test at the Sydney Cricket Ground (SCG).
- In doing so he surpassed Sachin Tendulkar by reaching 37 Test hundreds in fewer innings — Smith achieved the mark in 219 innings, while Tendulkar had reached 37 centuries in 220 innings.
- This hundred was his 13th in Ashes Tests, allowing him to surpass England legend Jack Hobbs on the list of Ashes centuries; only Don Bradman's 19 Ashes hundreds remain ahead

131	ININGS	131
6720	RUNS	7227
56.95	AVG	62.04
25	TEST	26
5.24	100 ININGS	5.03

Indian fast bowler Mohammed Siraj has been named the captain of the Hyderabad Ranji Trophy team for the remainder of the season, while top-order bat G Rahul Singh has been named as his deputy.



Australia captain Alyssa Healy announces retirement from international cricket

- Alyssa Healy, a mainstay of Australia's dominant women's cricket team for 15 years and latterly its captain, has announced.
- Healy had already announced her retirement from T20 internationals.



Virat Kohli becomes fastest player to reach to 28,000 runs across formats.

- Virat Kohli reached 28,000 international runs in the first ODI vs New Zealand at Vadodara.
- He became the fastest to 28,000 runs, achieving it in 624 innings, ahead of Tendulkar (644) and Sangakkara (666).
- He is only the third batter to reach this milestone after Tendulkar and Sangakkara.



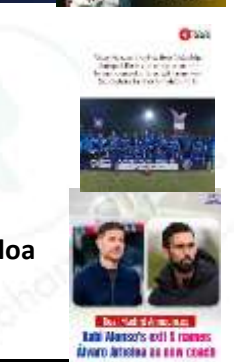
Mitchell Starc Named ICC Men's Player of the Month for December 2025

- The International Cricket Council (ICC) has named Australia's Mitchell Starc as the ICC Men's Player of the Month for December 2025.
- On the other hand, South Africa's Laura Wolvaardt has been named the ICC Women's Player of the Month.



Vidarbha Clinch Maiden Vijay Hazare Trophy Title

- Vidarbha clinched their maiden Vijay Hazare Trophy title in the 2025–26 season.
- Vidarbha defeated Saurashtra by 38 runs to secure the trophy.



Football

Real Madrid Football Club Announced that Xabi Alonso left his role as team coach and Álvaro Arbeloa as the new first-team coach.

FC Barcelona win their 16th Spanish Super Cup

- FC Barcelona secured their 16th Spanish Super Cup title after defeating Real Madrid 3–2 in the final held at the King Abdullah Sports City Stadium in Jeddah, Saudi Arabia.

**Senegal defeats Morocco to win Africa Cup**

- Senegal have won the 2025 Africa Cup of Nations title, beating hosts Morocco 1–0
- This victory secured Senegal's second AFCON (Africa Cup of Nations) title (their first was in 2021).
- The 2025 Africa Cup of Nations (AFCON) took place in Morocco from 21 December 2025 to 18 January 2026, with the final played on 18 January 2026.

**Amelia Valverde appointed as Indian senior women's football team coach**

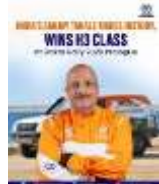
- The All India Football Federation (AIFF) announced the appointment of Costa Rica's Amelia Valverde as the head coach of the Indian senior women's team.
- Valverde was the longest-serving coach in the history of the Costa Rican women's national team, leading Las Ticas from 2015 to 2023.**

**Basketball****National Basketball Championship - Indian Railways reigns supreme with twin titles**

- It was double victory for the Indian Railways at the 75th senior National basketball championship at the Nehru Indoor Stadium .
- In the women's section, Railways defeated Kerala 75-66 to clinch its eighth consecutive crown and 41st overall.**
- In the men's category, Railways dethroned defending champion Tamil Nadu.

**F1 racing****India's Sanjay Takale makes history, wins H3 Class at Dakar Rally 2026 Prologue.**

- In a historic achievement for Indian motorsport, top driver Sanjay Takale delivered a standout performance in the Prologue Stage of the Dakar Rally 2026, finishing first in the high average speed Group H3 and 35th overall in the Cars category.

**Racer Atiqa Mir becomes first Indian to secure top five finish at IAME UAE Karting Championship**

- Atiqa Mir (11) became the first Indian and first female to finish top-five on debut.
- Achieved this in Round 7 of the IAME UAE Karting Championship at Yas Marina Circuit.
- She moved from Mini to Junior S125 category.

**Squash****British Junior Open Squash: Anahat Singh gets silver in Women's Under-19**

- In squash, the top-seeded Indian player, Anahat Singh, clinched the silver medal in the women's under-19 final **at the British Junior Open squash championships 2026.**

**Athletics****Amieyra Khoslla Wins Gold at National Climbing Championship**

- Fourteen-year-old climbing sensation Amieyra Khoslla clinched the gold medal in the Youth Girls (Under-17) category at the 29th National Sport Climbing Championship 2025
- The 29th edition of the championship was organised by the Indian Mountaineering Foundation in association with the General Thimayya National Academy of Adventure
- The championship was held in Bengaluru from December 26 to 29**

**Lovlina Borgohain, Nikhat Zareen Clinch Titles at National Boxing Championships**

- Lovlina Borgohain won the women's 75kg category.**
- Nikhat Zareen claimed the 52kg title at the National Boxing Championships 2026 in Noida
- This was the first time that the men's and women's National Championships were held simultaneously at the same venue.



National Boxing Championships 2026 winners**Women**

- Minakshi Hooda - 48kg
- Lovlina Borgohain - 75kg
- Pooja Rani - 80kg

Men

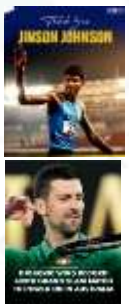
- Vishwanath Suresh - 50kg
- Jadumani Singh - 55kg
- Sumit Kundu - 75kg

Delhi CM Inaugurates National Junior Boys Handball Championship

- **Delhi** Chief Minister Rekha Gupta inaugurated the **47th** National Junior Boys Handball Championship at a government school in Pitampura, New Delhi.
- **The championship is being jointly organised by the Handball Federation of India and the Delhi Handball Association.**
- A cash prize of ₹1 lakh for the winning team.
- Under the revised policy, international medal winners are eligible for ₹7 crore for gold, ₹5 crore for silver, and ₹3 crore for bronze.

India's Asian Games Gold Medalist Runner Jinson Johnson announces Retirement

- National record-holder and Asian Games gold-winning Indian middle distance runner Jinson Johnson announced his retirement.
- **He went on to bag the bronze medal in 1500m at the 2023 Asian Games in Hangzhou.**
- Johnson also won the silver and bronze medals at the Asian Athletics Championships in 2015 and 2017, respectively.
- **Jinson Johnson holds the national record in 1500m.**

**Ranipet Schoolgirl Wins Gold at National Martial Arts Championship**

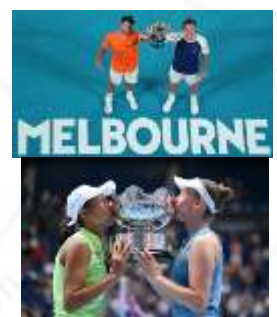
- A class 9 student, Roshini, of Vedavalli Vidyalaya, NPS Senior Secondary School in Ranipet, **has won the gold medal at the 29th All India National Championship 2026 for traditional martial arts held at Goa recently.**
- The event promotes traditional Indian martial arts such as silambam.

Tennis**Djokovic wins record 400th Slam match to power on in Australia**

- Novak Djokovic is the first tennis player to achieve 400 Grand Slam singles match wins.
- The Australian Open is one of the four Grand Slam tournaments, played on hard courts.
- Djokovic has won the Australian Open a record ten times.

Australian Open 2026: Mertens and Zhang, Harrison and Skupski win doubles title

- Australian Open men's doubles title : Neal Skupski and Christian Harrison - their first Grand Slam event as a team.
- Australian Open women's doubles : Elise Mertens and Zhang Shuai
- Australian Open mixed-doubles : John Peers and Olivia Gadecki



Grand Slam tournaments, also called majors, are the four most important annual tennis events.

The Grand Slam itinerary consists of :

- **The Australian Open in mid-January,**
- **The French Open in May - June,**
- **Wimbledon in June-July**
- **The US Open in August-September.**
- **The Australian and United States tournaments are played on hard courts, the French on clay, and Wimbledon on grass.**
- **Wimbledon is the oldest, founded in 1877, followed by the US in 1881, the French in 1891, and the Australian in 1905.**

**Miss****44th Junior National Kho Kho Championship Begins in Bengaluru**

- The 44th Junior National Kho Kho Championship started at the Atal Bihari Vajpayee Stadium in Gunjur, Bengaluru.
- **Championship offers young players a national platform to learn and grow, while KSKKA President Lokeshwara highlighted improved training and facilities for emerging talent.**
- Meanwhile, the 58th Senior National Kho Kho Championship will be held in Kazipet, Telangana, from 11th to 15th January and the 35th Sub-Junior Nationals in Kurukshetra, Haryana, from 31st January to 4th February.

India International Youth Sailing Championship 2026 to take place at Chennai Port

- The 11th India International Youth Sailing Championship 2026 will officially take place from 4th to 10th January at the Chennai Port. The Championship was launched in Chennai
- **This is India's longest-running and most consistent international youth sailing regatta.**



PPA Marks 65th Port Foundation Day with 21st Paradip Marathon

- Paradip Port Authority, Odisha observed its **65th Port Foundation Day with the successful conduct of the 21st Paradip Marathon 2026.**
- Paradip Port Authority, foundation stone was laid on 3 January 1962.
- It is **located in Odisha** and is a vital deep-water port on the East Coast of India, situated at the convergence of the Mahanadi River and the Bay of Bengal.



Veeyapuram Chundan wins Champions Boat League; Niranam Chundan clinches President's Trophy

- Veeyapuram Chundan, rowed by the Village Boat Club (VBC) from Kainakary, was crowned **fifth edition of the Champions Boat League (CBL) Season 5** champions.
- In the **President's Trophy**, held as the finale of the CBL season at Ashtamudi Lake in Kollam, Niranam Chundan (rowed by Niranam Boat Club) won the President's Trophy race.
- The Village Boat Club accepted the championship trophy and a cash prize of ₹25 lakh along with the CBL trophy.

National Paralympic Powerlifting Championship Inaugurated in Roorkee

- Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami inaugurated the National Paralympic Powerlifting Championship in Uttarakhand in January 2026.
- **Event:** The Championship was inaugurated virtually from COER University, Roorkee.
 - **Nature of sport:** Paralympic powerlifting.
- **Focus:** The championship highlights powerlifting as a sport of resilience, discipline, courage and self-confidence, especially for persons with disabilities.

Surat's Yash Rashiya Wins Gold at Roll Ball World Cup 2025

- Yash Anil Rashiya, a 20-year-old athlete from Surat, India, won the gold medal at the 7th Roll Ball World Cup 2025 held in Dubai.



(Miscellaneous)

Toddler Sets Two Guinness Records With Snooker Trick Shots

- A two-year-old boy from Manchester Jude Owens became the youngest person ever to successfully execute two different trick shots in snooker.
- He set the record for the youngest player to make a bank shot in pool.
- He had already created history by becoming the youngest to double pot a snooker shot.



Important Facts for Exams

- Snooker is played on a larger table than pool with smaller balls.
- A double pot means two balls are pocketed in a single stroke.
- A bank shot involves the ball rebounding off a cushion before potting.

Team India secured the third prize (Bronze Medal) at the 35th Breckenridge International snow sculpture championships in Breckenridge, Colorado, USA.

In the 2026 results:

Gold Medal: Team Republic of Korea

Silver Medal: Team Mongolia

Bronze Medal: Team India

Index

India becomes world's largest rice producer

- Union Agriculture Minister said India has become the world's largest rice producer, with output at 150.18 million tonnes, overtaking China at 145.28 million tonnes.
- India has overtaken China to become the No. 1 rice-producing country globally**, as per the minister's statement (2024–25 output: 150.18 MT).



State-wise ranking:

As per Economic Survey (Statistical Appendix) for 2023–24, the three largest rice-producing states were:

- Telangana** – 16.63 MT ($\approx$ 12.17% share)
- Uttar Pradesh** – 15.72 MT ($\approx$ 11.50% share)

Geographical features of rice production in India:

- Climate belt:** Rice thrives in hot, humid conditions—hence concentration in eastern, southern, and north-eastern India.
- Water geography:** Strong presence in river deltas and floodplains (Ganga–Brahmaputra plains; Krishna–Godavari–Cauvery deltas) where water availability and alluvium support paddy.
- Irrigation-driven expansion:** In lower rainfall zones, rice is sustained via canals/tube-wells, enabling high yields but raising water-stress concerns.
- Terrain adaptation:** In hilly regions, rice is grown via terraced cultivation with controlled water flow.



Dynamic Ground Water Resource Assessment Report, 2024

- Released by Ministry of Jal Shakti; shows net improvement over 2017.**
- Recharge: 446.90 BCM (long-term rise via rainwater harvesting).
- Over-exploited units: 11.13% ($\downarrow$ from 17.24% in 2017).**
- Conservation impact:** Recharge from tanks/ponds/structures 25.34 BCM (nearly doubled).
- Stress pockets:** Punjab, Haryana, Delhi, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Telangana, Gujarat.

Initiatives taken to counter depletion:

- National Aquifer Mapping Programme (NAQUIM & NAQUIM 2.0):** Scientific mapping and aquifer-level management planning.
- Atal Bhujal Yojana (ATAL JAL):** Community-led demand-side management in water-stressed blocks.
- Master Plan for Artificial Recharge (2020):** Proposal for 42 crore structures to harness 185 BCM of monsoon rainfall.
- Jal Shakti Abhiyan** – Catch the Rain: Nationwide focus on rainwater harvesting and water conservation.
- PMKSY** – Groundwater component: Promotes efficient irrigation and conjunctive water use in Safe



WHO Pharmacovigilance

- Union Health Minister announced that India has risen to 8th position globally in contributions to the WHO pharmacovigilance database, from 123rd a decade ago.
- WHO pharmacovigilance refers to the global system** for monitoring, detecting, assessing, and preventing adverse effects of medicines and vaccines, coordinated through international data-sharing mechanisms.
- Aim:** Ensure patient safety by early identification of medicine- and vaccine-related risks.
- Strengthen regulatory decision-making through real-world safety data.



The UN's World Economic Situation and Prospects Report 2026

- The global economy is forecast to grow by 2.7 per cent in 2026, slightly below the 2.8 per cent estimated for 2025, **40 bps faster than previously anticipated, according to the World Economic Situation and Prospects 2026, released by the United Nations**
- The report is prepared by the UN's Department of Economic and Social Affairs (DESA) in partnership with the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD) and the five United Nations regional commissions.

Key Takeaways:

- Global military expenditure rose to \$2.7 trillion in 2024, marking the steepest annual increase since at least 1988.
- This surge may divert funds from long-term investments in human capital, infrastructure, and development cooperation with vulnerable economies.**
- Global growth is expected to edge up to 2.9% in 2027.
- The UN upgraded India's growth forecast for 2026 by 20 bps to 6.6%, with growth rising slightly to 6.7% in 2027.

**Bengaluru Tops 2025 Ranking as Best Indian City for Women**

- Bengaluru has emerged as the best city for women in India, topping the Top Cities for Women in India 2025 report.
- Released by Avtar Group, which assessed 125 cities across the country on parameters linked to women's inclusion, safety, employment and quality of life.
- Bengaluru secured the first rank with a City Inclusion Score (CIS) of 53.29.
- Chennai ranked second with a score of 49.86.

Uttarakhand Police Tops ICJS 2.0 Rankings, SDRF Lauded for Mahakumbh Role**ICJS (Inter-Operable Criminal Justice System) 2.0 national ranking**

- In the latest ICJS 2.0 ranking, Uttarakhand ranked first with 93.46, followed by Haryana at 93.41 and Assam at 93.16.
- Two major achievements of the Uttarakhand Police**--securing first position in the ICJS (Inter-Operable Criminal Justice System) 2.0 national ranking and the exemplary performance of the Uttarakhand State Disaster Response Force (SDRF) during Prayagraj Mahakumbh-2025.

**The 2026 Henley Passport Index**

- The Henley Passport Index is the world's most trusted ranking of global mobility.
- It measures how many destinations passport holders can visit without needing a prior visa.**
- At the **very top is Singapore**, holding the No. 1 spot. Singaporeans can travel to 192 countries and territories without needing a visa.
- Right behind are Japan and South Korea, which are tied at No. 2, with access to 188 destinations.
- Denmark, Luxembourg, Spain, Sweden, and Switzerland all share No. 3.

**India's passport strength**

- In 2026, it ranks 80th, moving up five spots from last year. Indian citizens can now travel to 55 countries without a visa.

The weakest passports: At the bottom of the index:

- No. 101: Afghanistan**, visa-free access to just 24 destinations
- No. 100: Syria (26 destinations)
- No. 99: Iraq (29 destinations)

Rank	Country	Visa-Free Destinations
1st	Singapore	192
2nd	Japan, South Korea	188
3rd	Denmark, Luxembourg, Spain, Sweden, Switzerland	186
4th	Austria, Belgium, Finland, France, Germany, Greece, Ireland, Italy, Netherlands, Norway	185
5th	Hungary, Portugal, Slovakia, Slovenia, UAE	184
6th	Croatia, Czechia, Estonia, Malta, New Zealand, Poland	183
101st	Afghanistan	24

100th	Syria	26
99th	Iraq	29
98th	Pakistan, Yemen	31
97th	Somalia	33
96th	Nepal	35

NITI Aayog Releases Export Preparedness Index (EPI) 2024

- **NITI Aayog released the Export Preparedness Index (EPI) 2024**, a comprehensive assessment of export readiness across India's States and Union Territories (UTs).
- The Index acknowledges the diversity of subnational economic structures and their critical role in advancing India's global trade ambitions.
- **First published in August 2020, the latest edition marks the fourth iteration of the Index.**
- Aligned with India's goal of achieving USD 1 trillion in merchandise exports by 2030 and the vision of Viksit Bharat @2047
- **NITI Aayog released the Export Preparedness Index (EPI) 2024**, a comprehensive assessment of export readiness across India's States and Union Territories (UTs).
- The Index acknowledges the diversity of subnational economic structures and their critical role in advancing India's global trade ambitions.
- **First published in August 2020, the latest edition marks the fourth iteration of the Index.**
- Aligned with India's goal of achieving USD 1 trillion in merchandise exports by 2030 and the vision of Viksit Bharat @2047

The Global Risks Report 2026

- The **World Economic Forum's Global Risks Report 2026** has ranked **geoeconomic confrontation as the world's top short-term risk, overtaking armed conflict, reflecting rising trade wars, sanctions, and weaponization of economic tools.**
- The Global Risks Report 2026 is the **21st annual assessment published by the World Economic Forum**, drawing on the Global Risks Perception Survey (GRPS) of leaders from government, business, academia, civil society and international organisations.
- It evaluates 33 global risks across 2-year (short-term) and 10-year (long-term) time horizons.



Key findings of the report:

- Geo-economic confrontation ranks 1st in the 2-year horizon, defined by the strategic use of trade, tariffs, sanctions, investment restrictions, and resource controls.
- Extreme weather events drop from 2nd (2025 report) to 4th in the short-term risk ranking.

National Legislative Index (NLI)

- The 86th All India Presiding Officers Conference, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla announced the initiation of a National Legislative Index (NLI) to objectively assess and compare the performance of legislatures.
- The **National Legislative Index is a proposed performance-evaluation framework to objectively measure and compare the functioning of Parliament and State Legislatures using predefined indicators.**



Aim:

- To promote healthy competition among legislatures.
- To enhance efficiency, accountability, and quality of legislative deliberation.
- To make legislatures more people-centric and outcome-oriented.

Key features:

- **Objective performance metrics:** Assesses legislatures on measurable parameters such as number of sittings, legislative output, committee work, and utilisation of House time, reducing subjective political judgement.
- **Comparative and competitive framework:** Enables comparison across Parliament and State Legislatures to foster healthy competition and best-practice sharing.

- **Accountability & transparency focus:** Encourages discipline, quality debate, and citizen-centric law making by linking performance with public scrutiny.

India Launches Responsible Nations Index (RNI)

- India has launched the Responsible Nations Index (RNI) 2026 to introduce a new global benchmark for evaluating countries on ethical governance and responsibility, with India ranked 16th globally.
- The Responsible Nations Index (RNI) is a global composite index designed to assess countries based on ethical governance, social well-being, environmental stewardship, and global responsibility, moving beyond traditional power- and GDP-centric metrics.
- Launched by: Under the aegis of the World Intellectual Foundation (WIF).



Aim:

- To redefine national success by embedding ethical responsibility, inclusiveness, sustainability, and global cooperation into the assessment of nationhood.

Assessment criteria:

The RNI evaluates nations across four broad pillars:

- Ethical governance
- Social well-being and inclusiveness
- Environmental responsibility and sustainability
- Global responsibility and cooperative international conduct

Key features:

- Responsibility-centric framework, not power-centric.
- Integrates governance, moral values, and humanitarian outcomes.
- Encourages policy introspection and ethical benchmarking among nations.
- Designed as a dialogue-driven index, fostering global cooperation rather than competition.
- Accompanied by an annual Responsible Nations Index Report.

Rankings (RNI 2026):

- **Top 5 countries:**
 - Singapore – Rank 1
 - Switzerland – Rank 2
 - Denmark – Rank 3
 - Cyprus – Rank 4
 - Sweden – Rank 5
- India: Rank 16 (Overall Score: 0.5515) and Central African Republic – Overall Score: 0.35715, Rank: 154 (Last).
- India is the top-ranked Asian nation.
- India ranks 16th globally, ahead of South Korea (21), Thailand (24) and Kyrgyzstan (22).
- 9 of the top 10 countries are European, underscoring [Europe's strength](#) in institutional ethics.

The Numbeo Global Safety Index

- In January 2026, according to Numbeo Safety Index 2026 rankings by Numbeo, a crowd-sourced global database, Mangaluru (Karnataka) emerged as the safest city in India.
- **Released by:** Numbeo
- **Total Cities Covered:** 304
- **Top 3 Safest City (Globally):** Qingdao, Shandong (China) (Score: 89.2); Abu Dhabi(UAE)(88.9); Doha(Qatar)(84.5)
- **Top 3 Safest City in India:** Mangaluru (Karnataka) (Rank 46; Score: 74.4); Ahmedabad(Gujarat)(Rank 87, 68.5); Jaipur(Rajasthan)(Rank 106, 65.3).
- **Unsafe Cities in India:** New Delhi(Delhi) was ranked the least safe city in India, placing 255th globally with a score of 40.9, followed by Noida (Uttar Pradesh, UP) at 234th (44.9) and Gurgaon (Haryana) at 229th(45.9).
- **Top 3 Safest Countries:** UAE – 86.0; Qatar – 84.8; Andorra – 84.8
- India ranked 70th globally among countries, with an overall safety.



About Numbeo:

- Chief Executive Officer (CEO) – Mladen Adamovic

- **Headquarters** – Belgrade, Serbia
- **Established** – 2009

IISc Bangalore only Indian institute to feature in global top 100: THE Subject Rankings 2026

- Indian institutions make a limited mark in the Times Higher Education (THE) World University Rankings by Subject 2026.
- **IISc Bangalore is the only Indian institute to rank under 100 in the Computer Science subject category**, followed by Amity University at the 251-300 slot, Jamia Millia Islamia at the 301-400 belt.
- The THE World University Rankings by Subject 2026 use the same 18 indicators as the overall world rankings, recalibrated for each discipline



Institution	Country/Territory	Rank 2026	Rank 2025
Harvard University	United States	1	1
University of Oxford	United Kingdom	2	4
Massachusetts Institute of Technology	United States	=3	3
Stanford University	United States	=3	2
University of Cambridge	United Kingdom	5	6
University of California, Berkeley	United States	6	5
California Institute of Technology	United States	7	7
Peking University	China	8	11
Princeton University	United States	9	8
National University of Singapore	Singapore	10	9

India Ranks Sixth in Asia Manufacturing Index 2026

- India has ranked sixth among 11 Asian economies in the Asia Manufacturing Index (AMI) 2026.
- Asia Manufacturing Index is released by Dezan Shira & Associates
- Headquartered in Hong Kong
- **China** : Retained the top spot for the third consecutive year due to its unmatched industrial scale and supply chains.
- **This index uses a structured framework to assess the manufacturing competitiveness of large Asian economies.**
- It ranks countries on the basis of eight major pillars: economy, political risk, business environment, international trade, tax policy, infrastructure, workforce and innovation.

Global Water Bankruptcy Report

- The United Nations University Institute for Water, Environment and Health (UNU-INWEH) released a flagship report titled “Global Water Bankruptcy: Living Beyond Our Hydrological Means in the Post-Crisis Era”.
- **It describes a persistent post-crisis failure state where long-term water use exceeds renewable inflows and safe depletion limits**, causing irreversible damage to natural capital.
- It highlights that “water stress” (pressure) and “water crisis” (temporary shock) are no longer adequate terms because the previous “normal” baselines have effectively collapsed in many regions.



Data and Facts Water Bankruptcy:

- **Massive Scale**: Nearly 75% of the world’s population lives in countries classified as water-insecure or critically water-insecure as of 2026.
- **Agricultural Stress**: Roughly 70% of global freshwater is used for agriculture; over 170 million hectares of irrigated cropland are under high or very high water stress.
- **Groundwater Depletion**: Around 70% of the world’s major aquifers show long-term declining trends, with some areas sinking by up to 25 cm per year due to land subsidence.
- **Wetland Liquidation**: The world has lost roughly 410 million hectares of natural wetlands in the last five decades—an area almost the size of the European Union.

Top 10 countries on Global Soft Power Index 2026: US leads the chart as China narrows the gap

- The Brand Finance Global Soft Power Index 2026 — ranking 193 UN member states across 55 metrics — published
- The United States retained the top position with a score of 74.9 out of 100, despite being the only country to witness the sharpest decline, by 4.6 points
- China ranks second
- Japan ranks third
- The UK ranked fourth

**Where does India rank on the Global Soft Power Index 2026?**

- India ranks 32nd with a score of 48.0, slipping two positions and declining 1.8 points from last year.

**QS Europe Rankings 2026: Oxford Leads, Top Universities Listed**

- The QS World University Rankings Europe 2026 have been released.

Compiled by Quacquarelli Symonds (QS),

- The **University of Oxford** has secured the first position
- ETH Zurich followed closely at second place,
- Seven of the top 10 are UK universities.

